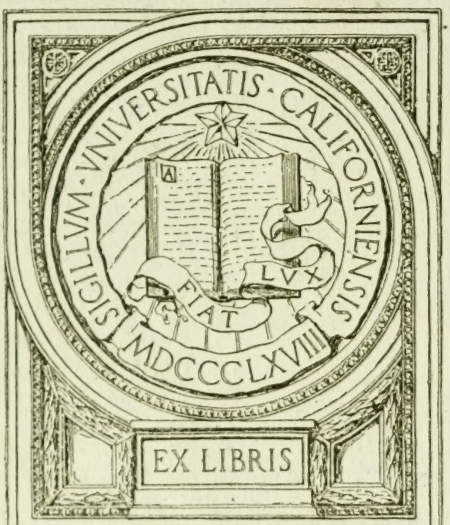
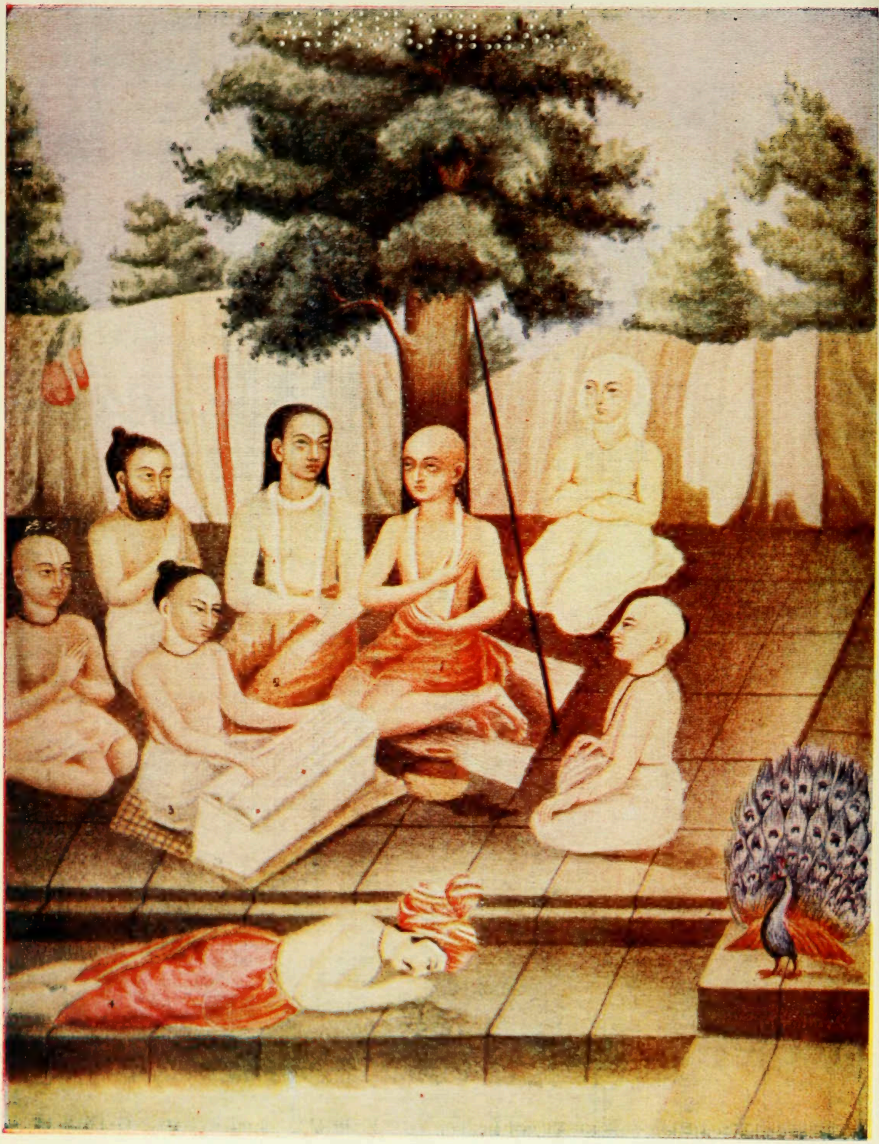
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Chaitanya Deva listening to the Bhagabata. This picture was painted between 1512 and 1533 A. D. during the life-time of Chaitanya by order of Raja Pratapa Rudra of Puri. It is said to have been carried to Nadia by Crinivasa one of the disciples. From his descendants, it passed to the family of Raja Nanda Kumar of East India Company fame, and by them is preserved at their country-seat of Kunjaghata near Murshidabad. The figures are as follows:—(1) Chaitanya Deva (2) Nityananda on his right (3) Bhagabata Acharyya (4) the Raja Protapa Rudra patron of the artist, in the attitude of devotion. The peacock in line with the Raja is perhaps heraldic to show his rank.

# HISTORY

OF

# Bengali Language and Literature.

## A series of lectures delivered as Reader to the Calcutta University,

BY


## DINESH CHANDRA SEN, B.A.

*Fellow of the Calcutta University, Associate Member of the Asiatic Society of Bengal, Honorary Member of the Indian Research Society, Author of Banga Bhasa-O-Sahitya and other Bengali works, &c., &c., &c.*


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"This language, current through an extent of country nearly equal to Great Britain, when properly cultivated, will be inferior to none in elegance and perspicuity."

**William Carey.**

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**F. H. Skrine.**

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CALCUTTA.

Published by the University.

1911.

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CALCUTTA:
Printed by—D. C. KERR, at the "VALMIKI PRESS,"
11, Haldar Lane, *Bowbazar*.

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C.S.I., M.A., D.L., D.Sc., F.R.A.S., F.R.S.E.,

VICE-CHANCELLOR OF THE CALCUTTA UNIVERSITY

Whose sound and far-sighted educational measures in furthering the cause of our beautiful language will be ever gratefully remembered by his countrymen.

THESE PAGES

*ARE INSCRIBED*

IN TOKEN OF THE AUTHOR'S GRATITUDE AND ESTEEM.

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# PREFACE.

This work consists of the lectures delivered by me as Reader in Bengali Language and Literature to the Calcutta University during the months of January to April 1909, at the Senate House, Calcutta. They treat of our language and literature from the earliest times down to 1850.

The volume now presented to the public has very little affinity with my Bengali work on the same subject, for which I was granted a literary pension by the Right Honorable the Secretary of State for India in 1899. There must, of course, be something in common between the two books, dealing as they do with the same subject, but the arrangement adopted in the present work is altogether new, and the latest facts, not anticipated in my Bengali treatise, have been incorporated in it.

It should be borne in mind that our early Bengali literature had the strange characteristic of forming a gift from the lower to the higher classes. The more cultured ranks of our society under Hindoo rule delighted in the study of classical Sanskrit; during the Mahomedan period, Arabic and Persian were added to this; and the vernacular literature deemed it always a great honour and privilege if it could only now and then obtain an approving nod from the aristocracy. This perhaps accounts for the somewhat vulgar humour that characterises old Bengali writing. But inspite of occasional coarseness a depth of poetry throbbed in the heart of the multitude. I refer my readers particularly to the Mañgala Gāns, to the works of the Manasā and Chandī-cults, and to the Yātrā and Kavi songs. For the great Vaiṣṇava period of our literature, on the other hand, no apology is necessary. In this our people attained the very flowering point of the literary sense. I do not know how far I

have been successful in conveying, even in a small degree, the great beauty of this department of our literature.

With regard to the short chapter on pre-Mahomedan literature, which is chiefly Buddhistic, I regret to say that I was not allowed access to the materials collected by Mahāmahopādhyāya Haraprasad Shāstri in Nepal. The chief interest of this period is, however, linguistic and philological. When Mahāmahopādhyāya Shāstri publishes an account of his researches in that field, the world will, I feel sure, learn many things that are not found in this book.

It is stated on page 89 that Nula Panchānana, the great authority on genealogical questions, lived a hundred and fifty years ago. This is not correct. I have lately discovered that he must have lived about three hundred years ago, since in his family the present is the tenth genaration in descent from him.

On page 950 again, I have referred to the gentleman known as Hindu Stuart. The following additional particulars, taken from a book entitled "The story of the Lal Bazar Baptist Church" by Edward J. Wenger p. 508) may be of interest in connection with his tomb in the South Park Street cemetery.—"This tomb is that of Major General Charles Stuart, who died on the 31st March 1828, aged 70 years. He is generally known as Hindu Stuart, because it is traditionally stated, that he became a Hindu and had his residence in Wood Street, Calcutta, full of idols. It is stated that Government refused to allow him to be cremated as a Hindu because of his position as a general officer of the British army, so gave him a burial in this cemetery, but allowed his tomb to be constructed in the shape of a Hindu temple with emblems of idolatry all about its exterior. In itself it is a very curious-looking structure.....Our interest in it lies more in the fact that he was one of the bitterest opponents of the missionaries in his day."

Ever since 1897 when my Bengali work on the History of Bengali Language and Literature first saw the light, I have been suffering from severe nervous ailments. I have never since been fit for the strain of steady and continuous work. I had to work on the lectures that are contained in this book under severe and trying conditions. Twice during the progress of the book through the press, my condition created grave anxiety. In this state of health, I had to revise all the proofs myself, often including the first readings. I am not at all an expert proof-reader. This will account, though it may not be a sufficient excuse, for the many errors that will be found in the following pages. But the indulgent reader may find in the book, in spite of all its defects, the results of lifelong devotion. There are many things in it which will, I am afraid, be of little interest to the European reader, but it has been my endeavour to make the work of some use to every scholar whose curiosity and interest may be roused in regard to the subject. So I have taken care not to omit any point, however trivial it may appear at first sight.

My esteemed friends Babu Kumud Bandhu Basu and Mr. C. S. Paterson of the Young Men's Christian Association, Calcutta, have very kindly looked through the pages of this book. I take this opportunity of conveying my grateful thanks to them. To another European friend also, whose name I am not permitted to mention, I am much indebted. As I still, however, had to make considerable additions and alterations even after these revisions, I alone am responsible for the many defects of the work.

During the long years of my research in the field of old Bengali Literature, I have had the esteemed patronage and help of many European and Indian gentlemen, foremost among whom I may mention the names of Dr. G. A. Grierson, C. I. E., Mr. F. H. Skrine, Mr. W. C. Macpherson, C. S. I., the Hon'ble Mr. R. T. Greer, C. S. I.,

Mr. B. C. Mitra, Mr. K. C. De, (I. C. S.), Mr. G. N. Tagore of Calcutta, their Highnesses the Maharajas of Mayurbhanja and Tippera, and the Hon'ble Maharaja of Cossimbazar. In the early years of my research I had obtained considerable help from Mahamahopādhyāya Hara Prasad Shāstri. To these and to all others who have helped me in times of need, my heart goes forth in great esteem and gratitude. I am indebted to my friend Mr. Nagendra Nath Vasu for allowing me the use of his valuable library of old Bengali manuscripts and helping me with suggestions, and also to Mr. Abanindra Nath Tagore for lending me some of the panels with old paintings, which have been reproduced in this book.

Before I conclude, I owe it to myself to offer my special thanks to that great friend and patron of Bengali literature, the Hon'ble Mr. Justice Asutosh Mookerjee, Vice-Chancellor of the Calcutta University, to whose ardent sympathy and unwearied efforts our language owes its present firm footing in this University. It is to his constant encouragement that these lectures owe their origin and completion. If I have been able even in a small measure to prove myself worthy of his distinguished patronage, I shall consider my labours amply rewarded. In the Convocation address delivered by him on the 13th March, 1909, he made the following kind and appreciative reference to my lectures. "We have had a long series of luminous lectures from one of our own graduates Babu Dinesh Chandra Sen, on the fascinating subject of the history of the Bengali Language and Literature. These lectures take a comprehensive view of the development of our vernacular, and their publication will unquestionably facilitate the historical investigation of the origin of the vernacular literature of this country, the study of which is avowedly one of the foremost objects of the new Regulations to promote."

19, Kanta Puker Lane,
*Bagbazar, Calcutta.*

DINESH CHANDRA SEN.

# HISTORY

OF THE

# Bengali Language & Literature.

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# HISTORY

OF

# Bengali Language & Literature.

## CHAPTER I.

### Early Influences on the Bengali Language.

**Aryan Settlement in Bengal.**

Bengal was a very ancient centre of Aryan settlement in India. The pre-historic kingdom of Pragjyotiṣ, which extended from modern Jalpaiguri to the back-woods of Assam, was one of the earliest Aryan colonies in this country. 'Vanga' is mentioned in the Aitereya Āraṅyaka* and frequent references to this land are found in the great epics—the Rāmāyaṅa and the Mahābhārata. According to Manu, Bengal formed a part of the Aryyāvarta.† The two great heroes of the Dwāpara yuga, who are said to have been the sworn enemies of Çri Kriṣṅa—the great upholder of Brahmanic power, were (1) Jarāsandha, the King of Magadha and (2) Pouṅdraka Vāsu Deva,‡ the King of Pāṅduā in Bengal, and both of them led expeditions to Dwaraka to subvert the power of Kriṣṅa.

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* **Aitereya Āraṅyaka** 2.1.1.

† আসমুদ্রাত্তু বৈ পূর্ব্বাদাসমুদ্রাত্তু পশ্চিমাৎ।
তয়োরেবান্তরং গির্য্যোর্যাবর্ত্তং বিদুর্বুধাঃ ॥—Manu.

‡ See **Hari Vaṁça,** Bhavisya Parva, Chap. 19.

**Buddhistic and Jain influences.**

This land has, from very early times, been the cradle of popular movements in religion. The Buddhists and the Jains, at one time, converted nearly the whole population of Bengal to their new creeds, and the Brahmanic influence was for centuries at a very low ebb here. Some of the greatest Buddhist scholars and reformers of India were born in Bengal, among whom the names of Atiça Dīpankara (born, 980 A.D.) and Çila-Bhadra are known throughout the Buddhistic world. Çanta Rakṣit, the renowned High Priest of the monastery of Nālandā—a native of Gauḍa, spent many years of his life in Tibet on a religious mission, and an illustrious band of Bengalis, within the first few centuries of the Christian era, travelled to China, Corea and Japan, carrying there the light of the Buddhist religion. The scriptures of the Japanese priests are still written in Bengali characters of the 11th century,* which indicates the once-great ascendency of the enterprising Bengali priests in the Land of the Rising Sun. The marvellous sculptural design of the Boro Buddor temple of Java owed its execution, in no inconsiderable degree, to Bengali artists, who worked side by side with the people of Kalinga and Guzrat, to whom that island was indebted for its ancient civilization. In the vast panorama of bas-reliefs in that temple, we find numerous representations of ships which the people of lower Bengal built, and which carried them to Ceylon, Java, Sumatra, Japan and China,—countries visited by them for the purpose of promulgating

* In the Horiuzi temple of Japan, the manuscript of a Buddhistic work entitled **Usñīsa Vijay Dhārinī,** has lately been found. The priests of the temple worship the manuscript, a fac-simile of which is now in the possession of the Oxford university. It is written in a character, which we consider to be identical with that prevalent in Bengal in the 6th century. Vide Anecdota Oxiniensis, Vol. III.

the Buddhistic faith and conducting commercial transactions. The well-known story of how prince Vijay Siṁha, son of King Siṁhabāhu of Bengal, migrated to Ceylon with seven hundred followers and established his kingdom there in 543 B.C. is narrated in Mahāvaṁça and other Buddhist works. Buddhism flourished in Ceylon under the patronage of the kings of the Siṁha dynasty—and the island is called 'Siṁhal' after them. The Ceylonese era dates from the commencement of the reign of Vijay Siṁha. The citizens of Champā in Bengal had already, in a still earlier epoch of history, founded a colony in Cochin China and named it after that famous old town.* About the middle of the ninth century, Dhīmān and his son Bit Pālo, inhabitants of Vārendra (North Bengal), founded new schools of painting, sculpture and works in cast metal, which stamped their influence on works of art in Nepal, from whence the art of the Bengali masters spread to China and other Buddhistic countries.†

In Bengal new ideas in religion have ever found a fit soil to grow upon, and it is interesting to observe, that out of the twenty-four Tīrthankaras (divine men) of the Jains, twenty-three attained Mokṣa (salvation) in Bengal. The place of their religious activity was Samet-çekhara or the Pārçvanāth hills

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* See Buddhist India, by Rhys Davids, p. 35.

† Vide Indian Antiquary Vol. IV. p. 101, and also Indian Painting and Sculpture by E. B. Havell p. 79. On page 19 of this work, Mr. Havell writes:—"From the sea-ports of her Western and Eastern coasts, India sent streams of colonists, missioneries and craftsmen all over Southern Asia, Ceylon, Syam and far distant Cambodia. Through China and Japan, Indian art entered Japan about the middle of the sixth Century" The Eastern sea-ports, here referred to, were probably Tamluk, Chittagong and those on the Orissa Coast."

in the district of Hāzāribāgh and many of the Tīrthankaras, such for instance as Çreaṁgçunāth and Vāsupujya, were born in Bengal.* The greatest of the Jaina Tīrthankaras—Mahavira spent eighteen years of his life preaching his faith in Rāḍa Deça (Western Bengal).

**Bengal interdicted by Manu.**

The country was for centuries in open revolt against Hindu orthodoxy. Buddhistic and Jain influences here were so great, that the codes of Manu, while including Bengal within the geographical boundary of Aryyāvarta, distinctly prohibit all contact of the Hindus with this land, for fear of contamination.† Ānanda Tīrtha, the famous commentator of Aitereya Āraṅyaka, declares Bengal to be inhabited by Rākṣasas and Piçāchas. In fact it is probable, that Bengal was mostly peopled by the descendants of the early citizens of Magadah,‡ hence Brahmanism could not thrive for many centuries amidst a people, who were the pioneers of Buddhism.

**Bengali, a form of Paiçachi Prakrita.**

The Buddhist priests had already, in the latter part of the tenth century, begun to write books in Prākrita called the Gouḍa Prākrita. This Prākrita was called by the grammarian Kriṣṇa Pandit, who flourished in the twelfth century, as a form of Paiçāchī Prākrita or a Prākrita spoken by the evil spirits. The rules specified by him, in his celebrated grammar Prākrita-Chandrikā, as peculiar to our

* Vide **Jainamālā** or a chronological table of the **Tīrthankaras** quoted in the Bengali Encyclopædia, **Viçvakosa** Vol. VII. p. 168.

† "অঙ্গ বঙ্গ কলিঙ্গেষু সৌরাষ্ট্র মগধেষু চ।
তীর্থযাত্রাং বিনা গচ্ছন্ পুনঃ সংস্কার মর্হতি।"—Manu.

‡ Vide Indian Pundits in the Land of Snow, by Sarat Chandra Das, p 21.

dialect, apply to it up to this day. According to him র and ণ change into ল and ন, and য় is pronounced as জ in this form of Prākrita, and of শ, ষ, স, one form only is found in current use. These are, generally speaking, the characteristic features of spoken Bengali up to this day and our old manuscripts are full of examples of them. The reasons which made Krishna Pandit give our language the contemptuous name of Paiçāchī Prākrita, are not far to seek. It is the same that made Manu*condemn all touch with this land. The dialect of the Buddhist people, in which the Buddhist priests were writing books, could not be accepted by the Sanskritic school which arose with the revival of Hinduism.

**Earliest Bengali works by the Buddhists.**

Several works written in the tenth and the eleventh centuries of the Christian era in a very old form of Bengali, have lately been discovered by Mahāmahopādhyāya Hara Prasāda Çāstrī in Nepal. These are (1) Charyyācharyya Viniçchaya, (2) Bodhicharyyāvatāra and (3) Dākārṅava. The manuscript of Budhicharyyāvatār is incomplete. They appear to be but poor fragments of a literature which owed its origin chiefly to the earnestness of the Tāntrika Buddhists for popularizing their creed. Though these specimens have how been nearly all lost, we hope some portion of them may be yet recovered by careful research carried into the literary archives of Nepal and Chittagong, —the present resorts of Buddhism in Eastern India.

**Revival of Hinduism.**

This effort on the part of the Buddhists to raise Bengali to the status of a written language, how-

*Manu lived in a prehistoric age, but as the laws of that sage are no longer to be found in the form in which they originally existed, our remarks apply to their modified version given in the **Bhrigu samhitā** which belongs to a much later period.

ever, came suddenly to a standstill on the revival of Hinduism in Bengal. Buddhist works were carried by the vanquished exponents of that faith to Nepal and Burma; and all traces of the creed, which was once ascendant in the country, were obliterated there. Whatever may be urged in favour of the theory of "the gradual, almost insensible, assimilation of Buddhism to Hinduism" there can be no doubt that Buddhism was often suppressed in India by a storm of Brahmanic persecution. The following extract from Çankara-Vijaya regarding King Sudhanvā will show the ruthless manner in which the Buddhists were sometimes persecuted :—

"দুষ্টমতাবলম্বিনঃ বৌদ্ধান্ জৈনানসংখ্যাতান্ রাজমুখ্যান-নেকবিদ্যাপ্রসঙ্গৈর্নির্জিত্য তেষাং শীর্ষাণি পরশুভিশ্ছিত্বা বহুষু উদূখলেষু নিক্ষিপ্য কটভ্রমর্ণৈশ্চূর্ণীকৃত্য চৈবং দুষ্টমতধ্বংসমাচরন্ নির্ভয়ো বর্ত্ততে।"

"Many of the chief princes, professing the wicked doctrines of the Buddhist and the Jain religions, were vanquished in various scholarly controversies. Their heads were then cut off with axes, thrown into mortars, and broken to pieces (reduced to powder) by means of pestles. So these wicked doctrines were thoroughly annihilated, and the country made free from danger."

**Progress of the Vernacular retarded.**

With the decadence of the power of the Buddhist priests, who in their zeal to popularize their creed, had not considered the Vernacular of Bengal as an unworthy medium for propagating their religious views, Bengali lost the patronage which it had secured of the lettered men of the country; and its future seemed dismal and uncheerful. We have shewn that the form of Prākrita prevalent in Bengal was in disfavour with the Sanskritic school which gave it a contemptuous epithet. Sanskrit scholars,

who brought about a revival of Hinduism in Bengal, were imbued with a taste for the hard and fast rules of classical grammar, and had an unmixed abhorrence for the laxities of Prākrita adopted by the Buddhists. Bengali seemed to have no prospects with such scholars:—nay they zealously opposed the efforts of those who offered to help the Vernacular of the country to assert its claim as a written language. The following well-known Sanskrit couplet bears testimony to their ill-will.

"অষ্টাদশ পুরাণানি রামস্য চরিতানি চ।
ভাষায়াং মানবঃ শ্রুত্বা রৌরবং নরকং ব্রজেৎ॥"

"If a person hears the stories of the eighteen Purānas or of the Rāmāyaṅa recited in Bengali, he will be thrown into the hell called the Rourava."

There is a corresponding Bengali couplet which is also well-known:—

"কৃত্তিবেসে, কাশীদেসে, আর বামুনঘেঁষে
এই তিন সর্ব্বনেশে।"

"Krittivāsa (Bengali translator of the Rāmāyaṅa), Kāçīdāsa (Bengali translator of the Mahābhārata) and those who aspire to mix with the Brahmins too closely, are the greatest of evil-doers."

In the famous controversy, which Rājā Rāmmohan Ray held with the orthodox Pandits, he had frequently to explain his conduct in regard to his publication of vernacular translations of the Sanskrit scriptures, which according to those Brahmins, were sacrilegious. This shows that even as late as the early part of the 19th century, when

Bengali had reached a high stage of development, it was looked down upon by the orthodox Brahmins.

Our readers are likely to conclude from the above, that the Brahmins were jealous of the gradual development of Bengali and its recognition as a written language. They wanted all truths of their religion to be locked up in the Sanskrit texts; any attempt to promulgate them through the vehicle of a popular dialect, meant a loss of the great power which they had monopolized; and they thus looked upon all such movements to enrich the vernacular language, with jealousy and distrust. But it admits of another explanation also, which is perhaps the right one. The Brahmanic school probably suspected, that the hunters after cheap popularity who adopted Bengali for conveying the truths of the Brahmanic religion, would not keep intact the purity of their spiritual ideal, and that the truths, so dearly prized by them, would be sullied in the provincial versions of the great Sanskrit works. They therefore decried all efforts to popularize the Çāstras by compiling Bengali translations. Add to this their contempt for Bengali which was one of the most lax forms of the Ardha-māgadhi Prākrita. Not only did the Sanskrit-knowing people hold the Vernacular of the country in disfavour, but even the writers of Bengali themselves had no high opinion of the resources of this language. We frequently come across such lines in old Bengali works, as—"Naturally Bengali poems are faulty"* (Vijay gupta) "Not fit to be discussed in a vernacular poem" † (Kavindra)—implying, that Bengali

* সহজে পাঁচালী গীত নানা দোষময়।—Vijay Gupta.

† "পাঁচালীতে নহে যোগ্যবাদ।"—**Kavindra Parameçwara.**

was quite an unfit medium for conveying any serious or high thought.

**How could Bengali obtain fvaour in the Hindu Courts ?**

The question is : how could the poor Vernacular of Bengal find recognition in the courts of the kings, inspite of this opposition of the Brahmins ? Every Hindu Court gloried in keeping a number of Sanskrit scholars attached to it. From the time of Vikramāditya it grew to be a fashion with Hindu kings to keep learned companions, and they were generally picked men—finished masters in Sanskrit Poetry, Grammar and Logic, who revelled in the high flown style and in the niceties of rhetoric which abound in the latter-day Sanskrit works, such as Kādamvarī, Daçakumār Charita and Çri Harṣa Charita. The copperplate-inscriptions of the Pāl and Sen Kings of Bengal bear abundant proofs of the learning and poetical powers of some of these gifted men, whose contempt for Bengali was as great as was their scholarship in Sanskrit. How can we account for the fact, that the court of Kriṣṅa Chandra of Navadwipa,—a glorious seat of Sanskrit learning—where Hari Rām Tarkasiddhānta, Krisnānanda Vāchaspati and Rāmgopāl Sārbabhouma were the professors of Logic—where Vāneçwar Vidyālankāra won his laurels in Sanskrit poetry and Çiva Rām Vācaspati, Rām Ballabha Vidyāvāgiça and Vīreçwar Nyāya-Panchānana discoursed on philosophy,—such a distinguished seat of classical learning as Kriṣṅa Chandra's court could bestow its favours and titles on Bhārat Chandra and Rāmprasād—the Bengali poets of the eighteenth century ? Not only Kriṣṅa Chandra, but many other Kings and Chiefs of Bengal, who preceded him, are described as having extended their patronage and favour to

the early Bengali poets. Their courts were guided by Sanskrit-knowing Pandits, and how are we to reconcile the fact, that these Brāhmins welcomed the poor *patois*—the despicable Paiçāchī Prākrita of Bengal, for which they had hitherto only a feeling of unmixed contempt.

**Bengali favoured by Moslem Chiefs.**

This elevation of Bengali to a literary status was brought about by several influences, of which the Mahammadan conquest was undoubtedly one of the foremost. If the Hindu Kings had continued to enjoy independence, Bengali would scarcely have got an opportunity to find its way to the courts of Kings.

The Pāthāns occupied Bengal early in the thirteenth century. They came from a far distance—from Bulkh, Oxus or Transoxina, but they settled in the plains of Bengal and had no mind to return to their mountainous home. The Pāthān Emperors learned Bengali and lived in close touch with the teeming Hindu population whom they were called upon to rule. The minarets and cupolas of their Mosques rose to the sky, adjoining the spires and tridents of the Hindu temples. The sounds of the conch-shells and bells emanating from the latter, were heard while the new-comers assembled in the Mosques to say their evening prayers. The pompous processions and the religious rites of the Hindus—their Durgāpujā, Rāsa and Dolotsava—displayed a religious enthusiasm which equalled their own, while celebrating the Maharam, Id, Sabebarāt and other festivals. The Emperors heard of the far-reaching fame of the Sanskrit epics, the Rāmāyaṅa and the Mahābhārata, and observed the

wonderful influence which they exercised in moulding the religious and domestic life of the Hindus, and they naturally felt a desire to be acquainted with the contents of those poems. The Pāthān Emperors and Chiefs could not have the great patience of the Hindu Kings who were inspired by a religious zeal to hear the Brahmin scholars recite Sanskrit texts and their learned annotations, step by step, requiring the listeners many long years to complete a course of lectures on the Rāmāyaṅa or the Mahābhārata. They appointed scholars to translate the works into Bengali which they now spoke and understood. The first Bengali translation of the Mahābhārata of which we hear, was undertaken at the order of Nasirā Sāhā, the Emperor of Gauḍa who ruled for 40 years till 1325 A.D. This translation has not yet been recovered, but we find mention of it, in another translation of the epic made by Kavīndra Parameçwara, at the command of Parāgal Khān, the governor of Chittagong. Nasira Shāh was a great patron of the Vernacular of this country. The poet Vidyāpati dedicates one of his songs to this monarch* and in another, speaks with high respect of Sultan Guisuddin.†

The name of the Emperor of Gauḍa who appointed Krittivāsa to translate the Rāmāyaṅa, is not known with certainty. He might be Raja-Kaṁsanārāyaṅa or a Moslem Emperor, but even if

* সো নসিরা সাহ জানে। যাক হানিল মদন বাণে—চিরঞ্জীব রঁহু পঞ্চ গৌড়েশ্বর, কবি বিদ্যাপতি ভাণে।

—Nasira Shaha knows it well, whom cupid pierced with his dart—the poet Vidyapati says—Long live the Emperor of the 'five Indies.'

† "প্রভু গয়াসুদ্দিন সুলতান"—Vidyapati.

he was a Hindu King, there are abundant proofs to show, that his court was stamped with Moslem influence. The Emperor Husen Sāhā was a great patron of Bengali. Mālādhar Vasu, a native of Kulingrāma, and one of his courtiers was employed by him to translate the Bhāgavata into Bengali, and after two chapters of this work had been translated by him, in 1480 A.D., the Emperor was pleased to confer on him the title of Gunarāj Khān. We have already referred to a translation of the Mahābhārata made by Kavindra Parameçwar at the behest of Parāgal Khān. This Parāgal Khān was a general of Husen Sāhā, deputed by him to conquer Chittagong. Frequent references are found in old Bengali literature, indicating the esteem and trust in which the Emperor Husen Sāhā was held by the Hindus.* Kavindra Parameçwar had translated the Mahābhārata upto the Strīparva, and Chhuti Khān son of Parāgal Khān, who had succeeded his father in the governorship of Chittagong, employed another poet named Çrīkaraṅa Nandī for translating the Açvamedh Parva of that epic. Çrīkaraṅ Nandī's translation has lately been published by the Sāhitya Parisada of Calcutta. The poet Ālāol, who lived about the middle of the seventeenth century, translated a Hindi work entitled

* (১) সনাতন হুসেন সাহ নৃপতি-তিলক,

**Padmā Purāna** by Vijaygupta

(২) নৃপতি হুসেন সাহ হয় মহামতি।
পঞ্চম গৌড়েতে যার পরম সুখ্যাতি॥

**Mahābhārat** by **Kabīndra**

(৩) শ্রীযুত হসন, জগত ভূষণ, সেহ এহি রস জান,

Song by **Yaçorāja Khān**

Padmāvat by Mir Mahammad in a highly sanskritised Bengali at the command of Māgan Thākur, a Mahammadan minister of the court of the Chief of Aracan. It should be noted here, that there are many instances where Mahammadans adopted Hindu names and the name Māgan Thākur should not lead us to mistake him for a Mahamaden. Ālāol was also employed by the Moslem chief—Solaman, to translate a Persian work into Bengali. Instances of like nature, where Mahammadan Emperors and Chiefs initiated and patronised translations of Sanskrit and Persian works into Bengali, are numerous, and we are led to believe, that when the powerful Moslem Sovereigns of Bengal granted this recognition to the Vernacular language in their courts, Hindu Rājās naturally followed suit. The Brahmins could not resist the influence of this high patronage; they were therefore compelled to favour the language they had hated so much, and latterly they themselves came forward to write poems and compile works of translation in Bengali. From the account we have found in some of the early Bengali works of translation, we can have a glimpse of the manner in which court patronage was accorded to the Bengali poets. When the shades of twilight settled on the dark green clumps of shrubby trees on the far Sonāmurā ranges, Parāgal Khān the Governor used to call his ministers, attendants and courtiers every evening to his palace at Parāgalpur in Feni, and before this illustrious audience, the translator of the Mahābhārata had to recite portions from his poems—the governor himself giving cheers in admiration of beautiful and interesting passages. The poet flattered his noble patron by calling him an

incarnation of Hari in Kaliyuga* and it is curious to note, that the Pāthān chief, who, was a devout Mahammadan, enjoyed this compliment of the Hindu poet and did not take it as an affront.

**Hindu Rājās follow the Example.**

Thus the appointment of Bengali poets to the courts of Hindu Rājās, grew to be a fashion after the example of the Moslem chiefs, and we find most of the works of our best poets dedicated to the kings and noble men who patronised them. Thus the works of Vidyāpati, the Maithil poet, are inseparably associated with Çiva Siṁha and other sovereigns of Mithilā. Mukundarām, the immortal author of Chandī, had for his patron Bānkurā Rāi, the Rājā of Ārah-Brāhmanbhumi. Rāmeçvara who wrote the "Çivāyana" enjoyed the patronage of Yaçovanta Siṁha, Raja of Karnagaḍa. Ghanarām, the author of "Dharmamangal" was the recipient of many favours from Kirttī Chandra, the Raja of Burdwan, and who can think of the great poet Bhārat Chandra without remembering his great friend and patron Krisṅa Chandra of Navadwipa? Raja Jay Chandra employed the poet Bhabānī Dās for compiling a translation of the Rāmāyaṅa; and many other valuable Sanskrit works were translated into Bengali under the auspices of the Kings of Tippera. We shall dwell upon all these works in their proper places hereafter.

We now confidently presume that the above proofs will be held sufficient to support the view, that the patronage and favour of the Mahammadan Emperors and chiefs gave the first start towards recognition of Bengali in the courts of the Hindu Rājās

* "কলিকালে হবু যেন কৃষ্ণ অবতার।"

and to establish its claims on the attention of scholars. It is curious to observe that, more than once in history, we have owed the development of our language to the influence of foreign people from whom such help was the least expected. Mr. Nathanial Prassy Halhed, a European member of the Indian Civil Service, wrote the earliest Bengali grammar for us in the eighteenth century; and Bengali prose, in our own days, owes a good deal to the impetus given to it by the European missionaries.

**Other Causes.**

The other causes, which contributed to a rapid development of Bengali during the Mahomedan period, may be briefly summed up as follows :—

(2) The revival of Hinduism, which we have called in this book as the Paurānik Renaissance.

(3) The great Vaiṣṇava movement in Bengal in the sixteenth century.

# CHAPTER II.

## Pre-Mahomedan Literature.

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**1. Aphorisms and wise-sayings,—Dāk and Khanā. 2. Dharma-cult—a form of Buddhism. 3. Ramāi Pandit and his Çuṅya Purāna. 4. Sahajiā-cult and its exponents. 5. Dharma-mañgal poems and the story related in them. 6. The ballads of the Pāl Kings. 7. The Çaiva-cult, how it faced Buddhism. 8. Genealogical records.**

Before dealing with the literature of Bengal that grew up after the Mahomedan conquest, we propose to dwell here upon the fragments of literary works which have come down to us,—from a much earlier period. They consist of (1) Aphorisms and pithy sayings which served as a guide for domestic and agricultural purposes to the rural folk of Bengal. (2) Hand-books of mystic doctrines, based on Tāntrik forms of Buddhism. (3) Ballads and songs in honour of some of the Pāl Kings of Bengal. (4) Hymns, odes and songs describing the prowess of Dharma Thākur and other household deities. (5) Genealogical accounts of the Kulin families of Bengal.

### 1 Aphorisms and wise-sayings, Dāk and Khanā.

**Dāker Vachana.**

Referring to the earliest literature of Bengal, which bears the stamp of Buddhistic influence, we light upon Dakārṅava,—a Tāntrik work of the Buddhists, containing aphorisms and wise-sayings in old Bengali regarding agriculture, astrology, medicine and other matters of interest to domestic life. Mahāmohopādhyāya Haraprasāda Çastri found a copy of Dakārṅava in the custody of the Buddhists of Nepal. Dakārṅavā gives specimens of a very old form of Bengali which may be traced to the tenth

century of the Christian era. Dāk-Tantra is also a book of authority with the rural folk of Bengal, but it is popularly known here as "Dāker-Vachana." The latter work gives a smoothed down version of its precursor and prototype preserved in Nepal; but there are numerous lines to be found in the editions of the book published by the Battalā Presses of Calcutta* which retain their old and antiquated forms. It is impossible to get any clear sense out of such lines as :—

"আদি অন্ত ভুজসি।
ইষ্টদেবে যেহ পুজসি ।।
বুন্দা বুঝিয়া এড়িব লুণ্ড।
আগল হৈলে নিবারিব তুণ্ড ।।
আনহি বসতি আনহি গোয়ালি।
হেন বসতের কি বাউলি ।
ভাষা বোল পাতে লিখি ।
বাটাহুব বোল পাড়ি সাখি ।।
মধ্যস্থে যবে সমাধে ন্যায় ।
বলে ডাক বড় দুখ পায় ।।
মধ্যস্থে যবে হেমাতি বুঝে।
বলে ডাক নরকে পচে ।। "

Probably the last portion refers to the rules for settling disputes by arbitration—a practice generally adopted in the old order of society. There are evident traces of Buddhistic views in these sayings. Buddhism, in its days of decline in India, became identical with scepticism. In Dāker-Bachana, we come across such views as these :—

**Buddhistic views.**

"When we get a good palatable thing to eat, it is not wise to keep it for to-morrow. Enjoy

* Published by Beni Madhab De & Co., 318, Battala, Upper Chitpore Road, Calcutta.

curds and milk; if they bring on disease, get it cured by medicine. For, says Dāk, when one dies, there is an end of his connection with the world."* This is quite an un-Hindu idea. The pleasures of the present moment are condemned by the Hindu Çāstras and the views quoted above remind us of Chārvāka and other free-thinkers, and we have said that the Buddhists of the latter-day school had turned into free-thinkers like Chārvāka. The Buddhistic Dharma Çāstra lays special stress on charitable works. In the short epigrammatic sayings of Dāk, there are many passages calling on a house-holder to perform works of charity and public good.

"One who is anxious to do a virtuous act, should dig tanks and plant trees (for the benefit of the people). One who founds institutions for the distribution of rice and water, never goes to Hell."†

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* "ভাল দ্রব্য যখন পাব।
কালিকারে তুলিয়া না থোব।
দধি দুগ্ধ করিয়া ভোগ।
ঔষধ দিয়া খণ্ডাব রোগ॥
বলে ডাক এই সংসার।
আপনে মইলে কিসের আর॥"

† "ধর্ম্ম করিতে যবে জানি।
পাথরি দিয়া রাখিব পানি।
গাছ রুইলে বড় ধর্ম্ম।
* * *
যে দেই ভাতশালা পানিশালী।
সে না যায় যমের পুরী॥"

We miss in these sayings, the familiar injunctions for prayer and worship, indispensable in a book of rules for the guidance of a Hindu house-holder; and here we can draw a clear line of demarcation between the state of society before and after the revival of Hinduism in Bengal. All rules and codes framed for the guidance of men and women in our society, after the downfall of Buddhism have a distinct and unmistakable reference to the metaphysical side of religion. In them a far greater stress is laid on devotion to gods than on principles of morality. The Hindu priests even go so far as to declare, that a man committing the worst of sins, may secure a place in Heaven by uttering the name of God, a single time. The Dāker Vachana evidently belongs to a period anterior to the acceptance of this ideal in society.

**Khanār Vachan**

Dāker Vachana is not the only book of its kind in old Bengali. Khanār Vachana furnishes an equally old specimen of our vernacular. The latter is more popular with the masses and has, therefore undergone far greater changes than Dāker-Vachana. We, however often light upon old and antiquated forms of expressions in it, which remind us, that though simplified and altered, the sayings must also be traced to an early age. Though the subjects treated of, in the two books, cover a varied field, by far the greater portion of them is devoted to agricultural subjects. In Bengal, where the people are chiefly of the peasant class, these sayings are accepted as a guide by millions;—the wisdom they display is the result of acute observation

**The sayings are mainly devoted to agricultural subjects.**

of nature and has a special significance in regard to the soil and climate of Bengal. We quote some of them below :—*

"If it rains in the month of Agrahāyaṅa, the king goes a-begging.

"If it rains in the month of Pouṣa, money may be had even by selling the chaff.

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* "যদি বরে আগনে।
রাজা নামেন মাগনে ॥
যদি বরে পৌষে।
কড়ি হয় তুষে ॥
যদি বরে মাঘের শেষ।
ধন্য রাজার পুণ্য দেশ ॥
যদি বরে ফাগুনে।
চীনা কাওন হয় দ্বিগুণে।"
"খনা ডেকে বলে যান।
রোদে ধান ছায়ায় পান ॥"
"দিনে রোদ রাতে জল।
তাতে বাড়ে ধানের বল ॥"
"কাতিকের উণ জলে।
খনা বলে দুনো ফলে ॥"
"শুন বাপু চাষার বেটা।"
বাঁশ ঝাড়ে দিও ধানের চিটা ॥
চিটা দিলে বাঁশের গোড়ে।
দুই কুড়া ভুঁই বেড়বে ঝাড়ে ॥"
"শুনরে বাপু চাষার বেটা।
মাটির মধ্যে বেলে যেটা।
তাতে যদি বুনিস পটোল
তাতেই তোর আশার সফল ॥"
"ঘন সরিষা পাতলা রাই।
নেঙ্গে নেঙ্গে কাপাস যাই ॥
কাপাস বলে কোটা ভাই।
জ্ঞাতি পানি যেন না পাই ॥"

"If it rains at the end of the month of Māgha, the king and his country become blessed.

"If it rains in Fālgun, the millet Chīnākāon (*Peanicum miliaceum*) grows abundantly."

"Khanā says, the paddy thrives in the sun and the betel in the shade."

"If the paddy gets profuse sunshine by day, and showers by night, it rapidly develops. Khanā says, the drizzling rain in the month of Kārtic, does immense good to the paddy."

"Hear, O son of ploughman, in the bamboo-bush put some smut of paddy, if you do so near the root of the shrubs, they will soon cover two Kuḍas of land (about 174 cubits square)."

"O son of ploughman, plant *patol* (*Trichosanthes diœca*) in a sandy soil, your expectations will be fulfilled."

"Sow the seeds of mustard close, but those of rye (*Sinapis ramose*) at some distance from one another. Cotton plants should be put at the distance of a leap from one another and jute should, by no means, be planted near them, for cotton plants will perish if they come in contact with the water from the jute-field.""

There are numerous rules of this nature laid down on agricultural matters, with special application to the products of the soil of Bengal. The books serve to this day as infallible agricultural manuals to the ploughmen of Bengal. The short sentences rhyming with one another are soon committed to memory; so every child and every woman knows them in rural Bengal.

The following rule is enjoined for building a residential house:— **On house-building.**

"On the east, let there be the ducks (*i.e.* there should be a tank); on the west, an avenue of bamboos; on the north, a garden of fruit-trees; and the south should be left open"*

**On the properties of plants and on the culinary art.**

The chapter on medicine is not taken from any learned Sanskrit medical work. The indigenous plants and herbs of rural Bengal are prescribed as remedies, the effects of which seem to be infallible on the human system and were known by direct experiment. The discourse on the culinary art of Bengal in Dāker vachan has a particular interest to us, as it describes the simple but exceedingly delicious fare, cooked by our village women. In plainness and in delicacy of taste, these dishes bear a striking contrast with the rich preparations of meat, introduced in the later times by the Mahammadans.

**Study of female character in Dāker Vachan.**

In Dāker-vachan we find an interesting study of female character which, I am afraid, will not be fully appreciated by people unacquainted with the life in our zenana. We give some extracts below :—†

"The husband is inside the house, the wife sits out-doors, and turns her head on all sides and smiles. With such a wife, says Dāk, the husband's life is not secure."

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* "পূবে হাঁস। পশ্চিমে বাশ।।
উত্তরে বাগ। দক্ষিনে ফাঁক।।"

† "ঘরে স্বামী বাইরে বইসে।
চারি পানে চাহে মুচকি হাসে।।
হেন স্ত্রীয়ে যাহার বাস।
তাহার কেন জীবনের আশ।।"

"The hearth is in the kitchen, but the wife cooks meals outside, she swells her small tresses and ties them into a large knot, and frequently turns back her head (as if to see somebody). She empties the pitcher, and goes to the pond for re-filling it, casts side-glances on the passers-by, and covertly glances at some stranger while talking with neighbours on the road, hums a tune while lighting the evening lamp. Such a woman should not be kept in the house."*

**Vāra Masī or 'twelve months' a favourite subject.**

The sky of Bengal, clear and transparent in the early spring, foggy in winter, and full of frowning clouds and angry flashes of lightnings in the rainy months, ever changing its aspects from month to month, cannot fail to strike a keen observer of nature with the clearly defined lines of its varied weather. The various seasons produce different results on the human system, on the paddy-fields, and on the variegated flowers and leaves of trees with which the villages abound. Life here changes, as it were, from month to month and Nature picturesquely disports herself on the stage of this beautiful country through the twelve sub-divisions

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* "ঘরে আখা বাইরে রান্ধে।
অল্প কেশ ফুলাইয়া বান্ধে ॥
ঘন ঘন চাহে উলটি ঘাড়।
বলে ডাক এ গৃহিণীতে ঘর উজাড় ॥
পানি ফেলিয়া পানিকে যায়।
পথিক দেখিয়া আড় চক্ষে চায় ॥
বাতি বুলে গান গায়।
পর পুরুষকে আড় চক্ষে চাহি।
পর সম্ভাষে বাটে রহি ॥
এ নারী ঘরে না থুহি ॥"

of the year. The "Vāramāsī" or a description of twelve months is a favourite subject with our old poets, who seem to be never weary of describing the peculiar pleasures and sorrows of each of the twelve months. Here, in these two manuals, there are frequent references to the conditions of weather foretelling the prospects of paddy during each month of the year. Food, peculiarly congenial to the human system in each season and month, is detailed in Dāker Vachana in strict accordance with the principles of health. I quote a portion below :—

"In the month of Kārtik, take the esculent root *Ol* (*Arum campanulatum*). In Agrāhayana the *Bel* fruit will prove congenial to health. In Pouṣ take *Kanji* (a kind of sour gruel or sowens made by steeping rice in water and letting the liquor ferment). In Māgh, a free use of mustard oil is recommended. In Fālgun take ginger and in Chaitra vegetables of a bitter taste (as Nim leaves) will do you good. In Vaiçakh *Nalita* (a pot herb), in Jyaiṣtha, butter milk,—in Āṣāḍa, curds, in Çrāvaṅa *Khoi* (a kind of fried-grain) in Bhādra, palm fruit and in Āçvina,—cucumber. This is the Vāramāsī, says Dāk."*

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* কার্ত্তিকে ওল, মার্গে বেল।
পৌষে কাজি মাঘে তেল॥
ফাল্গুনে আদা চৈত্রে তিতা।
বৈশাখেতে নিম নালিতা॥
জ্যৈষ্ঠে ঘোল আষাঢ়ে দহি।
শ্রাবনে খৈ ভাদ্রে তাল॥
আশ্বিনে শশা।
ডাক বলে এই বার মাসা॥"

The later Vāramasis, of which there is quite a legion in our old literature, are mainly devoted to tender feelings experienced by lovers in the different months of the year, especially when separated from one another.

**The popularity of the sayings.**

The popularity of the two books is not approached by any other writings that we know of, in the country, as even illiterate men have got the aphorisms by heart, and yet they have been handed down to us from a remote past,—it may be the tenth century A. D. as we have already said and as appears from the language in which their older versions are couched and from the spirit of the age which is stamped upon them.

**The question of authorship.**

Our next point will be to discuss the authorship of these aphorisms. Khanā is believed to be a historical personage,—the reputed wife of Varāhamihira and a prodigy in astronomy, in the days of Vikramāditya, the King of Ujjayinī. Even accepting all these traditions about her to be true,—it is absurd to suppose, that she—a native of Rajputana, would compose the aphorisms in Bengali or dwell upon subjects which peculiarly apply to Bengal. The Dāker Vachana has similarly been ascribed by popular belief to a milk-man named Dāk. In the vaṅitā (signature) of these sayings, we occasionaly come across the words "Dāk goālā" (Dāk-the milkman.) We have, however, found that they formed a part of the Buddhistic work—Dākārṅava Tantra, so their origin is easily explained. In some of the sayings we find the vaṅitā of Rāvaṅa. This exceedingly purile notion is no doubt due to the belief amongst the people of this country

that a knowledge of astrology has come down to us from the Rākṣasas. Inspite of all these traditions, we are inclined to believe, that these sayings contain the accumulated wisdom of the Bengal peasantry,—they are the heritage of an agricultural race to which the unassuming rural folk of Bengal have unconsciously contributed through ages, and that no particular person or persons should be credited with their authorship.

**Buddhistic works recast by the Hindus.**

### 2. Dharma-cult—a form of Buddhism.

The Moslem conquerors often built Mosques with the materials of the Hindu temples they had destroyed. The sculptural representations of gods and goddesses and other carvings on bricks indicating the ancient decorative art of the Hindus have been lately discovered from dilapidated Mosques in various places in India,—as the plaster, which concealed them from view, crumbled down from the walls in course of time.

Such has also been the case with Buddhism in India. In the Buddhist temple, the image of Buddha is often worshipped as Çiva. Buddhistic religious books have been so recast and transformed by the Hindu priests, that they now pass for religious poems of the Hindus in the eyes of the people. Yet they were unmistakably Buddhistic works at first. Such for instance are the poems of Dharma-mangal. Dharma-thākur, in praise of whose might, the poems were originally composed, represents the popular idea of Buddha and occupies the second place in the Budhistic group comprised of Buddha, Dharma and Saṅgha. The third of the group সঙ্ঘ, changed into শঙ্খ, is also alluded to, in the Çuṅya Purāṅa, by Rāmāi Pandit.

He mystically discourses on শঙ্খ,* which however, is as remote from সঙ্ঘ, as is the popular conception of Dharma-thākur, from that of the historical Buddha. There are passages which distinctly prove the Buddhistic origin of the poems. In the Çunya Purāṅa, which lays down rules for Dharma worship, there is a line,—"ধর্ম্মরাজ যজ্ঞ নিন্দা করে"—(Dharma Rāj condemns sacrifices). This sounds like a translation of the well-known line in honour of Buddha by the poet Jaydeva—"নিন্দসি যজ্ঞ বিধিরহহ শ্রুতি জাতং"

**Evidences of their Buddhistic origin.**

There are many other passages which clearly indicate the same truth; for instance "সিংহলে শ্রীধর্ম্মরাজ বহুত সম্মান"—(Dharma Rāj is held in high veneration in Ceylon). In another line we find "আগেতে ছিলেন প্রভু ললিত অবতার"—(In former times Dharma Rāj was the Lalita Avatāra). The most authoritative biography of Buddha is called the "Lalita Vistāra."

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* সংখ উপজিল সংখ সংখর বিচার।
কহ কহ পণ্ডিত সংখর সার॥
কোন সংখ জলে স্তান করেন অনাদ্দ করতার।
আদ্দ সংখ জলার জুতি॥
হরি হরি সংখ পাপ মুকতি॥
কোন সংখে না ছোঁএ পানি।
দখিন সংখে না ছোঁএে পানি॥
দখিন সংখে আপ পঅমানি।
কে সিরজিল গঙ্গা কে সিরজিল পঙ্ক।
তাহে উপজিল দ্বাদশ অঙ্গুল সংখ।
হে জঅ সঙ্ঘ হে বিজঅ সঙ্ঘ তুমি সংখ হইএ চিরাই।
তুম্মার জলে স্তান করেন শ্রীধর্ম্ম গোসাঞি॥

**Çunya Purān** PP. 83-84.

In the poems of Dharma-mangal itself, there are frequent references to Buddhist saints, such as Minanāth, Goraksanāth, Hāḍipa and Kālupa. The words নিরঞ্জন and শূন্য মূর্ত্তি with which the readers of the poems are so familiar, are words taken from the Buddhistic Çāstras. The doctrine known as the Çunyabād, which explains the origin of the universe from nothing, became a popular theory with the later Buddhistic school; and this doctrine is detailed not only in the Çunya Purāña, but also in the poems of Dharma-mangal. The Hāḍīs, Domas and other low caste people are the priests in many of the Dharma temples. The Doma Pandits at one time occupied a prominent position in the Buddhistic temples, and when Buddhism was driven away from this country, all religious functions in many of these Dharma temples, still continued to be discharged by the descendants of the Doma priests, as the Hindus dared not oust a priestly class, revered by the people, from their duties in temples. We noticed, that the poems in honour of Dharma-thākur have been thoroughly recast by the Hindu priests, and Hindu ideas have been largely introduced into them; but even as late as 1640 A.D. the Brahmin priests would not venture to mix too closely with the worshippers of Dharma-thākur for fear of losing caste. In the above year, when Mānik Ram Ganguli, a Brahmin, was inspired by Dharma-thākur, who appeared to him in a dream for encouraging him to write a Dharma-mangal, our poet fell prostrate before him in dismay, and said "জাতি যায় প্রভু যদি ইহা করি গান।"—I shall be an outcast, if I sing a song in your praise). This

distinctly proves that Dharma-thākur had originally no place in the Hindu Pantheon.

**The Brahmins gradually overcome their scruples.**

As the popularity of these songs amongst the masses continued unabated, the Brahmins gradually took them up, and later poems of Dharma-mangal have been so greatly transformed in their hands, that they look very much like works devoted to the Çāktacult; but reading between the lines, the readers will be able to discover evident traces of Buddhism in them. It should however be noted here, that the Buddhism indicated in these works, has scarcely anything in common with the pure Buddhism of Açoka's time; and both are even more unlike one another than the Pourāṅic Hindu religion of the present day and the pure religion of the Upaniṣadas.

**Early Bengali works by the Buddhists.**

The Çunya Purāṅa by Rāmāi Pandit, Chāryāchāryaviniçchay by Kānu Bhatta, the poems known as Dharma-mangal, and ballads and songs in honour of some of the Pāl Kings of Bengal bear distinct stamps of Buddhism on them. The ballads of the Pāl Kings, who were great patrons of Buddhism, indicate the marvellous power wielded by Gorakṣanāth and Hāḍisiddha, the great Buddhistic saints. The latter belonged to one of the meanest castes of the Hindu society, yet his power is said to have been so great, that the gods of Heaven, trembled in fear, when the saint approached. In the sogns of Govinda Chandra Pāl, revised by the poet Durlabha Mallik, the King is said to have asked his religious preceptor—the far-famed Hāḍisiddha, as to what was the true religion. Hāḍisiddhā said:—

"হাড়িপা বলেন বাছা শুন গোবিন্দাই।
অহিংসা পরম ধর্ম্ম যার পর নাই॥"

(O Govinda, my son, the highest act of religion is to abstain from destruction of life).

The popular notion of Buddhism in India holds this doctrine of অহিংসা as the most essential point in the religion of Buddha, about whom the poet Joydeva has said :—

"সদয়-হৃদয়-দর্শিত পশুঘাতং।"

### 3. Rāmāi Pundit and his Çunya Purāṅa.

**Rāmāi Pundit, born towards the end of the 10th Century A. D.**

The great exponent of the Dharma-cult in Bengal was, by general acceptance, Rāmāi Pandit—the reputed author of Çunya Purāṅa. The poems of Dharma-mangal also make mention of Ramāi Pundit with great esteem. His hand-book of Darma Pujā, called the Çunya Purāṅa, has been edited by Babu Nagendranāth Vasu and lately published by the Sāhitya Pariṣada of Calcutta. Rāmāi Pandit was a contemporary of Dharmapāl II, who reigned in Gouḍa in the early part of the 11th century A.D. Rājendra Chol's rock-inscription (1012 A.D.), recently discovered at Tirumalaya, makes mention of this monarch. Rāmāi Pandit was born at Champāighāt-on the river Dwārakeçwar in the District of Bānkura. The year of his birth is not known, but he was born on the 5th day of the waxing moon, in the month of Vaiçākha, towards the end of the 10th Century A.D.

**The question of his pedigree discussed**

Bābu Nagendranāth Vasu, who edits the Çunya Purāṅa, accepts the account of Rāmāi's life furnished by his descendants, and takes him to be a Brahmin. The account is full of fables and is scarcely entitled to credence. The descendants of Rāmāi Pandit, who still discharge the priestly

function in the Dharma temple at Mainā, are known as Dom Pandits and not Brahmins ; besides, there have been so many attempts in Bengal to raise a low-born saint to the rank and status of a Brahmin, evidently with a view to remove the stigma of humble origin laid on his descendants, that we can hardly accept this account of interested parties as true. Haridāsa, the great saint of the Vaiṣṇava community, was a Mahammadan ; but he is now declared by some Vaiṣṇavas to have been originally a Brahmin. Even in the accounts furnished from the temple of Mainā by the descendants of Rāmāi Pundit, there are points to throw a doubt on the pretensions to a high pedigree advanced by them. Dharma-thākur therein is said to have cursed Rāmāi, saying that the people of higher castes would not touch water given by the Saint. Rāmāi Pandit himself is said to have cursed his son Dharmadās for a fault, not clearly stated, by which he lost his caste and turned a Dom Pandit. These stories are evidently got up to establish the point that they were originally Brahmins, though so degraded now. The writer of the sketch very forcibly states that the Dom Pandits do not belong to the Doma caste. His very enthusiasm in establishing this point betrays the weakness of his position ; for the people of Bengal know Domas and Dom Pandits to belong to the same caste. The word দ্বিজ (twice-born) which occasionally occurs in the Bhanitā of Rāmāi Pandit, is a later interpolation and the Çunya Purāṅa, in its present shape, bears traces of many subsequent hands, as Nagendra Babu has himself admitted.

**His descendants.**

Rāmāi Pandit was eighty years old when he married. His son Dharmadās had four sons,—Mādhava, Sanātana, Çridhara and Trilochana. The members of Rāmāi Pandit's family are authorised priests of Yātrāsiddhi Roy—as Dharmathākur of the temple at Maina is called—and they are privileged to perform the copper-ceremony of the 36 castes.

**The contents of the Çunya Purāṇa.**

The Çunya Purāṇa begins with a description of the origin of the universe on the lines of the Mahāyana School of the Buddhists. It runs thus* :—

"There was no line, no form, no colour, and no sign.

"The sun and the moon were not, nor day, nor night.

"The earth was not, nor water, nor sky.

"The mounts Meru, Mandāra and Kailāsa were not.

"The creation was not, nor were there gods, nor men.

"Brahma was not, nor was Visnu, nor the etherial regions.

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* নহি রেক, নহি রূপ নহি ছিল বন্ন চিন।
রবি সসী নহি ছিল নহি ছিল রাতি দিন॥
নহি ছিল জল থল নহি ছিল আকাস।
মেরু মন্দার না ছিল না কৈলাস॥ 2.
নহি ছিষ্টি ছিল আর নহি সুর নর।
ব্রহ্মা বিষ্টু ন ছিল ন ছিল আঁবর॥ 7.
সরগ মরত নহি ছিল সভি ধুন্দকার।
দসদিক পাল নহি মেঘ তারাগণ॥ 10.
আট মিত্তু না ছিল জমর তাড়ন॥ 13.
সুন্নত ভরমন পরভুর সুন্নে করি ভর॥

**Çunya Purāṇ.**

"Heaven and earth were not, all was emptiness.

"The presiding gods of the ten directions were not, nor were there the clouds, nor the stars.

"Life was not, nor death, nor pangs of death.

"The Lord moved in the void, supporting Himself on the void."

From the Lord, says the Çunya Purāṅa, sprang air; and as He drew breath, Ulluk (owl), a bird sacred with the worshippers of Dharma-Thākur, was created. The owl is also sometimes called a Muni (sage). The next creation was tortoise, which is also sacred with the Dharma-worshippers. In the temple, dedicated to Dharma Thākur by Lāu Sen—King of Mainā, in the 11th century, Dharma is still worshipped as a tortoise. The other objects of creation were the serpent Ananta, and the earth; and then from the Lord came Çakti, known as Durgā.

We need not proceed further with this catalogue of theological reveries. The Çunya Purāṅa gives details about the method of worshipping Dharma. We find Çiva, Viṣṇu, Brahmā and a host of Paurānik gods mentioned in this book in a strange way. They discharge functions which have little in common with those attributed to them by the Hindus. Occasionally we come across the word বস্তুনিব্বান, which reminds us of the Nirvana of Buddha.

Çunya Purāṅa, published by the Sāhitya Pariṣad, contains altogether 56 chapters, of which 5 are devoted to an account of the creation of the universe. The rest detail the method of Dharma-worship with occasional references to the sacrifices made by Rājā Hari Chandra and other devout

followers of Dharma, for the sake of religion.

**Specimens of passages from the original work.**

There are several passages in prose in the book which furnish curious specimens of very old Bengali mixed with later interpolations. Our readers will admit from the antique forms of words in the following lines that they formed a part of the original writings of Rāmāi Pandit.

"হে ভগবান বার ভাই বার আদিত্ত হাথ পাতি নেহ সেবকর অর্ঘ পুষ্প পানি সেবক হব সুখি ধামাং করি গুরু পণ্ডিত দেউলা দান পতি সাংসুর ভোক্তা আমনি সন্ন্যাসী গতি জাইতি।" p. 70.

"সুনার কেতকী আনেন করন্তি আসিন্যা।
চারিদিকে নিরঞ্জন সারিন্যা ধন্ম কিন্যা॥" p. 24.

"রাতিত পাথর চারি পাতি কর।
কতে হল সুদ সুনার আড়া।"

"কাঞ্চন বাঁধিআ মেজে করিল কাট ডাল মণ্ডপে ফটিকর থাম লাগে চন্দন নাদন আর সাত ডকে লাগিল গজান। ইলা মণ্ডপে দপ্পন সভাকরে।" p. 59.

The book contains many passages of this nature, and the learned editor has, in an apologetic tone, avowed his inability to explain many of them.

**The last chapter subsequently interpolated.**

The last chapter, which is headed "নিরঞ্জনের রুষ্মা" (the anger of Niranjan) and was evidently annexed, at least three centuries after the composition of the original work, refers to the revival of Hinduism, —the downfall of the followers of Sat-Dharma or pure religion (Buddhism), and to a free fight between the Mahammadans and the Brāhmins at Jājpur,— the Mahammadans being described as the incarnations of gods and goddesses who are said to have come down for wreaking vengeance on the Brāhmins for oppressing the Sat-Dharmis. We give a free and abridged translation of the curious passage

below.* In all probability the passage was written by Sahadeva Chakravarti, one of the authors of Dharma-mangal, of whom we shall have to write at some length, hereafter.

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* জাজপুর পুয়বাদি সোলসয় ঘর বেদি
কর লয় দুন।
দখিন্যা মাগিতে জায়, জার ঘরে নাহি পায়
সাঁপ দিয়া পুরায় ভুবন। ১
মালদহে লাগে কর দিলঅ কন্ন দুন।
দখিন্যা মাগিতে যায়, যার ঘরে নাঞি পায়
সাঁপ দিয়া পুড়াএ ভুবন। ২
মালদহে লাগে কর না চিনে আপন পর
জালের নাহিক দিস পাস।
বলিঠ হইল বড় দশবিস হয়্যা জড়
সদ্ধর্ম্মিরে করএ বিনাস। ৩
বেদকরে উচ্চারণ বেব্যাঅ অগ্নি ঘনে ঘন
দেখিয়া সভাই কম্পমান।
মনেতে পাইয়া মর্ম্ম সভে বলে রাখ ধর্ম্ম
তোমা বিনা কে করে পরিত্তান। ৪
এইরূপে দ্বিজগণ করে সৃষ্টি সংহারণ
ই বড় হোইল অবিচার।
বৈকণ্ঠে থাকিয়া ধর্ম্ম মনেতে পাইয়া মর্ম্ম
মায়াতে হোইল অন্ধকার। ৫
ধর্ম্ম হৈল্যা জবন রূপী মাথাএ ত কাল টুপি
হাতে সোভে ত্রিরূচ কামান।
চাপিআ উত্তম হয় ত্রিভুবনে লাগে ভয়
খোদায় বলিয়া এক নাম॥ ৬
নিরঞ্জন নিরাকার হৈলা ভেস্ত অবতার
মুখেতে বলেত দম্বদার।
জতেক দেবতাগণ সভে হয়্যা একমন
আনন্দেতে পরিল ইজার॥
ব্রহ্মা হৈল মহাঁমদ বিষ্ণু হৈল পেকাম্বর
আদম্ফ হৈল সুলপানি।

**The Brahmins and the Sat-Dharmīs.**

"In Jājpur and Māldah sixteen hundred families of Vedic Brāhmins mustered strong. Being assembled in groups of ten or twelve, they killed the Sat-Dharmis (Buddhists) who would not pay them religious fees, by uttering incantations and curses. They recited Mantras from the Vedas and fire came out from their mouths, as they did so. The followers of Sat-Dharma trembled with fear at the sight thereof, and prayed to Dharma; for who else could give them succour in that crisis? The Brāhmins began to destroy the creation in the above manner, and acts of great violence were perpetrated on the earth. Dharma who resided in Baikuntha was grieved to see all this. He came to the world as a Muhammadan. On his head he wore a black cap, and in his hand he held a cross-bow.

**Dharma comes as a Muhammadan to punish the Brahmins.**

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গণেশ হইল গাজি কার্ত্তিক হৈল কাজি
ফকির হইলা যত মুনি।
তেজিয়া আপন ভেক, নারদ হইলা সেক
পুরন্দর হইল মলনা।
চন্দ্র সূর্য্য আদি দেবে পদাতিক হয়্যা সেবে
সভে মিলে বাজায় বাজনা।। ৯
আপনি চণ্ডিকা দেবী, তিঁহ হৈলা হায়া বিবি
পদ্মাবতী হল্যা বিবি নুর।
জতেক দেবতাগণ হয়্যা সভে একমন
প্রবেশ করিল জাজপুর।
দেউল দেহারা ভাঙ্গে ক্যাড়া ফিড়্যা খায় রঙ্গে
পাখড় পাখড় বোলে বোল।
ধরিয়া ধর্ম্মের পায় রামাঞি পণ্ডিত গায়
ই বড় বিসম গণ্ডগোল।।

I have changed the word ঘুন to জুন in the second line, as I consider the latter to be the correct reading.

**Çunya Purāṅ**, p. 140.

He mounted a horse and was called Khodā. Niranjana incarnated himself in Bhest (heaven). All the gods being of one mind, wore trousers. Brahmā incarnated himself as Muhammad, Viṣṇu as Paigamvar and Çiva became Ādamfa (Ādam). Ganeça came as a Gāzi, Kārtika as a Kāzi, Nārada became a Sekha and Indra a Moulana. The Riṣis of heaven became Fakirs. The sun, the moon and the other gods came in the capacity of foot-soldiers, and began to beat drums. The goddess Chandi incarnated herself as Hayā Bibi and Padmāvatī became Bibi Nur. The gods being all of one mind entered Jājpur. They broke the temples and Maṭhas and cried "seize," "seize." Falling at the feet of Dharma, Rāmāi Pandit sings, "O what a great confusion!"

**The history of the fight unknown.**

What historical incident is referred to, in the description given above, is not clearly known. But it unmistakably points to a general feeling of gratification, with which the Buddhists watched the oppression of the Brāhmins by the Muhammadans at Jājpur, which they attributed to divine wrath, for atrocities committed upon themselves.

#### 4. The Sahajiā-cult.

**The Sahajiā creed started by the Buddhists.**

When Buddhism declined in India, and Hinduism had not yet risen on her horizon in the fulness of its glorious revival,—when the idea of a higher life inspired by a keen sense of morality and introspection, which was the dominant spirit of Buddhism, declined into scepticism and sensuality, and when devotion and absolute trust in God, which characterised the Paurānik Hinduism, was yet unknown—in the twilight of the transition-period,

mystic rituals of Tāntrikism ruled Buddhistic and Hindu communities all over India. The Vāmāchārī Tāntriks perpetrated wanton crimes in the name of religion and the vast literature, they have left us, lays down codes for those initiated in the creed, which totally upset the moral fabric of society.

The Sahajiā-cult owed its origin to the Vāmāchārī Buddhists. Salvation was sought for by a process of rituals in which young and beautiful women were required to be loved and worshipped. In sexual love there is surely a higher side which points to love Divine. The Sahajiā-cult was originally based upon this idea.

Kāṅu Bhatta—a Buddhist scholar, who lived in the latter part of the 10th century, was the first apostle of love-songs of the Sahajiā-cult in Bengali. This love is not a legitimate affair sanctioned by society; with one's own wife it could not, according to this creed, reach a high stage of perfection. Kānu Bhatta's work in Bengali which formulates the creed of Vāmāchār is called Charyyā-Charyya Viniçchaya. It has been lately recovered from Nepāl by Mahāmahopādhyāya Hara Prasād Çāstri. Another work of a similar kind is Bodhi-Charyyā-vatāra, the MS. of which, as I have said elsewhere, is incomplete.

**Charyyā-Charyya Viniçchaya and Bodhi Charyā-vatāra.**

There are passages in the love-songs contained in the above two works which are obscene; but they are permeated by a mystic spiritual significance and are capable of a higher interpretation.

The doctrines promulgated by the Vāmāchari Buddhists did not pass away with the overthrow of the Buddhistic influence in Bengal. In the

Sahajiā creed of the Vaiṣṇavas, the old doctrines re-appeared amongst the masses, and its great exponent Chaṅdīdās echoed the sentiments of Kāṅu Bhatta in his love-songs, giving it a far higher spiritual tone than they had ever received from the Buddhists. Chaṅdīdās lived in the 14th century, so his writings do not, properly speaking, belong to the pre-Mahammadan period to which we should have confined ourselves in this chapter. For an exposition of the Sahajiā doctrines, however, we find it necessary to refer to some of his songs which elucidate the essential principles of this curious creed. Says Chaṅdīdās :—

**Chaṅdī Dās as an exponent of Sahajiā.**

"Every one speaks of Sahajiā,—alas, who knows its real meaning? One who has crossed the region of darkness (passions) can alone have the light of Sahajiā."*

Chaṅdīdās's writings on this point occasionally appear as riddles,—and indeed all writings of this class are so,—but they give sufficient glimpses of the purity of his faith.

† "The woman must remain chaste and never fall; she will sacrifice herself entirely to love, but outwordly the object of her love will be as nobody

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* সহজ সহজ, সবাই কহয়
সহজ জানিবে কে।
তিমির অন্ধকার যে হৈয়াছে পার
সহজ জেনেছে সে॥ **Chaṅdīdās.**

† "হইবি সতী, না হবি অসতী"
"অন্তরে পরাণ বাটিয়া দেওবি
বাহিরে বাসিবি পর।"

to her. Secret love must be indulged in secret; and thereby her mind should be purified; but she should not submit to desire. She must plunge herself headlong in the sea of abuse, but at the same time scrupulously avoid touching the forbidden stream and be quite indifferent to both pleasure and pain, (she will allow herself to be abused by others remaining true to herself)."

To play with passions,—to indulge freely in love, at the same time to guard oneself against a fall, is risky. The poet knows it well and says*—

"To be a true lover, one must be able to make a frog dance in the mouth of a snake"—(which means, the lover while playing with dangerous passions,—nay, while apparently running even to the very mouth of destruction, must possess the self-control to return unhurt). "This love may be attained by one who can suspend the highest peak of Mount Sumeru with a thread, or bind an elephant with a

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"গোপন পীরিতি গোপনে রাখিবি
সাধিবি মনের কাজ"
"না হবি কাহার বস।"
"কলঙ্ক সাগরে সিনান করিবি
এলাঞা মাথার কেশ।
"নীরে না ভিজিবি, জল না ছুঁইবি
সম দুঃখ সম ক্লেশ।"
"সাপের মুখেতে ভেকেরে নাচাবি
তবেত রসিক-রাজ।
"যে জন চতুর, সুমেরু শেখর
সুতায় গাঁথিতে পারে।
"মাকড়সার জালে, মাতঙ্গ বাঁধিলে
এ রস মিলয়ে তারে।।"

cobweb ;"†—implying that it is not in an ordinary man's power to control the surging passions of love and remain immaculate in his vow. The poet says, that by exercising restraint over feelings and desires and at the same time by running though great sacrifices for its cause, salvation through love may be obtained.

According to Chaṅdīdās, the initiated people must exercise great discretion in selecting their objects of love. The lovers should be both pure in heart, spiritually bent and immaculate in morals.

" If a young maiden (of a spiritual temperament) falls in love with a man of inferior quality, she shares the fate of a flower pierced by thorns and dies of a broken heart. If a youth happens to fall in love with a maiden of lower type, he becomes like one, who is under the influence of evil-spirits, —moves about in great unrest, and eventually succumbs to despair ; says Chaṅdīdās. " Such a union between a good-natured person and one who bears an opposite character may be compared to love between the tooth and the tongue ; they live together but the former does not let an opportunity slip to bite the latter."*

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* যে জাতি যুবতি, সাধিতে সে রতি কুজাতি পুরুষে ধরে।
কণ্টকে যেমতি পুষ্প হয় ক্ষত হৃদয় ফাটিয়া মরে ॥
পুরুষ তেমতি নারী হীন জাতি রতির আশ্রয় লয়।
ভূতে ধরে তারে মরে ঘুরে ফিরে দ্বিজ চণ্ডীদাস কয় ॥
সুজনের সনে আনের পীরিতি কহিতে পরাণ ফাটে
জিহ্বার সহিত, দন্তের পীরিতি সময় পাইলে কাটে ।।"

(It should be noted here that the word রতি as used in the above extract, meant pure love in **Chaṅdīdās's** time. Its meaning has since degraded and it now means a low carnal gratification).

Chaṅdīdās himself loved a washer-woman following the rules of the Sahajiā cult, for according to Gupta Sādhan Tantra, a book of authority with the sect, a washer-woman amongst others, is a legitimate subject of such love for a Vāmāchārī Tāntrik. Here is the text of the above Tantra.*

"A dancing girl, a girl of the Kapāli caste, a prostitute, a washer-woman, a barbar's daughter, a Brāhmin girl, a Çudra girl, a milk-maid, a girl of the Mālākar caste—these nine are recognised as the legitimate subjects for Tāntric practices; those that are most clever amongst these, should be held as pre-eminently fit; maidens endowed with beauty, good luck, youth and amiable disposition are to be worshipped with care and a man's salvation is attained thereby."

In purity and edifying influence, Chaṅdīdās's sentiments made a near approach to spiritual love; and he literally worshipped the washer-woman with the ardour of a devotee, though he himself was a good Brāhmin. Her name was Rāmī, and Chaṅdīdās says of her:—

"O my love, I have taken refuge at they feet, knowing, they have a cooling effect (on my burn-

* নটী কপালিকী বেশ্যা রজকী নাপিতাঙ্গনা।
ব্রাহ্মণী শূদ্রকন্যা চ তথা গোপালকন্যকা॥
মালাকরস্য কন্যা চ নব কন্যাঃ প্রকীর্ত্তিতাঃ।
বিশেষবৈদগ্ধ্যযুতাঃ সর্ব্বা এব কুলাঙ্গনাঃ॥
রূপযৌবনসম্পন্নাঃ শীলসৌভাগ্যশালিন্যাঃ।
পূজনীয়াঃ প্রযত্নেন ততঃ সিদ্ধঃ ভবেন্নরঃ॥

**Gupta Sādhan Tantra.**

ing heart). I adore your beauty beaming with holy maidenhood which inspires no carnal desire. When I do not see you, my mind becomes restless; and as I see you, my heart is soothed. O washer-woman, my lady, you are to me what parents are to helpless children. The three prayers that a Brāhmin offers daily to his God, I offer to you. You are to me as holy as Gāyatrī from which the Vedas originated. I know you to be the goddess Sarasvatī who inspires songs. I know you to be the goddess Pārvatī.—You are the garland of my neck,—my heaven and earth, my nether-worlds and my mountains—nay, my whole universe!—you are the apple of my eyes. Without you all is dark to me. My eyes are soothed when I see you. The day I do not see your moonlike face, I remain like a dead man. I cannot, for a moment, forget your grace and beauty. O, tell me how I may deserve your favour? You are my sacred hymns and the essence of my prayers. My love for your maidenly beauty has not any element of physical desire in it. Says Chaṅdīdās,—the love of the washerwoman is pure gold tested by touch-stone."* Chaṅdīdās was himself

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* শুন রজকিনী রামি, ও দুটি চরণ, শীতল বলিয়া,
শরণ লইলাম আমি।
রজকিনী রূপ, কিশোরী স্বরূপ, কাম গন্ধ নাহি তায়।
না দেখিলে মন, করে উচাটন, দেখিলে পরাণ জুড়ায়॥
তুমি রজকিনী আমার রমণী, তুমি হও মাতৃ পিতৃ।
ত্রিসন্ধ্যা যাজন, তোমার ভজন, তুমি বেদমাতা গায়ত্রী॥
তুমি বাগ্বাদিনী, হরের রমণী, তুমি সে গলার হারা।
তুমি স্বর্গ মর্ত্ত্য, পাতাল, পর্ব্বত, তুমি সে নয়ানের তারা॥

convinced that sexual love leads to love Divine. He says "Hear me, friends, how salvation may be attained through love for a woman: Reduce your body to a dry log (make it such as to be quite unmoved by passions). He that pervades the universe, unseen by all, is approachable only by him who knows the secret of pure love."†

So sang Chaṅdīdās—the great exponent of the Sahajiā cult in Bengal in the 14th century, more than 3 hundred years after Kāṅu Bhatta had composed his love songs. It goes without saying, that in their earnest efforts to attain salvation by worshipping young and beautiful damsels, many a youth turned moral wrecks in this country. Chaṅdidās rightly

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তোমা বিনে মোর সকলই আঁধার, দেখিলে জুড়ায় আঁখি।
যে দিন না দেখি ও চাঁদবদন মরমে মরিয়া থাকি।।
ও রূপ মাধুরি পাশরিতে নারি, কি দিয়ে করিব বশ।
তুমি সে মন্ত্র, তুমি সে তন্ত্র, তুমি উপাসনা বস।
রজকিনী রূপ, কিশোরী স্বরূপ কাম গন্ধ নাহি তায়।
রজকিনী প্রেম, নিকষিত হেম বড়ু চণ্ডীদাসে গায়।।

† "নায়িকা সাধন, শুনহ লক্ষণ,
যেরূপে করিতে হয়।
শুষ্ক কাষ্ঠের সম, আপনার দেহ
করিতে হয়।।
ব্রহ্মাণ্ড ব্যাপিয়া, আছয়ে যে জন
কেহ না দেখয়ে তারে।
প্রেমের পীরিতি, যে জন জানয়ে,
সেই সে পাইতে পারে।।"

**Chaṅdīdās.**

says, that "in a million it would be difficult to find one"* who has the capacity for self-restraint required by the Sahajiā preachers.

**The dangers of Sahajiā, the harm it did to the Vaiṣṇava Society.**

From the earliest times the Hindu society does not seem to have offered any refuge to fallen women. The dangers of admitting fallen women to a society with a severe ideal of female purity were fully realised by the Hindus. The rite of Satī, and an uncompromising form of widowhood, sprang up in our social organisation, as natural alternatives for women on the death of their husbands. The Buddhists reserved a place in their nunneries for fallen women and for those who took the vow of life-long maidenhood. The Buddhist Bhikṣus and Bhikṣunīes (monks and nuns) who probably started the principles of salvation by sexual love with all the noble intentions of Dona-Julia in Don Juan, fell victims to their own snares and rightly earned the contemptuous title of নেড়া নেড়ী—the shaved couple. This epithet is now applied to the fallen men and women of the Vaiṣṇava society. But the women of that class do not get their heads shaved as the Buddhist Bhikṣunīes used to do. The Buddhist monks and nuns who formed improper relationship were the persons who were first called নেড়া নেড়ী। The Vaiṣṇavas who borrowed the Sahajiā cult from the Buddhists were not spared these nicknames. Chaṅdīdās himself knew the dangers of the creed and perhaps he stood the severe test. But latterly it became debased to the extreme and produced disastrous results on the Vaiṣṇava community.

* "কোটিতে গোটিক হয়।"—Chaṅdīdās

For love, a little out of the way, if sanctioned by religion, offers temptations which the mass can hardly resist; and it is no wonder that taking advantage of a wicked interpretation of the love of Rādhā and Kriṣṇa, this cult of the Buddhist monks found favour in the lower stratum of Vaiṣṇava society, the degeneracy of which was mainly brought about by the immoral latitudes of the Sahajiā Vaiṣṇavas. The great Vaiṣṇava leaders were conscious of this drawback of their society and so condemned the creed. Chaitanya Deva would not allow any of his ascetic followers to mix with women, and Rupa, Sanātana and other devotees, who followed him, were unsparing in their hostile attitude to the Sahajiā Vaiṣṇavas. —Yet the creed numbered its votaries by hundreds amongst the Vaiṣṇavas, and we have come across about thirty authors in old Bengali literature who advocated the principles of Sahajiā.*

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* The following books, among others, give an exposition of the Sahajiā doctrines—some of them were written nearly 400 years ago, but *all*, before the British Conquest. Most of them contain prose-passages which may be taken as specimens of early Bengali prose.

1. **Svarupa Varṅan**
2. **Vrindāban Dhyān**
3. **Guruçisya Sambād**
4. **Rupamañjurī**
5. **Prārthanā**
6. **Rasa Bhakti Laharī**
7. **Rāga Ratnābali**
8. **Siddhināṁ**
9. **Atma Sādhan**

(by **Kriṣnadas.**)

10. **Amrita Rasa Chandrikā**
11. **Prembhāba Chandrikā**
12. **Sārāṭsār Kārikā**
13. **Bhaktī Laṭikā**
14. **Sadhya Prem Chandrikā**
15. **Rāga Mālā**
16. **Svarup Kalpa Latikā**
17. **Prem Vilās**
18. **Tatva Nirupan**
19. **Rasa Bhakti Chandrikā**

(attributed to **Norottam Dās**)

### 5. Dharmamangal-Poems.

Mayur Bhatta.

The authors of Dharmamangal-poems, written in honour of the god Dharma, unanimously agree in declaring Mayura Bhatta to be the earliest writer on the subject. The poem which is said to have furnished inspiration to the succeeding poets of the Dhurma-cult was called the Hākanda Purāṅa. Babu Nagendranath Vasu considers the Çunya Purāṅa by Rāmāi Pandit to be identical with the Hākanda Purāṅa.* But we do not agree with this theory, as the subject treated in most of the Dharmamangal-poems is quite different from what we find in the Çunya Purāṅa. Besides, the name Hākanda Purāṅa, is evidently associated with the superhuman sacrifices of Lāu Sen at Hākanda, and of this song Ramāi Pandit was not certainly the apostle.

Mayura Bhatta's time is not exactly known. In all probability he flourished a little before the Mahammadan conquest. Sītā Rām, the author of

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20. **Ūpāsanā Paṭala** } by **Premdās**
21. **Ānanda Bhairava** }
22. **Ānanda Laharī** by **Maṭhura Dās**
23. **Dīnamani Chandrodaya** by **Manharadās**
24. **Siddhānta Chandrodaya** }
25. **Amrita Rasa Vallī** }
26. **Vaiṣnavāmrita** } by **Mukunda Das**
27. **Sārātsāra Kārikā** }
28. **Sādhan Opāya** }
29. **Rāga Ratnāvali** }
30. **Ṭoṭva Kaṭha** by **Jodunaṭh Dās**
31. **Yogāgama** by **Jagat Kriṣṇa Dās**
32. **Bhandaṭaṭva Sār** by **Rasamaya Dās**
33. **Rati Vilās** by **Rasik Dās**
34. **Sahajaṭaṭva** by **Rādhā Ballav Dās**
35. **Dīpakojval** } by **Vaṁçīdas**
36. **Nikunja Rahasya** }
37. **Sidharati Kārika** } attributed to **Sanātana** by one who subscribes himself as a desciple of **Kriṣṇadās Kavirāj.**
38. **Vivarṭṭa Vilas** }

* See Preface to the **Çunya Purāṅa.**

a Dharmamangal, who lived early in the fifteenth Century, refers to Mayur Bhatta's songs, as already having grown obsolete and partially lost by lapse of years, in his time. Mayura Bhatta who was admittedly the pioneer in the field and deservedly very popular, preceded Sitā Rām by at least 3 or 4 centuries. We learn from an account given in Mānik Gāṅguli's poem that Mayura Bhatta belonged to a respectable Brāhman family of Bengal.

These poems were originally Buddhistic in spirit but they passed through great changes in the hands of the Hindu priests. Most of the Dharmamangal-poems give a description of the heroic achievements of Lāu Sen, the King of Maina who flourished in the 11th century. I briefly summarise the tale below :—

**The story of Dharmamangal.**

In the reign of Gauḍeçvara, son of Dharmapal II, King of Gauḍa, there lived one Soma Ghoṣa, who was originally a menial servant in his palace. He ingratiated himself into the confidence of the Emperor and secured for himself a landed property at Dhākur on the river Ajay. The son of Soma Ghoṣa was Ichāi Ghoṣa who was a great warrior and a devout worshipper of the Goddess Kālī. He gradually asserted his independence and inspite of all remonstrance offered by his father, declared war against the Emperor of Gauḍa. The Emperor sent several expeditions to put down the revolt but all failed. Karṅa Sen, King of Mainā-gaḍa, a feudatory chief, was summoned to help the Emperor in this crisis. Karṅa Sen, accompanied by his four sons, went to the battle field, but was vanquished in war and all his sons were killed.

He returned to his capital to witness the death of his queen who succumbed to grief owing to the loss of her sons. Karṅa Sen, who was now old, went to Gauḍa under these overwhelming bereavements, with a view to meet the monarch and acquaint him with the dire loss that had befallen him in his expedition. The Emperor of Gauḍa was naturally moved, to hear the sad tale, and tried to think how best he could soothe his friend in the despair thus brought upon him by his fidelity to the throne of Gauḍa. The Emperor had a sister-in-law, a young maiden of remarkable beauty. He asked Karṅa Sen to marry her. Karṅa Sen, as we have said, 'was already declined in the vale of years'; but he obeyed the royal command, and married the beautiful maiden, whose name was Rañjāvatī. Lāu Sen, the hero of Dharmamangal, was born to this married couple. It is said that his mother Rañjāvatī went through various ordeals and superhuman sacrifices in order to propitiate Dharma, one of these being self-destruction at the stake, when she was to be restored to life by the mercy of the god, who was pleased to grant her the boon of a son.

With the help of Lāu Sen, the Emperor of Gauḍa succeeded in putting down Karpurdhala King of Kāmrup (Assam) who had rebelled against him. He also sent Lāu Sen to punish King Haripāl who had refused the old Emperor's proposals to marry his young and beautiful daughter Kāneḍa. A battle ensued, in which the army was led to the field by the lovely princess herself. The encounter between her and our hero was sharp and animated, but she could not long withstand the superior skill and heroism of Lāu Sen,

and King Haripāl was ultimately forced to submit. Kāneḍā was, however, given in marriage to Lāu Sen with the consent of the Emperor. But Lāu Sen's great achievement, was the conquest of Dhākur. Ichhāi Ghoṣa, who had baffled all attempts of the Emperor to bring him to submission, by destroying the vast armies sent at various times for the purpose, was killed by Lāu Sen in a pitched battle.

Besides these historical events, the poems give accounts of very mean plots and machinations to kill Lāu Sen, by Māhudya,—the brother-in-law and prime minister of the Emperor of Gauḍa. Lāu Sen was Māhudya's nephew, being his sister's son. The marriage of his sister Rañjāvatī with Karṅa Sen, who was old and decrepit, had not been approved of by him and though it had been celebrated under the orders of the Emperor, yet her brother tried his best to dissuade Rañjā from going to Maynā-gaḍa with her husband. Rañjā did not listen to her brother's counsel, but firmly told him, that as Karṅa Sen was now her lord,—young or old, it mattered not to her,—she was bound to follow him wherever he might go. In great anger Māhudya cursed his sister, saying that no child would be born to her. Hence when her son was actually born, and prince Lāu Sen grew to be a handsome young hero with courage and spirit for any enterprise, a deep seated rage rankled in his uncle's bosom. There are hundreds of incidents in the poems, describing the plots to assassinate Lāu Sen formed by Māhudya and last though not least was a command issued by the Emperor of Gauḍa at the instigation of the prime minister, calling upon

Lāu-Sen to go to Hākanda and fulfil certain extra-ordinary conditions for the propitiation of the god Dharma. These involved a severe course of penances, and required that the prince should make the sun rise from the west. If he should not be able to satisfy the King by this, he was to lose his head. When Lāu Sen had gone to Hākanda on this strange mission, Māhudya led an army to Maynā-gaḍa and laid siege to his capital. The brave and heroic sacrifices of Lokhā Dumānī, wife of Kālu Doma, and those of his son Çaka, with the wonderful spirit of devotion to truth shown by Kālu in the sacrifice of his life at this crisis,—are graphically described by all the poets of Dharma-maṅgala. The trials and temptations which beset Lāu Sen in his early youth,—the court of Surikshya, the coquettish queen,—the manners of Nayānī, the lewd Vārui woman, are all full of interest for us as shedding light on various points of domestic and court-life as it prevailed in the Bengal of those days. Lāu Sen eventually comes out triumphant, by the favour of Dharma, and by dint of his wonderful devotion and strength of character.

**The historical aspects of the poems.**

Such, briefly, is the subject-matter of the Dharmamaṅgal-poems. The subject is an historical one. The ruins of Lāu Sen's palace may still be seen at Maynā-gaḍa in Tamaluk. The fort of the great Ichhāi Ghoṣa, who offered a fierce resistance to the Emperor of Gauḍa in the 11th century, is also lying in ruins on the banks of the Ajay in the district of Bāṅkurā. The temple of Kāli called Çyāmrupā, worshipped by Ichhāi, is also to be seen in that place, which is still full of the tradition of the prowess and heroic deeds of the glorious rebel.

The image of Dharma Thākur in the form of a tortoise, and a temple dedicated to it by Lāu Sen, may be seen in Maynā-gaḍa. In the list of the most prominent Indian Emperors of the Kali Yuga, furnished by our household almanacs, the name of Lāu Sen occurs along with those of Rājāh Yudhiṣṭhira, Mahīpāl and Ākbar. Haripāl, against whom Lāu Sen fought, lent his name to his capital in Simuliā on the river Brāhmanī. The ruins of the outer courts of his palace, called the Bāhir-Khanda, are still to be found in this village of Haripāl. The river Brahmanī, on which it once stood, has, however, been completely silted up. Old Simuliā is now indicated by Simul-gaḍa, which represents the once-fortified portion of the capital of Haripāl.

That the names Lui Chandra, Māhudyā, Lohatā, Jāllān-Çekar, Kaneḍā, Kalingā and Samolā are those of historical personages, appears from their very antiquated Prākrita forms. They could not have been invented by any poet within the last seven hundred years. The refined classical taste of the poets of the Renaissance period would not have permitted them to adopt these names in their poems if they had not been historical.

These rustic epics of Dharmamangala were recited and sung by rural folk in early times, and as such can not perhaps claim any high literary merit. But they are full of valuable references to the period before the Mahammadan conquest, and as our knowledge of that period is scanty, they possess an undoubted interest for the student of history.

**The extent of the kingdom of the Emperors of Gauḍa.**

It appears from them that the Emperor of Gauḍa, styled 'পঞ্চগৌড়েশ্বর' King of the five Gauḍas, or 'lord of the five Indies,' as Beal has translated it, was the actual sovereign-head of Bengal, Orissa and Kāmrupa. The kings of Cooch Behār, Āssām, Bārendra Deça, Shollipur, Kainjhorā, Simulyā, Maina-gaḍa, Doluipur and other places, were all his vassals, and assembled under his banner at his summons. The royal seat of the kings of Gauḍa, was at Ramāti, which is an abbreviation of the Ramāvātī mentioned in the copper-plate inscription of Madan Pāl. This was either an earlier name, or a part of the city of Gauḍa. We also find, in the feudal organisation of the Empire, that Domas and Chandālas formed the main personal army of the emperors and their devotion to the King furnishes the poets with many extraordinary examples of courage and heroism.

**Bara-bhuñas.**

We have read of the Bāra-bhuñās or twelve 'lords of the land' of Bengal, who wielded great power in the country during Mahammadan times. But the custom of having twelve sub-lords attached to a paramount court, did not originate in India during the Mahammadan period. It is one of the oldest institutions of the Aryans. In the codes of Manu and Çukrāchāryya, we find references to Dwādaça Mandaleçvara, which show that a great empire used to be divided into twelve subdivisions, or provinces each under its own chief, who was bound to serve the emperor, to attend his court and to acknowledge him as his feudal overlord. The *Dodecapolis* of the Greeks corresponds to this institution. During the reign of Darius,

these twelve lords became so powerful as to assert their independence and cause considerable trouble to the State. The custom of appointing twelve chiefs attached to the Darbār is even now prevalent in various States in Rājputnā, and this is also the practice in the court of the Mahārāja of Hill Tipperā, which retains some of the most ancient usages of early Hindu Kings.* In all the ballads of Dharmamangal we find frequent mention of these twelve lords, who are described as discharging important political functions in the court of the emperors of Gauḍa. They would appear to have been the pillars of the state, and in the confidence and honour with which they were treated at court, seem to have been second only to the Prime minister and to the feudatory chiefs. Certain functions were theirs which no one else could perform. At the time of the king's coronation, for instance, it was their privilege to pour on his head the sacramental water of the *abhiseka*. At the time of marriage of the emperor or his eldest son, they had the right of garlanding the newly-married couple.

The descriptions of the royal courts, with which these poems abound, give us glimpses of important administrative forms prevalent during the Hindu period of Indian history, though subsequent writers did not fail to introduce some features of the Mahammadan Durbār in their descriptions.

* For example, it is customary with the Tippera Rajas to enquire if any person dwelling in the Raj, has not had his daily meal before the Raja breaks his own fast, which he does at a very late hour of the day. This practice which, no doubt, originated from highly humane principles, has been reduced to a mere formal observance.

Mayura Bhatta, as we said, was the earliest writer of Dharmamangal and probably lived in the twelfth century. After him, came Khelārām, Mānik Gāngulī, Ruprām, Rāmachanadra, Çyām Pandit, Rāmdās Ādaka,. Sahadeva Chakravartī, Ghanarām and other writers, who gradually Hinduised the Buddhistic tales originally written to glorify Dharmaṭhākur. We shall notice their works in a subsequent chapter.

**The chief writers of Dharmamangal.**

### 6. The ballads and songs in honour of some of the Pāl Kings.

In Chaitanya Bhāgabata, a Bengali work of great authority with the Vaiṣṇavas, the author Vrindāvan Dās (born 1507 A.D.) refers to the great favour in which the ballads in praise of some of the Pāl Kings were held in Bengal. The copperplate-inscription of Madan Pāl corroborates the truth of this statement so far as Mahīpāl was concerned. The inscription says that the valourous and chivalric career of Mahīpāl, who was like a second Çiva, formed a favourite theme for popular songs in Bengal. We have an old Bengali saying "For the husking of rice in the mortar, the songs of Mahīpāl!" Later, when Çaivaite ideas became fashionable, the name of Çiva was substituted for that of Mahipal. All these things go to show that the Buddhistic monarchs of Bengal, about whom no chronicler came forward to write biographical or historical accounts,—whom the Brāhmanic school, while eulogising a Ballāla Sen or a Lakṣmaṅa Sen beyond all measure, completely ignored,—must have left indelible marks on the popular mind by the greatness of their character and public works. Immense tanks, for instance, in the Districts of

**The popularity of the Pāl Kings.**

Dinājpur and Rungpur, still attest the philanthropic spirit by which the Pāl-Kings endeared themselves to the millions of subjects over whom they ruled.

**The language of the songs greatly modernised.**

The popular songs in honour of the Pāl Kings were, no doubt, composed shortly after their death. The shape in which we find them now, however, is certainly not so old. The language has been considerably modernised, and here, as in the case of the Çuyna Purāṅa, we come, now and again, on traces of the ancient originals. The ballads used to be sung in chorus by professional ministrels amongst the admiring rural folk with whom they were so popular, and this fact accounts for the changes wrought in their versions from age to age, to suit the understanding of the people.

**Manik-Chandra Rajār Gān.**

Mānik Chandra Rājār Gān or the song of Manik Chandra Rājā, was first published by Dr. G. A. Grierson in the Asiatic Society's Journal (Vol. I, Part III 1878). Mānik Chandra Pāl ruled in Northern Bengal during the first half of the 11th century, and the work in question must have been composed shortly after his death.

**The crudeness of the song.**

There is not much that is intrinsically poetic in this ballad. It displays the unrestrained imagination of a rustic author. The miracles attributed to Hadi Siddha remind one of the wonders performed by *Danhas* or some other *dzinn* in the Arabian Nights. Gods and men alike seem to be subject to the influences of Tāntrik rites which awaken marvels at every step. But we occasionally catch glimpses of historical truth from incidental descriptions. The Government revenue of those days, was collected in cowries and trade

was mainly conducted by a system of barter. The higher classes seem to have been immensely rich and we find frequent descriptions of food being served to them on heavy golden plates. Their dinners were considered incomplete without at least some fifty different dishes, the tradition of which is not altogether unknown to our housewives even to this day.

The similes and metaphors used in the descriptions are very commonplace, and show that these rural folk were completely ignorant of those classical standards which now permeate even the lower stratum of Hindu society. The beautiful teeth of Rājā Gopī Chandra's wife are compared to Solā (bark of the cork-plant). Nowadays, any peasant of the most backward of Bengali villages would compare them to the seeds of a pomegranate, after the classical style.

**The redeeming feature. Queen Aduna's grief.**

But this perfectly artless song, in spite of its crudeness, is redeemed by the pathos which bursts forth in the cry of love of Aduṇā—the abandoned wife of Gopī Chānd. He turns ascetic and is about to leave her; she falls at his feet in tears, and with the devotion and loving entreaty of a gentle Hindu wife, says to her husband:—*

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* "না যাইও না যাইও রাজা দূর দেশান্তর।
কারে লাগিয়া বান্দিলাম শীতল মন্দির ঘর॥
বান্দিলাম বাঙ্গালা ঘর নাই পাড় কালি।
এমন বয়সে ছাড়ি যাও আমার বৃথা গাবুরাণী॥
নিন্দের স্বপনে রাজা হব দরিসন।
পালঙ্কে ফেলাইব হস্ত নাই প্রাণের ধন॥
দশ গিরির মাও বইন রবে শ্যামী লইবে কোলে।

"Leave me not O, King, for some distant exile.

"For whom have I built this cool house—this bungalow, spacious and beautiful beyond description! Will you desert me in my youth!— alas, vain is then my youth.

"How often shall I stretch out my hand and miss you, O jewel of my heart!

"In the homes of my neighbours, women young and old will have their husbands by their sides.

"My lot it will be to weep alone in an empty house.

"O king, let me go with you.

"If only I am with you, I can guard your precious life.

"I shall cook for you when you are hungry.

"I shall offer you water when you thirst.

"With laughter and gentle play, how many hours will pass!

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আমি নারী রোদন করিব খালি ঘর মন্দিরে ॥
আমাকে সঙ্গে করি লইয়া যাও।
জীয়ব জীবন ধন আমি কন্যা সঙ্গে গেলে।
রাঁধিয়া দিমু অন্ন ক্ষুধার কালে।
পিপাসার কালে দিমু পানী।
হাসিয়া খেলিয়া পোহামু রজনী।
আইল পাহার দেখিলে কথা কহিয়া যামু।
গিরি লোকের বাড়ী গেলে গুরুস্যাম বলিমু।
শীতল পাটি বিছায়্যা দিমু বালীসে হেলান পাও।
হাউস রঙ্গে যাতিমু হস্ত পাও।
গ্রীসকালে বদনত দিমু দণ্ড পাখার বাও।
মাঘ মাসি সিতে ঘেষিয়া রমু গাও।

"Walking in the open fields, we shall talk merrily and know no weariness.

"But when we approach the houses of men I shall declare you to be my guru—my master.

"When you desire to rest, I shall spread a cool mat for you, and you shall recline on a pillow, while I in happy mirthfulness slowly press with my hands your hands and feet.

"When the summer is hot, I shall gently fan you, and in the cold month of Māgha I shall cover you with warmth."

Gopī Chānd remonstrates, saying that an ascetic's lot is hard, and he will have to traverse forests infested with tigers and other wild beasts.

The queen says in reply*:—"These are false excuses to put me off.

"Who would believe in such nonsense as this?

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* কে কয় এ গুলা কথা কে আর পইতায়।
পুরুষের সঙ্গে গেলে কি স্ত্রীক বাঘে ধরে খায়॥
ও গুলি কথা ঝুটমুট পালাবার উপায়।
খায় না কেন বনের বাঘ তাক নাই ডর।
নিত কলঙ্কে মরণ হউক স্বামীর পদতল॥
তুমি হবু বটবৃক্ষ আমি তোমার লতা।
রাঙ্গা চরণ বেড়িয়া লমু পালাইয়া যাবু কোথা।
যখন আছিনু আমি মা বাপের ঘরে।
তখন কেন ধর্ম্মি রাজা না গেলেন সন্নাসী হয়ে॥
এখন হইনু রূপর নারী তোরে যোগ্যমান।
মোক ছাড়িয়া হবু সন্ন্যাস মুই তেজিম পরাণ॥

"When was it ever heard of, that a woman was killed by a tiger while in the company of her husband?

"But even if a tiger kills me—I fear it not. I shall die without stain in the eyes of the people, and at the feet of my husband.

"You will be to me as a fig tree and I as a creeper unto you.

"I cling to your beautiful feet, O how can you desert me?

"While I was yet a maiden in my father's house, why did you not, O my pious prince, turn ascetic and renounce the world?

"Now I have attained to womanhood and am worthy of your love.

"If you leave me now, I shall kill myself with sorrow."

**Govinda Chandra Rajār gān by Durlabha Mallik.**

In a similar ballad, which gives an account of Govinda Chandra Rājāh, whom we consider to be identical with Rājāh Gopī Chandra, the poet Durlabha Mallik, recasting the song in comparatively modern times, describes Queen Adunā's sorrows in somewhat the same way.

When all importunities had failed and the king could not be moved from his resolution to go alone*:—

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* হায় হায় কর্য়া রাণী ধুলায়ে লুটায়।
উহুনার রোদনে পাষাণ গল্যা যায়॥
কান্দয়ে নগরবাসী রাজা পানে চায়া।
বাল বৃদ্ধ যুবা কান্দে আর শিশু ম্যায়া॥

"Queen Adunā fell on the earth, crying alas! alas!

"Her lamentations would have melted a stone.

"The citizens assembled and began to shed tears for their king's departure.

"Children, old men, youths, and women all began to weep.

"The very ocean seemed to move in surging waves, at the sight of the sorrow of the Queen.

"The horses and elephants wept silently in the stables.

"The birds 'Çārī' and 'Çuka' wept in their cages and would not touch their food.

"The maidens who attended on the Queen began loudly to lament.

"The Queen herself threw away her ornaments.

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রাণীর ক্রন্দনে নদী উথলে সাগর।
পাইসালে কান্দে অশ্ব যতেক কুঞ্জর।।
শারি শুয়া পক্ষী কান্দে না করে আহার।
দাসীগণ কান্দে রাজার করি হাহাকার।।
খসাইয়া পেলে হার কেয়ুর কঙ্কণ।
অভিমানে দুর করে যত আভরন।।
পুঁছিয়া ফেলিল সব সিঁথার সিন্দুর।
নাকের বেসর পেলে পায়ের নুপুর।।
রাজার চরণে পড়ে জড়ায়ে কুন্তল।
মোরা সঙ্গে যাব রাজা দেশান্তরে চল।

"In great affliction she threw away her jewels.

"She wiped away the sacred vermilion from her forehead.

"From her face she drew off the Besara, and from her feet she threw away the Nupura.

"In utter woe she fell at the king's feet, covering them with her dishevelled hair and, crying again and again 'O king let me go with you!'

**The doctrine of Çunyabād.**

The Çūnyabāda, or doctrine of primeval nothingness, which, as we have said in a preceding paragraph, characterises the Mahāyana school of Buddhists, is preached in this poem by the great sage Hāḍipā and there are numerous other evidences of Buddhistic influence in it.

**The capital of Gopi Chand. His great renunciation—a subject of national interest.**

The capital of Govinda Chandra Rājāh is described as situated at the town of Patikā which has been identified with PāitkāPārā under the police-station of Jaldhakā in the District of Rungpur. The renunciation of Rājāh Gopī Chānd created a sensation all over India, which even at this distance of time, continues to be echoed in poems and dramas written in the Hindi and Maharātti languages. A recent picture, by Ravi Varma representing Gopī Chānd on the point of deserting his queen and palace, commands a large sale all over India.

**A promised edition of the songs.**

Babu Biçweçwara Bhattāchāryya B.A., subdivisional Magistrate of Nilphamari in the District of Rungpur, is at present collecting and editing

a number of old and rare songs in honour of the Pāl Kings from Northern Bengal.*

### 7. The Çaiva-cult, how it faced Buddhism.

Çiva as Rudra Deva.

It was to the growing influence of the Çaivā religion that Buddhism eventually succumbed in India. The conception of Çiva, as we find it in the Purānas, is grand beyond all description. In the Vedic literature, he had been known as Rudra Deva. There he was the God of destruction, awe-inspiring, with four arms, each of which held a different weapon, and amongst which his trident and the Pināk carried at their points the grim terrors of death. The movements of this god, in infinite celestial space, made the great planets crush each other, and his trident pierced the elephants who supported the ten points of the compass. All other gods fell on their knees, and cried for protection, when Çiva danced in wild and destructive ecstacy at the time of the final dissolution of the universe.

The Paurāṅik conception borrowed from Buddhism.

But the Purāṅas completely changed the Great God. We have heard of the fiery planets growing cold with lapse of time in the celestial regions, the pleasant verdure of shrubs and plants covering those orbs from which once emanated sparks of living fire. The God Çiva has passed through a similar transformation. In the Paurāṅik age he is represented as the very personification of calmness.

* Very lately Babu Nagendranath Vasu has discovered several versions of songs about Govinda Chandra Raja, in the villages of Orissa. These versions appear to be more correct and reliable than their Bengali prototypes. The custodians of the songs there have been, as in Bengal, the Yogis who were doubtless an important class of men in the Buddhist society.

The destructive elements have all been eliminated, and he is now quiet and dignified, absorbed in Samādhi. This Samādhi is akin to the Nirvāṅa of the Buddhists. The Great God is above all desire, as was Buddha. Çiva kills Madana, the God of Love, of whom another name is Mara; and Buddha's struggles with Māra and eventual conquest over him are well-known. He is represented as an ascetic with the beggar's bowl in his hand. He has a golden palace at Kailāsa; and Kuvera, the Lord of Wealth, is in charge of his store. But the Great God has nothing to do with wealth. He lives by begging, sleeps in the burning ground and remains absorbed in contemplation. In this respect also, he was verily like Buddha, who, though a prince, left the palace of Kapilāvastu to embrace the life of a bhikṣu. Çiva's company is sought for by the resplendent gods of heaven, but ghosts and goblins are his companions. Buddha, though a prince, mixed with the poor and the lowly, and thus showed that he scorned none.

**Çiva drinks poison to save the world.**

When the ocean was churned by the gods, Lakṣmī, the Goddess of wealth, arose from it. Viṣṇu seized her as his prize; the great diamond Kaustuva, also fell to his share. The majestic elephant Airāvata, the incomparable horse Uchchaiḥçravā, and the celestial Pārijāta tree, which arose next from the ocean, were given to the God Indra. Last, though not least, appeared that ambrosia which had the effect of giving immortality to him who partook of it. This was divided amongst the assembled gods equally. Çiva meanwhile, remained in Kailāsa, absorbed in samādhi, caring not whether the universe were lost

or gained by the other gods. But at a second churning of the ocean from which the gods had expected yet more prizes, streams of deadly poison issued from it in overwhelming quantities, with clouds of smoke that looked like curling snakes. This threatened to flood the universe and destroy it. The gods were awe-struck. They knew not how to protect the world from the destruction which seemed to be impending. In their despair, they called on Çiva to save creation. The Great God's heart was moved with compassion. He gathered the floods of poison in his out-stretched hands and drank it all up, in the presence of the wondering gods. But the poison he drank left a blue mark on his throat, and he is called Nilakaṇṭha or the Blue-throated. This episode is narrated in such a manner in the Purāṅas, that it seems to me to be analogous to the story of pain and sacrifice undergone by Buddha, who suffered for the sake of suffering humanity.

**His figure compared to Mount Himalaya.**

Let us picture to ourselves the image of the great Çiva. He is like a mountain of white marble, tranquilly seated in the posture of Samādhi. On his forehead is the crescent moon. From his matted locks flows the pure stream of the Ganges, that goddess whom his mercy melts into an unceasing fountain of white waters. In this attitude he may be compared very aptly to some mountains of the Himalayas, with the young moon shining above its cloudy height, and the perennial flow of the Ganges pouring over its steep regions. The heads of venomous snakes peep out of the locks of Çiva, as they do from the recesses of the great mountains.

The image of Çiva, as made in clay and marble, in the villages shows the quietness and composure of Buddha, and both are now so like one another! Yet nothing could have been more dissimilar than the original conception of Rudradeva—the Çiva of the Vedas.

**Myth and history confounded in India.**

The best points of Buddha's life are ascribed to Çiva. The Purāṅas represent him as embodying all the attributes of Buddha's greatness. One point may be urged in favour of Buddha. He was a living person of flesh and blood, and as such, the influence of his sternly real personality might be presumed to produce far greater results than that of a mythological God. In India, however, this matter is viewed in a different light. Here, when a saint or great religious teacher dies, he is at once deified. He becomes one of the glorious gods and in popular estimation he occupies a place not far remote from that ascribed to the celestials. On the other hand, thousands of men and women in India, believe in every word of the Purāṅas. To them Çiva is as real as any historical personage. Buddha, though deified, could not claim the grandeur of the back-ground which sets forth the luminous figure of the great God of the Hindu Trinity. Infinite space, the whole of heaven and earth and the solar regions, are represented as the incidents of that back-ground. Çiva has no birth, no death; his eyes never close, they are raised heavenward, lost in celestial reverie, and they scarcely look down towards this mundane world of ours, except for the sake of mercy. Buddha, already divested of his original glory, and reduced to Dharma Ṭhākur,

became quite lustreless in the eyes of the people, before this great and resplendent divinity of the Hindus.

**The domestic virtues extolled in the Çaiva religion.**

Çiva has one element, however, which is wanting in the conception of Buddha. This is the sanctity of the nuptial vow, which sheds glory on his abode at Kailās. Buddha's emancipation could not be complete without deserting a devoted and loving wife. But Çiva and Durgā, the ideal couple, cannot be dissociated from one another. Durgā, who is also called Satī and Annapurnā, is the goddess who distributes rice to the hungry. To the world she is as mother, who cares not for herself, but for her children only; and Çiva is the ideal of a Hindu householder, never ruffled in temper, immoveable, immaculate and merciful, their union representing the fulfilment of the spiritual vows given and accepted in marriage, that two will live for one another and for others. How perfect this mutual love was, is proved in the death of Satī. Her devotion to Çiva was so great that she could not bear to hear him abused by her father Dakṣa. Feeling that the blood of the defamer of her lord ran in her own veins, she considered her body itself as unholy, and gave it up in a flash, to be born again as a daughter of Himabat. In this new life she passed through severe penances and sacrifices to be worthy of being united in marriage to Çiva. In the stoical asceticism of Buddha, these domestic features find no place, and while assimilating the quintessence of Buddhism, the Çaiva religion has this point in addition, which at once appealed to the Hindus a people conspicuous for their strong domestic instincts.

Buddhism, as presented to us on the eve of its downfall, combined sceptical views with gross superstition. The light that it had given to India, had spent itself in ages gone by, and in the shape in which it existed latterly, could scarcely commend itself to the Indian people, accustomed as they were, to live in a highly spiritual atmosphere. Dharma and Çiva in the popular notions of the period, appeared as very humble deities, whose function suited the requirements of the rustic folk who worshipped them.

**The oldest songs of Çiva.**

The oldest songs relating to Çiva, which fall within the scope of this chapter, shew nothing of that high conception of him which distinguished the period of the Paurāṅik Renaissance. They were meant for Bengali villagers, and Çiva figures in them as assisting in the work of the rice-fields, and even ploughing them himself like any peasant. Even in the Çuṅya Purāṅa, there is a song devoted to Çiva in his agricultural capacity, from which we may take the following extract *:—

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* জখন আছেন গোসাঞি হয়া দিগম্বর।
ঘরে ঘরে ভিখা মাগিয়া বুলেন ঈসর॥
রজনী পরভাতে ভিক্খার লাগি যাই।
কুত্থাএ পাই কুথাএ না পাই॥
হর্ত্তকী বএড়া তাহে করি দিনপাত।
কত হরস গোসাঞি ভিক্খাএ ভাত॥
আহ্মার বচনে গোসাঞি তুহ্মি চস চাস।
কখন অন্ন হএ গোসাঞি কখন উপবাস॥
পুখরি কাঁদাএ লইব ভুম খানি।
আরসা হইলে জেন ছিচএ দিব পানি॥
ঘরে ধান থাকিলেক পরভু সুখে অন্ন খাব।
অন্নর বিহনে পরভু কত দুঃখ পাব॥

Çiva figures as a peasant.

"The Lord is without any raiment.

"He begs from door to door.

"At dawn of day he rises, and goes out to beg.

"Some people give him alms; by others he is refused. Sometimes he lives on *bayra** and *haritaki*† only. But Oh, how happy is he when they give him the begger's rice!

"I say unto you, O Lord, why don't you plough?

"By begging, you often have to fast, and you get rice only now and then.

"You must select a muddy soil for cultivation, but if you can't secure this, and dry lands fall to your share, you should water them well.

"When you have rice at home, how glad will you be to take your daily meal! How long will you, O Lord, suffer for want of food?

"Why not cultivate cotton, O Lord; How long will you wear a tiger's skin?

"You besmear your body with ashes (Bibhuti).

"Why not cultivate mustard and *tila*.‡ (So that you may have oil to anoint yourself). And be sure to grow plenty of vegetables. Above all, don't

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কাপাস চসহ পরভু পরিব কাপড়।
কত না পরিব গোঁসাই কেওদা বাঘের ছড়॥
তিল সরিসা চাষ কর গোঁসাই বলি তব পাএ।
কত না মাখিব গোঁসাই বিভুতিগুলা গাএ।
সকল চাস চস পরভু আর রুইও কলা।
সকল দব্ব পাই যেন ধম্ম পূজার বেলা॥

**Çunya Purāṅa.**

* Terminalia Belerica.

† Terminalia Chabula.

‡ Sesamum Orentale.

forget banana plants, so that for the Dharma-pujā nothing may be wanting."

**The agricultural capacity of Çiva retained in the later Çivayanas.**

In the Çivāyana, or songs of Çiva by later writers, who were the exponents of the Çaiva cult in Bengal, we find a chapter devoted to Çiva's agricultural speculation and experiences. The traditions about Çiva related in the Purāṅas have no bearing whatever upon these. We shall here quote a passage from the Çivayana of Rameçwar, a writer of the 18th century, which will at once recall the anecdotes of Çiva related in the Çunya-Purāṅa. Rāmeçwar, Kavichandra and other writers, though their own idea of Çiva was of the high classical type, could not help embodying these humble episodes in their descriptions. This shows how greatly the rural people of Bengal favoured them. A song in honour of Çiva, though noble in all respects, would not be perfect in the popular estimation unless it included these humbler aspects of his character, that had found favour in the country for centuries. In that chapter of the Çivayana to which we are referring, Bhima, who first appeared in the Çunya Purāṅa as a devoted servant of Çiva in the rice-fields, still retains the tradition of this character, co-operating with Çiva in his field-labour.*

"Çiva sits in the field and says to Bhima the ploughman :—

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* ক্ষেতে বসি কৃষাণে ঈশাণ বলে ভাল।
চারিদণ্ডে চৌদিক চৌরস করে চাল॥
আড়ি তুলে ধারে ধারে ধরাইল ধান।
হাটু পাড়ি ঈশানেতে আরম্ভে নিড়াণ॥
দল দুব্বা সোলা শ্যামা ত্রিশিরা কেশুর।

"Good. In four Danda's time* you must level the ground perfectly on all sides."

"The rice was planted in several places on the ridges between the furrows, and Çiva, kneeling, applied himself to work with a weeding hook.

"The grasses called Dala-durbā and Çyāma,† Triçirā ‡ and Kesur § were weeded out with care, and the straw in the field was quickly cleared. The old fellow || would not leave the field for one moment, but kept watch over it like a tiger."

Altogether it is a long description, giving every detail of the field-work of the Bengali peasantry from which we have taken only the above short extract. Means are suggested for the destruction of the mosquitoes and leeches with which the marshy fields of Lower Bengal, are infested, and other precautions are given by which the peasant may secure a good harvest. From the language in which these episodes are couched, I am inclined to believe, that they formed part of some old song of Çiva which Rāmeçwar was incorporating in his

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গড় খড় নানা খড় উপারে প্রচুর।
বাদ নাহি বাঘ যেন বসি থাকে বুড়া।।

**Çivāyana by Rameçwar.**

* A Danda is 24 minutes. 7½ Dandas make a Prahara and 4 Praharas make a day (12 hours). Time is reckoned in Bengal-villages by this standard even now.

† Species of Cyperus.

‡ Grass with three blades

§ Scirpus kyseer.

|| **Çiva** is here meant.

poem without much revision. There are many passages such as—

"বারটি বারঠে চেকুড়াব ঝড়াউড়ি।
গুলামুখি পাতিমারে পুতে যার নুড়ি।"

which it is difficult to explain, because of the antiquated words and provincialisms used—peculiar to the locality in which the author lived. The somewhat revolting story of the intrigue with Durga, in the guise of a Bāgdinī woman, which is told of Çiva by these writers must also be referred for its origin to the late Buddhistic age. They incorporated in their songs tales which had been prevalent amongst the rustic people of Bengal at that period when moral ideas become confused under Tāntrik influences.

**The story of the Bāgdini woman.**

Three elements are found in the later Çiva-poems. (1) There is the Paurāṇik element, with its grand conception of Çiva, which, as I have said in the foregoing pages, shews traces of the spiritual influence of Buddha's life (2) We have the humbler attributes of the divinity, ascribed to him by villagers and peasants under Tāntric influences. (3) and again, counteracting these last, we have the purity and perfection of family relationships, as represented in the ideal Hindu household. Here inspite of many conflicting interests of the undivided family, the prescence of its head brings harmony and peace, the result of that spirit of forbearance that he has gained by the long habit of viewing all mundane concerns from a lofty spiritual stand-point. Here the mistress of the house-hold lives entirely for her lord, for her children and for others, without a thought of personal comforts

inspired only by holy love—a perfect picture of patient suffering and unflagging devotion.

**The domestic elements develop in Bengali poems.**

In Bengali songs of Çiva, this last trait reaches a high stage of development, showing the peculiar bent of our vernacular genius in conceiving and idealising purely domestic subjects.

**Kailas, the heaven of Çiva.**

Kailāsa, the City of Çiva, is the abode of bliss, where gold and lead have the same value, where the tiger and the lamb, the mongoose and the serpent are friends, and drink from the same fountain, forgetting their natural enmity. The love, harmony and tranquility which pervade Mount Kailāsa, are all inspired by Mahadeva himself, whose holy dwelling-place is thus strangely unlike the heavens of other gods, glittering with gold and making the impression of the aggrandised capital of some worldly monarch.

### 8. Genealogical records.

**Achār.**

If I am asked as to what is the chief basis of that Paurāṅik Hinduism which triumphed over Buddhism and has since ruled supreme in India, I should say Āchāra. This word, I find difficult to translate into English. It means rules for the guidance of every day-life to which every Hindu should conform; yet this definition does not fully express the idea. The word Āchāra refers only to the details of daily life and must not be confounded with questions of morality. A man may not be very moral, and still his life may be Āchāra-puta, or pure as regards the observance of the rules laid down by the Çastras.

**Raghunandan and his great work.**

The great compiler of these rules in the 16th century in Bengal was Raghunandan Bhattāchāryya and he is up to the present the greatest authority in the country with the orthodox community. To a superficial observer, the Herculean efforts made by Raghunandan in collating a vast body of ancient Sanskrit works, in order to settle very minor points in the every-day life of a Hindu, will appear like lost labour; but diving deeper into the subject, and applying the principles of historical evolution to it, the reader will find a rational explanation for the popularity of Aṣṭāviṁsaṭi Ṭaṭṭva—the great work of Raghunandan, and have to admit that the age was in eminent need of such a scholar. If the country had not wanted him, why should his book have been accepted by the people of Bengal? He did not possess any arbitrary power to enforce his code upon the multitude. They submitted to his yoke willingly.

**The contents of Astaviṁsaṭi Ṭaṭta.**

On particular lunar days, particular foods prove uncongenial to the human system. This is the current belief of Indians. Raghunandan devotes an important chapter of his work to a consideration of this point.* The details of methods for performing Çrāddha and other religious ceremonies, for observing fasts and vigils, the restrictions against marriage between the people of the same caste, and against long journeys by sea or land,—such are the subjects which have been treated with patient scholarship in

* For instance, one should not eat a pumpkin or its gourd (cucurbita pepo) on the 2nd day of a Lunation; Brihati (Solanumhirsatum) on the third; Patal (Trichosanthes dioeca) on the 4th; Radish (Raphanus Sativus) on the 5th; Nimba (Melia Azadirachta) on the 6th; and so on.

this celebrated work. He quotes chapter and verse from Manu, Yājñavalkya and a host of ancient sages in support of his views with regard to very small matters. A giant's labour was given to the raising of a mole-hill. The point that puzzles an enquirer, is how to account for the iron grip in which these rules, occasionally so puerile, have held the orthodox Hindu community for centuries. A devout Hindu would consult the Çāstras to know if on a particular day he could eat a certain vegetable. If in the month of Māgha a person takes radish, he will be pronounced a non-Hindu. What could be the reason that made people submit to such laws with religious veneration ?

**How is it that the book carries so great an authority ?**

To answer this question, we must survey our social condition during the decline of Buddhism. The great vice, which undermined the unity and strength of our society in the last days of Buddhism, was that of free-thinking carried to excess. The Buddhists preached :—

**Free-thinking and its result on society.**

"There is no heaven, no hell, no vice, no virtue. None created the world, none has the power to destroy it. No other evidence is to be recognised than what appeals directly to our senses. There is no soul, our body alone is subject to pleasure and pain—the result of good and bad actions. When we see that children are produced by the agency of parents, clay models by potters, and pictures by painters, such evidence is enough to shew how things come into existence. Then why should we ascribe them to an imaginary Creator ? Don't

give pain to yourself or to others. Not depending upon others, is salvation. Heaven lies in eating food of delicious taste."*

It is further preached that immorality is no vice, but this particular passage need not be quoted.

**Indiscriminate food.**

Now let us imagine the effect of such free-thinking on society. The Tāntriks who were dominant all over India in the age of which we are speaking, were known to banquet on things so horrible as, for instance, a putrid corpse. They wanted to shew that in their eyes nothing in creation was unholy.

**Laxity of marriage-laws.**

The marriage system had become lax. During the flourishing days of Buddhism, the different races of Asia had been brought into close touch with one another. The monasteries were filled with men and women of alien race, and when standards of morality sank low in Buddhistic society in course of time, a population, consisting of children disowned by the communities of both their parents came into existence, and

* The above is the translation of a passage from **Vidyonmād-Tarañgiṅī** a well-known Sanskrit work by **Chirañjiv Bhattāchāryya**. The author gives an interesting description of religious controversies amongst the various sects of Hindus. The above arguments are put in the mouth of a Buddhist. **Vidyonmād-Tarañgiṅī** was translated into English by the late **Rājā Kālī Kriśṅa Dev** of **Shobhā Vāzār**, Calcutta in 1834. The Sanskrit Text of the passage is given below :—

"ন স্বর্গো নৈব জন্মান্যদপি ন নরকো নাপ্যধর্ম্মো ন ধর্ম্মঃ,
কর্ত্তা নৈবাস্য কশ্চিৎ প্রভবতি জগতো নৈব ভর্ত্তা ন হর্ত্তা।
প্রত্যক্ষান্যন্ন মানং ন সকলফলভুগ্ দেহভিন্নোঽস্তি,
কশ্চিন্মিথ্যাভূতে সমস্তে ঽপ্যনুভবতি জনঃ সংশমেতদ্বিমোহং।'
অহিংসা পরমো ধর্ম্মঃ পাপমাত্মপ্রপীড়নম্।
অপরাধীনতা মুক্তিঃ স্বর্গোঽভিলষিতাশনম্॥
কা স্বস্থৌ পরিদেবনা যদি পুনঃ পিত্রোরপত্যোদ্ভবঃ।
কুন্ত্যাদ্যাঃ প্রভবন্তি সন্ততময়ী তত্তৎকুলালাদিতঃ॥"

the purity of the four original castes of the Hindus was lost. On an examination of skulls, the Mongolian type has been discovered in high-caste Hindus of various places in India. The Buddhists had no strict code of marriage-laws. In the Ambatto Sutta of the Buddhists we find that *pratiloma*—that reversal of ranks in marriage which is so highly condemned by Hindu law-givers—was at one time greatly in vogue in India. In the drama of Mrichchhakatika written by a Buddhist prince, we find Chāru Datta, a good Brāhmin, paying court to Vasanta Sena—a courtesan. In the Daçaratha Jātaka of the Buddhists, Sītā is represented as the sister of Rāma, who at the same time marries her. These and similar tales are told in a plain way without any comment, thus shewing that in Buddhistic society, rules of marriage were extremely loose.*

The revival of Hinduism in Bengal, between the 9th and the 13th century, meant war against these laxities brought by a set of free-thinkers who would submit to no leader, but would wreck the whole fabric of society on the quicksands of their own cynicism. To preserve the purity of the Aryan blood after the admixture and corruption it had already passed through, to counteract the influence of the Tāntrikism with its obnoxious idea of indiscriminate food, in a word, to undo the great evils of that age, strict rules regarding marriage and eating required to be enacted, if society was to be ordered and disciplined and led to accept a pure ideal.

**The propaganda of the revivalists.**

* Similarly in the history of Java, we find the Buddhist King **Jayālankār** marrying his own sister **Chāndra-Sura** in 675 A.D.

When the Hindu revivalists began their task of reformation, they found the original caste-system shattered by the indiscriminate union of men and women. Society was in a thoroughly disorganised state. The children born of couples who came from different castes, were not owned by either of the original castes. The new builders of society classified them, and admitted them into the new order, allotting to each a fixed status in society. This accounts for the origin of so many sub-castes in India. They came into existence by the breaking of marriage rules.

**The origin of the sub-castes.**

**Hard and fast rules laid down by Raghunandan.**

Hindu society, after admitting this heterogeneous population, shut its portals against newcomers, and no breach of the hard-and fast rules of marriage now enforced, was again to be tolerated. Regarding indiscriminate food, which had been taken in utter disregard of rules of health, minute details were now settled. But the vices to which human nature tends, cannot be checked by codes of law. A high ideal of spiritual life set before the people, keeps them in the right direction in these matters, and our society busied itself only in framing rules for the direction of the details of daily life. These rules hold their sway till now. If a person openly avows Jesus Christ to be the son of God, or Mahomet to be the only prophet of God, Hindu society will not war against him. Our toleration goes so far. But there are hundreds of petty rules in regard to eating—especially cooked foods—the infringement of any one of which will render him liable to be excommunicated from society or make him undergo severe penances. Marriage rules again have been made so severe, that

even in the narrow groove of one's own caste, the selection of a bride-groom has grown to be a serious problem with Hindu parents. The reactionary movement, as is natural in such cases, ran to excess, and small points took exaggerated proportions in the eyes of the people. Besides the Tantriks, there were other people near at hand, who disregarded prejudices of all kinds, in using meat as food. Buddhism, as I have said, had brought into India, a vast number of foreigners belonging to different Asiatic races. There were, amongst these, snake and cockroach eaters, not to speak of those whose daily food was ham and beef. The Hindu community had to be guarded against adopting the ways of such alien peoples, and as the Muhammoden conquerers could not be expected to take any interest in these matters, touching the well-being of the people, the leaders of society became their natural guardians and dictated their actions. Raghunandan compiled a treatise which was much needed in an age of vice, resulting from unrestrained conduct.

**Achār, an outcome of reactionery measures.**

I believe I have now explained what I understand by the word Āchāra, which, I said, is the chief basis of our modern Hindu society. Āchāra is a deliberate disavowal of this spirit of free-thinking. It is a reactionary step, taken to bring a loose and disorganised society into order and unity; and however absurd it may appear on a superficial view, it had a mission at the time when its stringent rules were first enacted; and it cannot be declared with certainty that the good results which the revivalists had in view, are fully exhausted even now.

The topics discussed above should not be considered as a digression ; for upon a knowledge of some of the essential features of the revival of Hinduism, will depend a right appreciation of the ideals set up by the succeeding literature.

**The qualities required of a Kulin.**

Vallāla Sen who ruled from 1119 to 1169 A.D. conferred Kulinism upon people of various castes in Bengal. The qualities required to entitle one to the status of a Kulīna were nine : viz., (1) āchāra, (2) humility, (3) learning, (4) good repute, (5) the visiting of sacred places, (6) devotion, (7) good conduct, (8) religious austerity and penance, and (9) charity. Āchāra, of which we have spoken already, heads the list of these qualities.

**Kulinism made hereditary.**

Vallāla Sen, while bestowing Kaulīnya, or the status of a Kulīna, on a few select people of the higher castes, enacted, that after a fixed period, new men endowed with the above qualifications, would be admitted into the grade of Kulīnas, and that these were to be the recognised heads of the different sections of the Hindu community in all social matters. But his son Lakṣmaṅa Sen afterwards ruled, that the descendants of the Kulīnas were to enherit Kulīnism irrespective of their personal qualifications, and thus the Kulīna classes, as they are now found, became stereotyped in society. Many books have been preserved in Sanskrit and Bengali, shewing the genealogy of the higher classes of the Hindu community ; and some of these may be traced to Vallāla Sen's time. These give a glimpse at the inside of our social organisation, and indicate the changes which it has undergone during the last one thousand

**Genealogical records.**

years. The son of a Kulīna became by right a Kulīna. This contravenes the wholesome principle of rewarding the meritorious members of society, on which Vallāla Sen had wanted to base Kulinism. Kulinism thus became an artificial institution, but it had one aspect which still evoked the greatest sacrifices, by developing a peculiar instinct of family-honour. The Kulīnas and the non-Kulīnas of a community were often bound together by marriage-ties. There were, however, many orthodox families in Bengal who would on no account recognise such relationships. They were prepared to sacrifice every earthly consideration, even their lives, to guard the purity of their Kaulīnya status or Kulīnism. The lay men of different communities on the other hand never lacked patience in their efforts to persuade such orthodox Kulīnas to marry with them, by offering huge sums of money. We find that a scion of the Vaidya Gaṅa family of Tenāi in Faridpur was persuaded to marry a girl of the Dāsarā Dutt family on a dowry of sixty-four villages in the subdivision of Mānikgañja in the District of Dacca. The ancestors of the Naikaṣya Kulīnas amongst Brahmins of the present day passed through tests and sacrifices such as only martyrs in a great cause would be supposed capable of undergoing. We find one of the lay Vaidyas coming to Senhāṭī to induce a Kulīna of that caste to form a matrimonial alliance with him, and persevering in his attempts, inspite of repeated refusals, till some banyan trees, planted by him on the banks of the river Bhairava on his first landing at the place, grew so large as to give shade to travellers,—when at last the Kulīna agreed to give a daughter of his family in

**The sacrifising spirit of the Kulinas.**

marriage. I find in the preface to a translation of Chandī by Rūpanārāyaṅa Ghoṣa (born, 1579 A. D.) that a lay Kāyastha named Jādavendra Rāy, Zemindar of Āmdālā, in the District of Dacca, took away two young men belonging to a Kulīna family in a boat on the river Padmā ; and there he made a proposal of marriage between them and his two daughters. If they would not agree to his proposals, they were to be drowned in the river. The elder of the two, Vāṅīnātha, preferred death to the disgrace that would be brought upon his family by such a connection. He was drowned accordingly. But the younger, Rūparāma, succumbed to the fear of death and accepted the alternative. We find in the Kula-Pañjikā by Kavi Kaṇṭhahāra, that a Kulīna Vaidya died broken hearted, from having been obliged to marry a tyrant's daughter.* Such instances are numerous in the genealogical books. This goes to show to what excesses the reactionary movement in regard to marriage rules was carried. The genealogical books also show our keen desire to follow ideals of purity and truth in life, and they record the struggle that Hindu society made to ward off the harm that the overtures of an arbitrary Mahammadan aristocracy, were constantly making upon their quiet life. If any one wants to study the character of the people of this country, and to understand their aims and aspirations instead of summarily dismissing them as mysterious beings, he would do well to study these works carefully.

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* "সংগ্রামসাহতনয়াপাণিপীড়নপীড়িতঃ।"

**Kavi Kaṇṭhahār.**

Kulinism has often been abused; but the sacrifices and martyrdoms undergone for its sake in our society cannot but evoke feelings of wonder and admiration.

The object of such sacrifices may be considered trivial but the qualities of self-denial, of utter disregard for earthly prosperity, and of devotion to a cause which distinguished these Kulinas are not to be despised. Just think of a man preferring to wear rags, to depend on a single meal a day, and to live in a hut of reeds, while his brother was made the owner of sixty-four villages and a palace, the same offer coming to him but being refused with indignation. Yet by marriage with a fellow caste-man's daughter, of non Kulina rank, he would not be excommunicated from society; only a very slight stain would be left on his family honour. Social prestige has in the past occupied the same place in popular estimation in India as a sense of political right does in western countries; and unless this difference is taken into consideration, the ideals of the Indian people cannot be fully realised.

**Specimesn of early composition in the records.**

I said, that some of the genealogical treatises may be traced to Vallāla Sen's time. The following Bengali lines which occur in a Sanskrit work by Chaturbhuja, a Vaidya, written three hundred seventy-five years ago, were evidently already very old :—

"দুহি বিনায়ক ত্রিপুর চাউ।
শিয়াল পহু থোবে কাউ।
গৈ লৈয়া কুলের বাস।
রাঢ়ে বঙ্গে সাত আট।"

There are many such lines to be found in other works of this class, which show in their style, a striking similarity to Dāker vachana and other early compositions.

**Early genealogical records in Bengali.**

Early genealogical books in Bengali are mostly written in prose. The field has not yet been properly explored; yet the Sanskrit works, that have already come to light containing the genealogical records of the three upper classes of our community form a vast literature. It is not however within our scope to refer to Sanskrit works. Of Bengali books on the subject, which are also numerous, we name some below. Though fragments of these writings seem to be ancient, yet their composition as a whole covers a period of not more than four hundred years, closing in the middle of 18th century.

**A list of some.**

A few of these Bengali works on our social history are as follows:—

1. Melabandha by Devivar Ghatak.
2. Prakriti Patal Nirṅaya by the same author.
3. Kulārṅava by Vāchaspati Miçra.
4. Mela-rahasya by Danujāri Miçra.
5. Daçā Tantra Prakāça by Harihar Kavindra.
6. Melaprakriti Nirṅaya.
7. Melamālā.
8. Mela-chandrikā.
9. Mela-prakāça.
10. Daçāvaṭi.
11. Kulatattva Prakāçikā.
12. Kula Sāra.
13. Pirāli Kārikā by Nilkaṅtha Bhatta.
14. Goṣṭhikathā and Kārikā by Nula Paṇchānana.

15. Rāḍhīya Samāj-nirṅaya.
16. Kula Pañji by Rāmadeva Āchāryya.
17. Rāḍhīya Graha Vipra Kārikā by Kulānanda.
18. Graha Biprakula Bichāra by the same author.
19. Ḍhākura by Çuka Deva.
20. Kula Pañji by Ghataka Viçārad Kānti Rām.
21. Dākuri by Çyāma.
22. Dakṣin Rāḍhīya Kārikā by Mālādhar Ghataka.
23. Kārikā by Ghataka Keçarī.
24. Kārikā by Ghataka Churāmaṇi.
25. Kula Pañjikā by Ghataka Vāchaspati.
26. Dhākuri by Sārvabhauma.
27. Dhākuri by Vāchaspati.
28. Dhākuri by Çambhu Vidyānidhi.
29. Dhākuri by Kāçināth Vasu.
30. Dhākuri by Mādhava Ghataka.
31. Dhākuri by Nandarām Miçra.
32. Dhākuri by Rādhāmohan Saraswatī.
33. Maulika Vaṁça Kārikā by Dwija Rāmānanda.
34. Dakṣin Rāḍhīya Kula Sarvasva.
35. Ekjaya Kārikā.
36. Vaṇgaja Kulaji Sāra Saṁgraha.
37. Vaṇgaja Kulaji by Dwija Vāchaspati.
38. Vaṇgaja Dhākuri by Dwija Rāmānanda.
39. Maulik Dhākuri by Rāmnārāyaṅa Vasu.
40. Dhākuri of Vārendra Kāyasthas by Kāçi Rām Dās.
41. Vārendra Dhākur by Yadu Nandana.
42. Kulaji of Gandha Vaṇiks by Tilak Rām.
43. Do. by Paraçu Rām.
44. Kulaji of Tāmvula Vaṇiks by Dwija Patra Paraçurām.

45. Kulaji of the Tantu Bains (weavers) by Mādhava.

46. Satdharmāchāra Kathā by Kiṇkar Dās.

47. Sadgopa Kulāchāra by Mani Mādhāva.

48. Tili Pañjikā by Rāmeçwar Datta.

49. Suvarṇa Vaṇika Kārikā by Maṇgal.

50. Rāja Mālā (completed in 1439 A.D.) by Çukreçwar and Vāṇeçwara.

This last is a genealogical history of the Rājāhs of Hill Tipperā.

**Important to the student of history.**

These genealogical works preserve the traditions of an ancient race, and though the composition of many of them, as we have said, belongs to comparatively recent times, yet they embody facts regarding our social condition which have been transmitted from distant ages. They are therefore entitled to the consideration of those interested in the history of Bengal. Not only do they give accounts of our social movements, but they are full of incidental references to contemporary events.

**An Example, Nalu Panchānan on the question of the caste of the Sen-Kings of Bengal.**

I shall here refer in some detail to a genealogical account written by a Brāhmin named Nalu-Paṇchānana, who is an admitted authority on the subject. The style of writing and the description of the subject clearly show that the author, who lived about one hundred fifty years ago, had embodied facts in it found in older records. The book is called Gosthikathā Kārikā. It is chosen here for reference, because the genealogical accounts will not again be touched upon, and because the matter contained in the Kārikā is important, as

giving the solution of a very knotty problem in the history of Bengal. The Sena Kings of Bengal were formerly believed to have belonged to the Vaidya or medical caste. In all the genealogical works written by the Brāhmins, Vaidyas and Kāyasthas, they were described as Vaidyas. In fact Rājā Rajendra Lal Mitra, who was the first to dispute the point of their caste, had to admit. "The universal belief in Bengal is that the Senas were of medical caste and families of Vaidyas are not wanting in the present day who trace their lineage from Vallāla Sen." * But in the copper-plate inscriptions of the Sena Kings, lately discovered in various parts of the country, they have been found to declare themselves as Brāhma-Kṣatriyas. In the face of their own declaration on this subject, the traditions and written accounts, which were formerly considered as perfectly reliable, lost all authority, and the Sena Kings were generally accepted by scholars as having been Kṣatriyas. Now the descendants of those Brāhmins, Kāyasthas and persons of other castes, on whom Vallāla Sen had bestowed Kaulinya, knew him to have belonged to the Vaidya caste, and they were in possession of written records substantiating this point. Yet nothing was now considered more reliable than a declaration on the part of the princes themselves as to the caste to which they belonged, preserved in the lasting impression borne by the copper-plates. The Kārikā, to which we have referred, however, unravels the history of these aspirations and proves them to have been

* Indo-Aryans, page 265.

mere pretensions. We quote a part of this interesting record below*:—

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* একদিন রাজা জিজ্ঞাসিল পঞ্চ গোত্রীয়ে।
মহাবংশ কুলীন আর সিদ্ধ শ্রোত্রিয়ে॥
কহ সভাসদ আছ যতেক পণ্ডিত।
কি হেতু ত্যজিলে বৈদ্যে ছিলে পুরোহিত॥
উত্তরিল মহেশাদি যতেক সুকৃতী।
নিত যাজে রত নহি নৈমিত্তিকে ব্রতী॥
অন্ন হল দশকর্ম্মা শ্রাদ্ধে পিণ্ডভোজী।
দ্বিজের স্থণ্ডিলে ঋত্বিক, নহি শূদ্র যাজী॥
আদিশূর রাজা বৈদ্য বৈশ্য তার জাতি।
একচ্ছত্রী রাজা ছিল ক্ষত্রবং ভাতি॥
ইন্দ্রদ্যুম্ন বৌদ্ধ রাজা জগন্নাথে কীর্ত্তি।
সাম্যবাদী তবু বলায় ক্ষত্রিয়বৃত্তি॥
রাজা হলে রাজন্য সে না ভাবে অন্যথা।
পতিত কাম্বোজাদি গৌড়ে ক্ষত্র যথা॥
ভূপাল অনঙ্গপাল আর মহীপাল।
জাতি ভ্রষ্ট, ক্ষত্র নহে রাজন্য প্রবল॥
তারাও বিভা করিত তিন জাতির মেয়ে।
ব্রাহ্মণ পুরোধা সাতশতী দেখ চেয়ে॥
তাই তারা ক্রিয়াকাণ্ডে বেদ জ্ঞানহীন।
যাজক পিণ্ডভোজী প্রথা ত অপ্রাচীন॥
বল্লাল লয় যবে পদ্মিনী জাতি হীনা।
লক্ষ্মণ কহে দ্বিজেএ প্রথা ত দেখিনা॥
ভাই বল্লাল ত্যজে কুপুত্র বলি সুতে।
লক্ষ্মণ ত্যজে পৈতা বৈদ্যকুল রক্ষিতে॥
ইথে উভয় পক্ষের বৈদ্য পতিত ব্রাত্য।

"One day the King asked the Brāhmins of five Gotras (families), some of whom were great Kulinas, and other Çuddha Çrotriayas, "O Pandits who adorn my court, tell me why have you deserted the Vaidyas, whereas formerly you used to discharge priestly functions in their families?" Maheça and other learned men said in reply, "We are not prepared to do the daily work of priests in any house. We perform priestly offices for occasional ceremonies only. The Brāhmins, who discharge ten set functions in one house, and eat the rice offered to the dead in the Çrādh-ceremony are generally illiterate. We act as priests in the 'Homá'-ceremonies of the Brāhmins only, and do not act as priests in the houses of Çudras. King Ādiçūra was a Vaidya. He belonged to the Vaiçya caste. He was an emperor paramount, and therefore assumed the status of a Kṣatriya. Indra Dumna was a Buddhist King. He founded the Jagannāth Temple. He did not believe in castes, yet he called himself a Kṣatriya. Whoever becomes a king aspires to the status of a

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ক্রমশঃ বৃষলে গণ্য অত্রত্য তত্রত্য ॥

* * * *

ভূমিপ হইলে সবার ইচ্ছা হয় ক্ষত্র।
গৌরব হেতু "রাজন্য" বলায় যত্র তত্র ॥
সবারি অভিলাষ সে উচ্চ হয় নিজে।
দেবত্ব পেলেও ইচ্ছা ব্রহ্মত্বে বিরাজে ॥

* * * *

বৈদ্য রাজা আদিশূর ক্ষত্রিয় আচার।
বেদে ব্রহ্মবৎ, কার্য্যে মাত্র ব্যবহার ॥

**Sambandha Nirṅaya, by Lālmohan Vidyānidhi** (2nd Edition) p p. 584-89.

Kṣatriya without considering other points. Similar instances are to be found in the cases of out-castes like the Kambojias in Gauḍa. Bhupāl, Anaṇgapāl and Mohipāl were not Kṣatriyas, they were out-castes. But they were great Kings, hence they could marry girls from the three highest classes. Look at the Sāt-Çati priests, they discharge priestly functions in all houses, hence they have lost all knowledge of the Vedas. They eat the rice offered to the dead in the Çrādh ceremony. When Vallāla Sen tried to pass into society a low-caste woman named Padminī, his son Lakṣmaṅa Sen informed the Brāhmins of his action and cried it down. Vallāla in great rage dismissed Lakṣmaṅa Sen from his court, and Lakṣmaṅa in order to protect the Vaidyas from his father's ire, made them give up the sacred thread. Thus the Vaidyas who belonged to the party of Vallāla Sen and those that belonged to that of his son, became Vrātyas (fallen).

Rājā Adiçūra belonged to the Vaidya caste, but he adopted the ways of a Kṣatriya. Whoever becomes a king wants to be called a Kṣatriya, and, for his own glorification, declares himself as a Kṣatriya everywhere. Every one aspires to a higher position than he enjoys. The Devas* want the position of Brahmā the Great God. According to the Çāstras, Ādiçūra is a Brāhmin (since the Vaidyas are traceable to an original Brāhmin father), but by custom he was a Vaiçya."

The last lines account for the Sena Kings calling themselves Brāhma-Kṣatriyas in the copper-plate inscriptions.

* Minor Gods or angels.

**An indefatigable worker in the field.**

These genealogical works give us, then, in terse and epigrammatic prose and poetry, the salient points in the social history of Bengal for the last one thousand years. The Bengali scholar whose indefatigable labour has brought to light hundreds of Mss. of genealogical works in Sanskrit and Bengali, and who has drawn the attention of his fellow-countrymen to an altogether unexplored field of literature, is Babu Nagendra Nath Vasu, the learned editor of the Bengali Encyclopedia, the Viçvakoṣa.

# Supplementary Notes

TO

## CHAPTER II.

**Bengali—a form of Prākrita.**

The Bengali language was known to our early writers as a form of Prākrita. The name Vanga-Bhāṣā is of recent origin. They called it Prākrita,* or merely Bhāṣā.

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* The old Bengali writers usually designated our language as **Prākrita**. There are numerous instances of it in our old literature. A few are quoted below :—

" ভারতের পুণ্যকথা শ্রদ্ধা দূর নহে।
পরাকৃত পদবন্ধে রাজেন্দ্র দাস কহে॥"

**Ādi-Parva by Rājendra Dās.**

" তাহা অনুসারে লিখি প্রাকৃত কথনে।"

**Kriṣṇa Karṇāmrita.**

" প্রাকৃত লিখিয়া বুঝি এই মোর সাধ।"

**Govinda Līlāmrita, translated by Jadunandan Dās.**

" ইহা বলি গীতার পড়িল এক শ্লোক।
প্রাকৃত প্রবন্ধে কহি শুন সর্ব্ব লোক॥"

**Chaitanya Mangala, by Lochan Dās.**

" সপ্তদশ পর্ব্ব কথা সংস্কৃত ছন্দ।
মূর্খ বুঝিবারে কৈল পরাকৃত ছন্দ॥"

**Açvamedha Parva by Rām Chandra Khān**

In an old Bengali translation of the Gita Govinda, we come across the following lines in Sanskrit by way of conclusion of a chapter.

" ইতি শ্রীশ্রীগীতগোবিন্দে মহাকাব্যে প্রাকৃতভাষায়াং স্বাধীন-ভর্তৃকাবর্ণনে সুপ্রীতপীতাম্বরনামদ্বাদশসর্গঃ।"

**The tendency to Sanskritize Bengali.**

It has already been said in a foregoing chapter that our language, under Buddhistic influence, had lapsed into a very lax form of Prākrita, and was on that account treated with contempt by the Brāhmanic school. I have already referred to some of its chief sources of development after the downfall of Buddhism. Within the last one thousand years there has been a movement for the enrichment of our language by importing Sanskrit words, and by correcting the current forms of words according to the rules laid down in Sanskrit-grammar. Curiously enough, in this process of the resuscitation of words, our language offers a striking resemblance to the Romance languages, which also passed through a similar process, almost at the same period of history. If we look into the works noticed in the foregoing pages, this fact will be apparent. In spite of many portions of these works having been recast in subsequent times, there are numerous instances in them of words belonging to a very lax form of Prākrita, which are no longer in written use. I quote some such words below :—

কাতি—the month of Kārtika (Last half of October and first half of November), পখা—wings, নখতা—stars, পুনি—again, বগা—crane, দে—body, বিনি—without, আহ্মি—I, তুহ্মি—you, মুরূখ—a dunce, বিভা—marriage, পুষ্প—a flower, বজ্জ—thunder, দপ্পন—a mirror.

**The resusciation of words.**

The influence of the written forms of words in a literary language, is often reflected in its spoken forms, and if we study the Prākrita writings of the 5th and 6th centuries, we shall find numerous instances of লাম, দলিদ্দ, চালুদত্ত, চলন and similar words being used for রাম, দরিদ্র, চারুদত্ত, চরণ &c. These loose forms are no longer in use in any spoken

dialect of India within the knowledge of the writer of the present treatise. In the translation of the Rāmāyaṅa by Krittivāsa (born, 1432 A. D.) there is one curious passage, which he certainly did not find in the original poem of Vālmīki, referring to this process of the recovery of words from their lax Prākrita forms. Vālmīki, when he was a robber could not say রাম but pronounced the word as লাম. The sage Nārada attributed this inability to the vices that he had practised in life, and declared with much force that no vicious man would ever be able to pronounce র. This story may be understood as an instance of the way in which the later Brahmanical school attacked and overcame the loose forms of Prākrita current in the Buddhistic period. No Bengali peasant, however illiterate, would now be excused if he could not pronounce the র in রাম.

The correction of words in the written forms of our language has continued even up to the present day. Every year the correctness of a number of current words is called in question, being measured by the severe test of Sanskrit grammar. If any flaw is found in the writings of modern Bengali authors, judging by this standard of the Sanskrit grammar, he is unsparingly abused by the purists, and the Bengali language is gradually growing ornate and classical. In this respect it approaches Sanskrit as does no other language of modern India. Bengali was formerly, however, extremely colloquial.*

* That formerly the language of Bengal was the furthest removed amongst Indian languages from the standards of Sanskrit will be proved inspite of its present very highly Sanskritised form, by the fact that even now ণ, ষ & স are not rightly pronounced by us, and for this defect the Sanskrit schools of Benares, Bombay and other important centres of Sanskrit learning, treat us with contempt.

and the reactionary spirit has, perhaps for this very reason, taken an extreme form. Within the last ten years ইতিমধ্যে, সক্ষম, অজানিত, নিমগ্ন, নিরপরাধী, কলঙ্কিনী, গোপিনী, পথমধ্যে, পথভ্রান্ত, সৃজন, and similar words which were in every day use, have lost their status in the written language, because they have not been found to conform to the rules of Sanskrit.

**Bengali now a highly artificial language.**

Now Bengali is a highly artificial language. I quote here a Bengali hymn by Bhārata Chandra,—the great Bengali poet of the 18th century. One may take this as a piece of pure Sanskrit, and if written in Devnāgri characters it will be read by Sanskrit scholars all over the world as a Sanskrit poem. They will certainly be surprised to hear, that it is a Bengali poem, quoted from the Bengali work Annadā Mangala. This goes to shew to what an extent written Bengali has approached Sanskrit.

"জয় শিবেশ শঙ্কর, বৃষধ্বজেশ্বর, মৃগাঙ্কশেখর, দিগম্বর।
জয় শ্মশাননাটক, বিষাণবাদক, হুতাশভালক মহত্তর॥
জয় সুরারিনাশন, বৃষেশবাহন, ভুজঙ্গভূষণ জটাধর।
জয়ত্রিলোককারক, ত্রিলোকপালক, ত্রিলোকনাশক মহেশ্বর॥"

One word more ought to be said here regarding this process of the resuscitation of words. Several European scholars have found fault with Bengali authors for writing in a high-flown artificial style, and for their tendency to use Sanskritic words in Bengali, in place of the corresponding current forms which are intelligible to the masses.

**The causes analysed.**

We must, however, proceed to enquire why such a style is daily growing in favour with Bengali writers, if it is so artificial. No one has power to

dictate arbitrary rules for the growth of a language. This will always develop naturally inspite of opposing influences. Only so long as our efforts help the natural course, will the rules laid down by grammarians and purists be accepted by the people. Arbitrary forms may be excused, if used by a genius ; they can never, however, claim a place in common language. Language steadily changes according to its inherent requirements. It will not follow any capricious course which may be dictated by individuals. This principle applies to the written and spoken forms of a language equally.

If this view of the matter is correct, we ought to see what influences tended to develop our language after the model of Sanskrit, and how long those influences are likely to work in the future.

**The propaganda of the Paurāṅik religion familiarised Sanskrit texts.**

Though Buddhism, as we have said, gave Bengali its first impetus towards the attainment of a literary status, the Sanskritic School afterwards took it up in right earnest and set themselves to the task of embellishing it. Let us take a survey of Hindu society in its entirety, after the downfall of Buddhism. The attempts of the revivalists to introduce the spirit of Paurāṅik religion amongst the masses were directed in various channels. There were the Yatrās, or popular theatres ; Kathakatās or narratives and recitations to which we shall have to refer hereafter ; the Pāthas, or readings from Sanskrit texts ; the Kirṭanas, singing by the Vaiṣṅavas ; and other similar organised efforts to popularise the creed of the Paurāṅik religion all over Bengal. The influence of these institutions upon the popular mind was immense. No

village in Bengal, however humble it might be, was without them. Not only did they form a perennial source of amusement to the people, but they formed the mission and the propaganda of Paurāṅik religion. The whole atmosphere of Bengal was permeated by these influences; and as Sanskrit texts formed their main basis, a greater number of Sanskrit words was every day imported into Bengali and a closer contact with Sanskritic forms made the ear constantly keener in the perception of faultly expression. Thus the process of self-correction held an uninterrupted course.

**The views of foreign Scholars open to objection.**

The view generally taken by foreign scholars, that this process of Sanskritising made the litarary language incomprehensible to the masses, is not tenable. When a village yātrā, or popular theatrical performance, is going on, ploughmen, shopkeepers and other illiterate people will stand patiently for hours, witnessing the scenes. And what do they hear? নীরদবরণ, নবঘনশ্যাম, নিকুঞ্জকানন, মরাল-গামিনী, গজপতি-গতি, অকলঙ্ক-বিধু, পীতবাস, কমল-নয়ন, বিধুবদন, নীলোৎপল, মত্ত করিবর, মৃগ-পতি, হরিনাক্ষ, মনসিজ, যুগ্মনেত্র, and hundreds of such words which are never used in their current dialect, come pouring in upon their ears, and these they enjoy immensely. The Rāmāyaṅa of Krittivāsa, and the Mahābhārata of Kaçīdās are read by peasants, and artizans, and in these works learned expressions like "নিষ্কলঙ্ক বিধুমুখী পীনঘনস্তনী" are so numerous that one would wonder how the illiterate men and women who hear them recited, could appreciate them. Yet there is not the least shadow of doubt that they do so. For in Bengal 100,000 copies of the Rāmāyaṅa published from Bartalā are sold every

year, and it is doubtful if a hundredth part of these copies is sold to the *Bhadralokas* or gentlefolk.

**The people not in awe of the Sanskrit vocabulary.**

Our masses are not at all in awe of the Sanskrit vocabulary. On the other hand they seem to be in love with it. They are fond of pedantic words and when they commit mistakes in using such words in their conversation, our scholarly people smile in derision. Our Calcutta theatres have many farcical scenes in which the rural folk, attempting a high flown style, are held up to ridicule, for the inappropriate use of words. Thus the artificial style of the present day originates in a variety of causes attending the revival of Hinduism, and so long as the rich vocabulary of Sanskrit is not fully exhausted, this process of the recovery of words and the importation of choice expressions from it for literarary and technical purposes, is not likely to cease. No one would leave a precious store until it has given him all that he needs. The genius of our language moves towards the Sanskrit ideal, being attracted to it by its unparallelled wealth of expression, and until it has taken full advantage of this treasure, it is not likely to change its present course. Our learned men desire this and our rural folk desire it no less. Broad-based as is the movement of our language towards the classical model, on the natural requirements of the Paurāṇik renaissance, we cannot forcibly retard this stream.

**Anglicised Bengali troubles them.**

Our masses, as I have said, are not afraid of encountering Sanskrit words. The very nature of their environment has accustomed them to this. If the modern literature of Bengal affords them any difficulty, it is found in those modes of expression and of constructing sentences in which Bengali

follows the model of English that appears strange and unintelligible to them.

The Bengali works, to which I have referred in this chapter, mainly form what may be called a rustic literature. They were in many cases recast and revised in subsequent times, but as I have already said there are many evidences indicative of the early period to which their composition is to be referred. There are quaint terms and expressions which have not only grown obsolete but are in many cases unintelligible to us. The literature of the period shews that our language was as remote from classical Sanskrit in those days, as it is akin to it now. I quote several passages here from the works mentioned in this chapter which will illustrate these facts.

**Though recast, the works often retain earlier forms.**

**Examples.**

"শুখান কাঠে বটে কাউ।
ভান্তি দাপুনি দেখে লাউ॥
যোগী আদ্য ছু ছু কলসী।
তা দেখিলে ঘর না আসি॥
যে লাগে শেষি লাগে।
যে না লাগে শেষি লাগে॥
সাতে হাতে তিন বিগথে।
তাহার কান্দি ধরে মাথে॥
আউট হাত আউট মুঠি।
তাহার ধান্য না লড়ে ঢেকী॥"

**Dāk**

সুনার কাস্তাখানি গঠিআ জুগাল।
সাত নারিকল জলে দাখানি পানিতলে॥
মরা মিন পুনরাম্র পরাণ দান পাইল।

নামসপ্ত মারিল মিগর গাএ ॥
বনর মিগ তখন বনেত পালএ।
সবগর ভীম খেত্তীক জে হুঙ্কার পড়িল।
আসিআত ভীম খেত্তী পরণাম করিল ॥

**Çūnya Purāna**

"চিয়াও চিয়াও বুড়িমা কল যাত্রা নিনি।
কত নিদ্রা কর মা আবালের গোপিনী ॥

**Songs of Manik Chandra.**

বাওন্নি মোণী কেঁথা নিল কোমরে বান্ধিয়া।
আশী মোণী সোভা নিল কপালে ডাবিয়া ॥
নয় মণিয়া খড়ম নিল চরণে নাগাএআ।
মণ পঞ্চাশে ভাঙ্গের গুড়া মুখের মধ্যে দিআ ॥
কলসী দশেক জল দিয়া ফেলাইল গিলিআ।
আর গৈর মার গৈর তিনটা গৈর দিয়া ॥
পুটী চৌদ্দ ধুলা নিলে হিরদে মাখিআ।
ওঠেএলা হাড়িসিদ্ধা গাও মোড়া দিয়া ॥
সগ্‌গেতে ঠেকিল মাথা হুটুস্ করিআ।
চান সূজ্য থুইলে সিদ্ধা দুই কাণে ভরিয়া।

**Songs of Manik Chandra.**

**A list of obsolete words with meaning.**

Here follows a list of words, found in the books mentioned in this chapter, which have become obsolete, with their meaning. A still more complete list of such words will be found in my Bengali work—"Vanga Bhāṣā O Sāhitya."

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| অক | ... | To him. |
| অগর | ... | Aloe wood (Aquilaria agallocha). |
| অচুম্বিতের | ... | Of wonder, on a sudden. |

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| অচ্ছরের | ... | Of a scholar. |
| অফিন্ | ... | Not rooted out. |
| অস্‌স | ... | Horse. |
| অইন্তেক | ... | Many. |
| আইদ | ... | Beginning. |
| আউড়ে | ... | In a crooked way. |
| আও | ... | Sound. |
| আধার | ... | Food. |
| আনাম | ... | Air. |
| আপহর | ... | Guard, watch. |
| আপ্ত | ... | One's own. |
| আরিব্বল | ... | The span of one's life. |
| আসানড়ি | ... | A stick. |
| আসিন্যা | ... | Bath. |
| ইখু | ... | A sugar cane. |
| ঈসর | ... | God. |
| একেতন যেকতন | ... | Some how or other. |
| এলায় | ... | Now. |
| উকুল | ... | Without bank, sea. |
| উলী | ... | Good fortune. |
| কন্নি | ... | A writer. |
| কাঞ্জী | ... | Small. |
| কুশলানী | ... | A well-wisher. |
| কেওদা | ... | Fat. |
| খচরা | ... | Those that move in the air. |
| গতি | ... | Followers. |
| গাভুর | ... | Strong, youthful. |
| গাবুরাণী | ... | Youthfulness. |
| গিরি | ... | House. |
| গাএন | ... | The chief singer in a chorus. |
| গোঁধলা | ... | Cow-dung. |
| ছামুর | ... | Of the front. |
| ছুছু | ... | Empty |
| জীউ | ... | Long live. |

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| জ্ঞাস্তা | ... | Agnates. |
| ঝোলাঙ্গা | ... | A wallet. |
| ডকবুস | ... | A big cudgell. |
| ডহর | ... | Low marshy lands. |
| ডারুকা | ... | A sort of chain. |
| ডারিয়া | ... | By binding. |
| ডাম্বাডোল | ... | A great tumult and uproar. |
| ডেবাডোরা | ... | To proclaim by beat of drum. |
| তাঁউল | ... | Rice. |
| তেতকে | ... | So much. |
| দায় | ... | Character, name. |
| দামরা | ... | Drum. |
| দোন | ... | Two. |
| দিব্ব | ... | A thing. |
| দুআরপাল<br>দুআরী | ... | Gate-keeper. |
| দুহি | ... | Two. |
| ধওল | ... | White. |
| ধিরকালি | ... | A musical instrument. |
| ধেআনে | ... | In contemplation. |
| নঅদিব | ... | Navadwip. |
| নঠ | ... | Spoiled. |
| নিন্দ | ... | Sleep. |
| নিতে | ... | Without. |
| নিত | ... | Dance. |
| নিল্লঅ | ... | To ascertain. |
| নেয়াই | ... | Right. |
| পটা | ... | Plank. |
| পইতায় | ... | To Believe. |
| পোখরি | ... | Pond. |
| পাহাড় | ... | Bank. |
| পয়দল | ... | Foot Soldiers. |
| বারুণ | ... | A broom. |
| বুন্দা | ... | A Drizzle. |

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| বম্ভ | ... | Bramha. |
| বাঅতি | ... | One who plays on a musical instrument. |
| বাজ্জ | ... | A musical instrument. |
| বেআলি | ... | Difference. |
| ভুসঙ্গ | ... | Ashes. |
| মাও | ... | Mother. |
| মধুকর | ... | A big boat. |
| মাল্লি | ... | Food. |
| মাড়াল | ... | Path. |
| মিঠ | ... | Sweet. |
| মুর্চ্ছল | ... | A musical instrument. |
| ঘেটে | ... | To the place. |
| লহড় | ... | A run. |
| সয়ল | ... | All. |
| সমাধে | ... | To understand. |
| সানে | ... | To Sign. |
| সাঁও | ... | A snake. |
| সেঁওয়ালী | ... | Pertaining to evening. |
| হীন | ... | Without. |

**Bengali verbs.**

Bengali verbs are easily traced to those of Prākrita. From হোই, পড়ই, কিনই, করই, বোলই, পচ্চই, ফুট, গাঅ, খাঅ, বুজঝ, চিন, জান, লগ্‌গ, পুচ্ছ &c., the transformation is easily made to হয়, পড়ে, কেনা, করে, বলে, নাচে, ফোটা, গাওয়া, থাকা, বুঝা, চেনা, জানা, লাগা, পোঁছা &c.

The participle forms in Prākrita শুনিঅ, লভিঅ, লই, করিঅ pass through slight changes in Bengali. Prākrita অচ্ছি changed to আছি and আছে, joins itself to other verbs, and forms the origin of the present participle in Bengali. Such forms as করিয়া + আছে, করিয়াছে, করেছে and কচ্ছে are thus accounted for. The Sanskrit form আসীৎ, changed to the Bengali

আছিল forms in the same manner the suffix of Bengali verbs in the past tense, such as করিয়া + আছিল, করিয়াছিল, and দেখিয়া + আছিল, দেখিয়াছিল etc. In the backward villages of Bengal the two words are still often used separately in the present participle forms, such as করিতে—আছে, খাইতে—আছে। There are numerous instances of Prākrita and Sanskrit forms of verbs being used in the works which we have dealt with in this chapter. Such for instance as করোসি, যায়ন্তি, বলন্তি &c., We quote some examples below :—

1. ইষ্ট দেবতা যেহ পূজসি। Dâk.
2. পরণাম করিয়া হংস বলন্তি সেইকালে।

**Çūnya Purāṅa**

These forms are now quite obsolete in Bengali.*

The Sanskrit forms করোমি and কুর্ব্বঃ have both been adopted in Bengali, subject to certain changes. In Eastern Bengal করুম (a form of করোমি) is in colloquial use. Western Bengal favoured the form করিব = কর্ব্ব (from কুর্ব্বঃ); and many instances of both are found in old literature. We quote a few lines below to shew the use of করিবু

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* In later works written in the 15th, 16th & 17th centuries instances of such use were numerons,—as in

1. "ভিক্ষুকের কন্যা তুমি কহিস আমারে।"

**Mahābhārata by Sañjaya.**

2. "নির্ভয়ে বোলেন্ত তবে সংগ্রাম ভিতর।"

**Viṣma Parva by Kavindra.**

3. বড় বড় বৈষ্ণব তার দর্শনেতে যান্তি।

**Caitanya Charitāmrita.**

4. হিরণ্যকশিপু মারি পিবন্তি রুধির।

**Çri Kriṣṇa Vijaya.**

(a form of কুর্ব্বঃ). The various forms derived from করোমি are very frequently met with in old Bengali Literature.

1. "নিতি নিতি অপরাধ করে। বলে ভাক কি করিবু তারে॥"

Dâk.

2. পৈরাগ মাধব নহি কি করিবু বিচার।"

Çûnya Pûrâṅa.

করিবু is changed to করিব and this form has been adopted in written Bengali both in Eastern and Western Bengal. The appearance of ক in হউক, যাউক, খাউক etc. is difficult to account for. Dr. Grierson traces it to Sanskrit কিম্. In old Bengali, there are frequent uses of verbs without this familiar suffix, as in,—

1. "জীউ, জীউ রায়ত ধর্ম্ম দিউক বর।"

**Mânik Chandra Râjâr Gân.**

2. "জয় হউ তোর যত ভকত সমাজ।"

**Chaitanya Bhâgabat.**

The verbal termination হ in the old imperative forms করিহ, যাইহ (changed to করিও, যাইও) is traced to Sanskrit হি; and examples of হি changed to হ are numerous in Prâkritâ. The হি often changes to হুঁ in Prâkrita, as in মইন্দ করেহুঁ in Pingal. This হুঁ forms a suffix of verbs in Hindi.

**Softening of words.**

In Bengali and in Prâkrita, words are generally softened,

(1) by changing the double letter to a single one. The long vowel আ in such cases is introduced to coalesce with the preceding letter, as হস্তি=হাতি, হস্ত=হাত, সপ্ত=সাত, কক্ষ=কাখ, মল্ল=মাল,

বজ্জ=বাজ, হট্ট=হাট, অষ্ট=আট, কর্ণ=কাণ, কজ্জল=কাজল, অক্ষি=আখি, ভল্লুক=ভালুক,—sometimes the long vowel আ also joins with the last letter, as ছত্র=ছাতা, চক্র=চাকা, চন্দ্র=চাঁদা, পক্ক=পাকা, পত্র=পাতা। There are also instances of the vowel আ of the termination being dropped as লজ্জা=লাজ, সজ্জনা=সাজ, ঢক্কা=ঢাক।

(2) By elision of a letter, as

(ক elided,) সুবর্ণকার=সোনার, চর্ম্মকার=চামার, কর্ম্মকার=কামার, কুম্ভকার=কুমার, নৌকা=নাও or না।

(খ elided), মুখ=মু।

(গ) দ্বিগুণ=দুনো, ভগিণী=বহিন=বোন।

(ত) ভ্রাতা=ভাই, মাতা=মা, শত=শ।

(দ) হৃদয়=হিয়া, কদলী=কলা।

(ভ) নাভি=নাই, গাভী=গাই।

(ম) গ্রাম=গাঁ।

ট and ড of Sanskrit words often change to ড় in their corresponding Bengali forms, and ধ to জ or ঝ; as ঘোটক=ঘোড়া, ঘট=ঘড়া, চণ্ডাল=চাড়াল, ষণ্ড=ষাঁড়, ভাণ্ড=ভাড়, উপাধ্যায়=ওঝা, সন্ধ্যা=সাঁজ, মধ্য=মাঝ.

**Bengali case-affixes.**

The case-affix in Bengali of the nominative (first person, singular) is generally formed by omitting the aspirate or the nasal ং of Sanskrit. The affix এন of the Sanskrit instrumental nominative, is reduced to এ in Prākrita and used in active forms; as "শুঅণেহ ভিচ্চাণকম্পকে শামীএ নিদ্ধণকেবি শোহেদি" (Mricchakatika, Canto III). Instances of this এ forming the affix of nominatives in active forms are numerous in old Bengali Mss., as :—

**The nominative case.**

1. "শুনিয়া রাজাএ বোলে হইয়া কৌতুক।"

**Sañjoy.**

2. "কোনমতে বিধাতাএ করিছে নির্ম্মাণ।"

**Rameçwar's Mahābhārata.**

In the current dialect of Bengal this এ is often used as রাজাএ ডাকিয়াছে, বাঘে ধরিয়াছে, &c. It is to be noted that the Bengali sentences, in active forms owe their construction rather to Sanskrit passive forms. The difference in the dual and plural numbers is not preserved in Prākrita. The usual affix in the plural forms being 'আ'. কুশলবা for কুশলবৌ, পুত্তআ for পুত্রাঃ and like forms are frequently found in Prākrita. In old Bengali also আ forms the affix of the nominative plural; as in :—

" নরা গজা বিশে শয়।
তার আধেক বাচে হয়॥
বাইশ বলদা তের ছাগলা।"

**Khanā.**

Trump traces the কে of the Bengali accusative to the Sanskrit কৃতে, used in the locative. But Max-muller's view, tracing কে to the Sanskrit pleonastic ক, is evidently correct. In the Gāthā and Prākrita languages the instances of the affix ক used pleonastically are so numerous, that sometimes we find it occurring in many words in a sentence—as in the Lalita Vistāra :—

**The Bengali accusative.**

সুবসন্তকে ঋতুবরে অগতকে।
রতিমে প্রিয়া ফুল্লিত পাদপকে॥
বশবর্ত্তী সুলক্ষণকো বিচিত্রিতকো।
তবরূপ সুরূপ সুশোভনকো॥
বয়ং জাত সুজাত সুসংস্থিকাঃ।
সুখ কারণ দেবনারাণ বসন্ততিকাঃ॥
উথি লযু পরিভুঞ্জ সুযৌবনকং।
দুর্লভ বোধি নিবর্ত্তয় মানসকং॥

Where the affix ক forms the termination of words in both nominative and accusative forms, it often becomes difficult to distinguish between the two. In sentences,—like,

"সৌরীন্দ্রক কীচক বলএ ততক্ষণ."

Kavīndra.

a doubt may naturally occur as to who the person addressed is. It is, therefore, probable that for avoiding this difficulty, the form কে was adopted to denote the accusative and dative cases. In the Gāthā and Prākrita languages instances of the affix কে in the accusative and dative cases are not wanting, as in—

"পালিও আহু দাসীএপুত্তে দলিদ্দ চালুদত্তাকে তুমং।"

Mricchakatika, 8th Canto.

The pleonastic ক formerly served as the mere termination of a word and was not reckoned as a case-affix. Hence in old Bengali this কে is often affixed to words in various cases; as in "মথুরাকে পাঠাইল রূপ সনাতন।" (Chaitanya Charitāmrita) and "কাঁধকে রুমাল করি হাসয়ে মুরারি" (Çrikrishna Vijaya), where it forms the termination of the words in the locative case.

**The plural number.**

In old Bengali writings, সব, সকল, গুটি and similar words were generally used to denote the plural number. The word "আদি" (beginning with) was also often used with a noun to imply plurality. The following extract from Narottama Vilāsa will shew numerous instances of the use of আদি in the above manner.

"শ্রীচৈতন্যদাস আদি যথা উত্তরিলা।
শ্রীনৃসিংহ কবিরাজে তথা নিয়োজিলা॥

শ্রীপতি শ্রীনিধি পণ্ডিতাদি বাসা ঘরে।
করিলেন নিযুক্ত, শ্রীবাস আগার্যোরে॥
আকাই হাটের কৃষ্ণদাসাদি বাসায়।
হইলা নিযুক্ত শ্রীবল্লভী কান্ত রায়॥

The genitive forms.

The genitive sign র being affixed to পণ্ডিতাদি, কবিরাজাদি forms পণ্ডিতাদির, কবিরাজাদির, and the current genitive forms পণ্ডিতদের, কবিরাজদের are thus easily explained. The pleonastic affix ক is often found to be joined with পণ্ডিতাদি, কবিরাজাদি &c. In the Narottama Vilāsa we find

"রাম চন্দ্রাদিক যৈছ গেলা বৃন্দাবনে।
কবিরাজ খ্যাতি তার হইল যেমনে॥"

This দিক is changed to দিগ and we may thus account for দিগর and দিগের—formed by joining the genitive affix র to the above words. Some Bengali scholars are, however, of opinion that the genitive plural "দিগের" comes directly from the Persian 'দিগর'.

The current Bengali form in Eastern Bengal in the genitive plural is, however, formed not by affixing 'দিগের' but by 'গো' or 'গোর' to the words. The forms আমাগোর, তোমাগোর, তানগোর, রামগোর, are no doubt derived by the genitive post-position র being affixed to the pleonastic 'ক' changed to গ.

The instrumental case.

There can scarcely be said to be any particular affix in Bengali to denote the instrumental case. The Sanskrit রামেন changes to রামএ. I have said that the Bengali active forms were akin to the Sanskrit passive voice. The sentences 'কুড়ালে পা কাটিয়াছে' 'রাজায় বলিয়াছে,' still in current use in different parts of Bengal, shew how the construction of the Sanskrit passive changes into Bengali active forms.

**The dative case.**

There is no difference in Bengali between the dative and the accusative cases, the affix কে being used for both.

**Ablative case.**

The Prākrita sign for the ablative case is হিংতো. The Bengali হইতে is derived from হিংতো. In old Bengali we find this word to be হন্তে, as in,—"হাড় হন্তে নির্ম্মিয়া করয় পুনি হাড়" (Padmāvatī by Āloāl), and often as হনে, as in,—"সেই হনে প্রাণ মোর আছে বা না জানি।" (Sañjaya).

**The genitive case.**

The genitive post-position ণ of Prākrita changes to র in Bengali. In the place of Prākrita অগ্গীণ we have Bengali অগ্নির; ণ often changes to 'ড়' or 'র' and and examples of this are numerous in the Uriyā dialect. Bopp, however, considers the genitive affix র to have been derived from the Sanskrit affix ক in the genitive plural froms as অস্মাকম্, যুষ্মাকম্ &c. Dr. Hœrnle traces this র to Sanskrit কৃত, changed into কেরক, কের, কর and other forms in the Prākrita and Hindi dialects. Rājā Rājendra Lāl is of opinion that the Bengali র comes from the Sanskrit genitive affix স্য.

**The locative case.**

The locative তে in Bengali is probably to be traced to the Sanskrit স্তসিল,—The locative in Bengali is often the same as in Sanskrit, as গহনে, কাননে, গৃহে &c. Sanskrit শালায়াং, বেলায়াং, ভূম্যাং &c. changes to শালাত্র, বেলায়, ভূমিএ &c. and in old Bengali such forms were in general use. In modern Bengali the এ changes to য়।

**Asāmese, Uriyā and Bengali.**

Let us say a word regarding Āsāmese and Uriyā in relation to Bengali, the three now forming distinct languages. Before the first Bengali grammar was written by Mr. Halhead, Bengali—which was called "Gaudiya Sādhū Bhāsā" by the people—presented different provincial dialects even in literary

compositions. The same author's works were read all over a vast tract of country, which geographically transcended the limits of Modern Bengal and the Eastern Provinces. But words were changed by those who copied the manuscripts, conformably to the dialectical peculiarities of each district, so that one reads 'লাফ' in the old manuscripts of Krittivāsa found in Western Bengal where লাফ would be the usual form in a manuscript of the same work, recovered from the Eastern Provinces. The Vaiṣṇava works written in Bengali found readers in Orissā and Āssām. The people of those countries occasionally changed words in those works to suit the peculiar forms of their dialects. Many Bengali works have lately been found in manuscript forms in Orissā. Bengali, therefore, in the various forms charecteristic of provincial dialects presented a literature which used to be read and written by the people of a vast area bounded by the sea on the South,—extending to the Himalayan forests on the North of Old Gauḍa,—stretching so far as Magadha and Mithila in the West and reaching to the backwoods of Āssām and the out-skirts of Burmā on the East. The differences of dialect described, could have been easily synthetised by a common grammar, including Āssāmese, Uriyā and Bengali in one group. Bengali, recognised as the most advanced language in Eastern India, and fast assimilating the forms of different provincial dialects, for the purpose of propagating the Vaiṣṇava creed, might have been taken as the common vehicle for the expression of the thought of these three provinces; and in fact on the principle of natural selection, it had already, before the

beginning of the nineteenth century, advanced its claim towards that end. But Āsāmese and Uriyā have now alienated themselves from Bengali. The people of those provinces declare that they possess a distinct literature of their own which is as old as Bengali literature; and indeed they do. The people of Chittagong, Tippera and Sylhet also possess old literatures stamped with provincialism of dialect, which now form a valuable part of our literature; but which are by no means any way nearer, in style and form, to the old literature of the Burdwan and Bānkurā districts, than are Āsamese and Uriyā. The vanity of preserving the peculiarities of a small province may be natural amongst its own people, but it does not indicate a healthy state of feeling. The literary language of England has now reached a wonderful development because the American, the Irish, the Scotch and the Australian have all adopted it. There is no want of peculiarities and dialectical differences in the forms of this language as spoken in those countries; but these differences of the spoken language are not recognised in writing, and all these countries have submitted to a single grammar. The language has thus gathered strength from the co-operation of its votaries who recognise this unity in their literature, though politically many of them are not under the same yoke. Here is a passage which I quote as a specimen of the spoken dialect of Chittagong. No Bengali of the Western districts would understand a line of it and in the peculiar from which it exhibits, it would appear more remote from current Bengali than is Uriyā or Āsāmese.

From an advertisement on a patent medicine.

# বলী খেলার কথা।

## রহিম ও করিম।

রহিম। [করিমকে দেখিয়া] ছালাম মাউঁ, কঁড়ে যাওর ?

করিম। এক্কানা বলীখেলা চাইতাম্ যাইর। তুঁয়ি কঁড়ে যাওর ?

রহিম। আঁয়ি বক্সীর হাডর হৃদয়ডাক্তারের দোয়ানং পোয়ার লাঙ্গি কিরমাইর দাবাই আইন্‌তাম্ যাইর।

করিম। ইবা কেঁয়ন দাবাই? বড় নাম হুনির; পরখ্ করি ন চাই।

রহিম। ওম্-মারে-মা! ইবা দাবাই না! ইবা বড় গম দাবাই। আঁর খাল্‌ত ভাইর পোয়ার লাঙ্গি এক আনা দি এক পুর্গ্যা নিঃ খাবাইলাম যে, আজ্জের আন্দাজ চীর বাইর হঙ্গিল্। বাজার্গ্যা বৌৎ দাবাই নি খাবাই চাই কোন ফল ন হয়। ইবা খাবাই বড় বেশী ফুল পাঙ্গি। আর এক কথা জাননি? ইবার লেগে দোছরা জোলাপ ন লাগে। আর গুরা পোয়ারে খাবাইতে কন ডর নাই।

করিম। দাবাইর কি নাম কইলা যে?

রহিম। ইবার নাম "ক্রিমি-বিজয়।" দাম এক পুর্গ্যা এক আনা।

করিম। দাবাই খানার কি নাম কইলা যে?

রহিম। কোহিনুর মেডিকেল হল.—বক্সীর হাডত্ হৃদয় ডাক্তারের দোয়ান আরি মিঞা! যিঁয়ত ওগগা মড়া মাইন্‌ষ্যর ঠাড্ লট্‌কাই দিয়ীল, হেই দোয়ানং।

করিম। ও—হিঁয়ত না? আঁয়িও বলিখেলাত্তুন ফিরিবার ওক্তত্ মাইয়ার লাই এক পুর্গ্যা ফাঁকি লই যাইয়ম্।

রহিম। ছালাম মাউঁ।

[উভয়ের প্রস্থান।]

Yet the people of Chittagong are proud of Bengali which they acknowledge as their mother-tongue; and some of our greatest modern poets, writers, and speakers, come from that district. Unity in language, as in all other matters, contributes to the glory of our national life, and this point should not be ignored by our brethren who speak only different forms of the same language.

# CHAPTER III.

## I. CHANDĪ DĀS. II. VIDYĀPATI.

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### I—Chandī Dās.

The poems of Chandī-dās and Vidyāpati contrasted with other vernacular writings of the age.

The Bengali works to which we have referred in the last chapter, scarcely rise to the level of of decent literature. They were composed by peasants and villagers, and these were the people who loved to read them and hear them recited. This fact must be held to account for their somewhat gross turn of humour. Our language, as I have said in the first chapter, was greatly stimulated by the attention it received from the Moslem Sovereigns of Gauḍa with their inevitably anti-Sanskritic culture. But it possessed inherent qualities of its own which were bound to have been recognised in course of time, even if chance had not brought the Mahammadans to this country. With poets like Chandi Dās and Vidyāpati, the vernaculars of Bengal and Behar could not long have been allowed to languish in the cold shade of Brahmanical disdain. These songs revealed its innate stength and gave unmistakable proof of its capacity to express the highest thoughts of the human mind. At the very time when rural folk were amusing themselves by a display of coarse wit in halting rhyme;—when no better themes than the plough, the furrow and the rice-field were to be found for the awakening of poetic inspiration; when the tales of the Siddhas—and their powers were being sung in the villages, and gave the same amus-

ment to illiterate people as fairy tales do to children; at that very period of fantastic and uncouth composition,—now more valued for philological and historical considerations than for any intrinsic poetic merits,—the vernaculars of Bengal and Behar were suddenly lit up by the rays of two brilliant stars, the precursors of an illustrious host who appeared on our literary horizon with the advent of Chaitanya Deva in the sixteenth century.

In order to understand the subjects treated by these two poets, one should first know what Parakīyā Rasa is.

**Parakīyā Rasa.**

Parakīyā Rasa which is sometimes identified with Madhura Rasa, forms the essence of the Vaiṣṇava theology. It is akin to the Sahajiā cult, which, as explained in a previous chapter, means the romantic worship of a woman other than one's own wife. By a strange combination of circumstances, this form of idialism, though to the Hindu mind it seems lawless and unhallowed, rapidly attained a highly spiritual form in Bengal. In a country where the portals of the Zenana remain ever closed to the outside world,—where in the words of a Bengali poet, "the rays of the sun may not touch and even the moon is not allowed to see the fair one"—in such an environment as that of the Hindu household, society admits of no opportunity for the free meeting of men and women. Yet human nature is every where the same, and here as elsewhere stringent social rules are ineffective to defeat the impulse of personal choice and romantic love. The greater the opposition, the stronger is the impulse which cries for

expression. In this country a blind Providence joins the hands of a mute pair who promise fidelity, often without knowing each other. When the situation grows monotonous, losing colour and poetry, both men and women are treated to lectures on the purity of the nuptial vow, and to promises of rewards in the next world. They fully believe in the sanctity of marriage, and are ready to sacrifice sentiment to stern duty. But human passion cannot be altogether repressed, and where it over-rides the ordinances of the Çastras, it rushes forward with extraordinary strength, all the greater for the attempt at forcible suppression.

**The feelings approach spirituality.**

The Parakiya presents insurmountable difficulties in this country. Those who love have scarcely a chance of meeting; they may long for the sight of one another's faces, yet this good fortune not be theirs for days and weeks together. There are numerous descriptions of the romantic feelings which this peculiar situation creates, in the Vaiṣṇava songs. Here are a few short extracts:—

"If he happens to see a single letter that forms my name, he pores over it in an ecstasy of joy."*

"He wanders about like a mad man and kisses the prints of my feet."†

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* "আমার নামের একটি আখর পাইলে হরসে লেয়।"

Rāiçekhar

† "পদ চিহ্ন চুম্বয়ে কাণ।"

Govinda Dās.

"If he hears my name incidentally mentioned by any, his face is lit up with strange emotion and in vain does he try to hide the joy."*

In cases where this feeling has arisen, and the persons concerned possess noble moral qualities—social and moral barriers continuing to exercise their full power, it is easy to see that the highest romantic idealism is the inevitable result. We then find that the very restrictions imposed, only accentuate the poetry of the passion. There is nothing which the lovers are not prepared to lay on the alter of this their highest dream. Such love is the nearest approach in cammon life to the mystic longings of the devotee's soul, for the realisation of God; and in fact, in the purity of its sentiment, and in its capacity for devotion and selfsacrifice, it approaches spirituality. Hence Vaiṣṇavism in Bengal adopted Parakīya as a symbol for the representation of divine love. Rādhā, the Princess, daughter of king Vriṣa Bhānu and wife of Āyān Ghoṣa, falls in love with Kriṣṇa—the shepherd boy. But Rādhā is thought of by Vaiṣṇavas as the human soul and Kriṣṇa as the incarnation of the Love of god. From this story every suspicion of grossness is understood to be eliminated, and the drama played out amidst the pastoral scenery of the banks of the Jumna, conveys only the purity and holiness of a hymn of worship.

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* "পরসঙ্গে নাম শুনি দরবয়ে হিয়া,
পুলক ঢাকিতে নানা করে পরকার।"

Chandidās.

Chandī Dās and Vidyāpati followed Jay Deva, and took this allegory for the expression in the vernacular of the highest form of the spiritual ideal.

**Chandī-dās's life.**

From a reference* given in one of Chandī Dās's poems, it appears that before 1403 A.D. he had composed 996 songs. He was born in the village of Chhātnā in the district of Birbhum, but in early life, settled at the neighbouring village of Nānnura, ten miles to the south-east of Bolpur—a station on the East Indian Railway. The site of his home—now reduced to a mere mound—is still to be seen at Nānnura, where he discharged priestly functions in the temple of Vāçulī Devī. This temple collapsed in course of time, and a new one has lately been built on the old site where the goddess Vāçulī is still worshipped.

**'Mad Chandi.'**

Chandī Dās, in the popular estimation was one of those souls who turn love-mad. In Eastern Bengal a man of eccentric tendencies is somtimes called 'পাগলা চণ্ডী' or 'a mad Chandī.' The word 'পাগলা' or 'mad fellow' is not rightly translated by the bold English word 'mad,'—for in Bengali it is tinged with a feeling of tenderness. 'পাগলা চণ্ডী' and 'পাগলা নিমাই' are adored by the people of Bengal. The epithet 'পাগলা' is akin to 'Dewānā' in Persian. They imply the poetic excesses of a great genius and are far from being terms of contempt.

**Chandidās & Rāmi.**

We have already alluded to Chandī Dās's love for Rāmi, the washerwoman. At Nānnura there is a spot which is pointed out as the site of Rāmī's

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* বিধুর নিকট নেত্র পক্ষ পঞ্চবাণ।
নবহুঁ নবহুঁ রস ইহ পরিমাণ॥ Chandīdās.

home-stead. The way in which the poet first fell in love, as related by the people of the locality, is curious. By one of those echoes from the future which are heard by the human mind, on that very day in his life when the stars were set for his meeting with Rāmī, he had a foregleam of his coming experiences in love. He had gone to purchase fish in the market. There he offered a certain price to a fish-wife for the fish he wished to buy, but at that very moment she gave a greater quantity for the same price to another; Chandī Dās was struck by this inequality of treatment and asked the fisher-woman's reason. She smiled and said "Oh, but his case is altogether different. We love each other!" Chandī Dās stood silent for sometime, brooding over this reply. The sweetness of such a feeling attracted him, and it so happened that on that very day, Rāmī, the young washerwoman, in all the beauty of her maiden-hood came into his sight and he fell over head and ears in love with her.

**Declared fallen from the Brahminic order.**

The result was disastrous from a worldly point of view. He was a Brāhmin and the washerwoman could take only the dust of his feet. Any other relation between them was not to be tolerated by society. Chandī Dās has told us in his songs that his love for Rāmī was pure, there being in it no element of passion. In his devotion to his lady, however, he would not now brook any restraint. He openly avowed his love in songs, and remained absorbed in a sort of reverie, neglecting the duties of his priestly calling. The love of Tasso for Leonara or even of Dante for Beatrice can scarcely lay claim to comparison with the martyrdom endured

by this Bengali poet for the lady of his heart. His songs, though in one of them he addresses Rāmī as "mother," were considered very offensive by Hindu Society, and he was excommunicated, and dismissed from his office in the temple of Vāçulī being proclaimed by beat of drum as fallen from the Brāhmanic order. A Brāhmin in love with a washerwoman! It was monstrous, and as if he had been a putrid corpse, all contact with him was declared unholy.

**Nakul intercedes.**

Now Chandī Dās had a brother named Nakula, who enjoyed great popularity with the Brāhmin community. By his earnest intervention on behalf of his brother it was settled, though after repeated opposition, that Chandī Dās could be taken back into caste, if he would give an undertaking of good conduct in future and provide a feast for the Brāhmins. Nakula arranged the feast, and when the Brāhmins assembled at the dinner party, information reached Rāmī, the washerwoman, that Chandī Dās was being restored to caste on the promise of deserting her for ever. She fainted at the news, and when consciousness returned, began to weep, in violent paroxysms of grief. In great agony, she went to the Vokul groves where she had so often waited to catch a glimpse of Chandī Dās's face. But she could not by any means control her feeling and rest here; she went onward to the place where the invited party were partaking of the banquet served for them. She gazed at Chandidās and tears flowed from her eyes in unceasing stream. Never before had Rāmī looked in public upon the face of Chandidās!

**Rāmī and the wonderful vision about her.**

Chandīdās forgot all the promises he had given to the Brahmins and in the worshipful manner of a priest, who approaches his house-hold goddess, appeared before her craving a thousand pardons. It is said that a wonderful vision was at this moment vouchsafed to only a few of the assembled Brahmins. They saw the four arms of the Divine mother of the universe shining forth, behind the supposed washerwoman !

**Holy as the Gayatri**

But the rest oft he Brahmins were very angry, and Chandīdās remained an outcast as before. His boldness became far greater now. He openly addressed Rāmī as বেদমাতা গায়ত্রি—Gayatri the mother of the Vedas ! Imagine the folly of this comparison ! Gayatri the great hymn of the Brahmins is to them the holiest thing on earth or in heaven. For a Brahmin to say, therefore, that a washerwoman was as holy in his eyes as the Gayatri, was an affront to the whole orthodox community, the degree of which can scarcely be conceived by one outside the pale of Hindu society. But Chandīdās had meant no more offence than a bird in its warblings ; in the fulness of his heart the mouth had spoken. In his dreams of love, thoughts of caste, of Brāhminhood or of any other earthly consideration had no place.*

**Chandīdās's death.**

Chandīdās met with a tragic death. While he was amusing his audience by a recitation of his love-songs in the house of a friend at the village of Kirṇahar near Nānnura, the roof of the house is said to have collapsed ; and the great poet who had

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* For some of Chandī Dās's Songs on Rāmi, see. pp, 43—44.

suffered so much because of his love, passed away from the earth.

**The subjects of his poems.**

I have said that love in its most abstract and refined form was the theme of Candīdās's songs. His poems on Rādhā and Kriṣṇa fall under the classification usual to the love-poems of the Vaiṣṇavas. The Pūrva Rāga or dawn of love; Dautya or message of love; Abhisāra or secret going-forth, and Sambhoga-milana or meeting of the lovers, Māthur or the final separation, caused by Kriṣṇa's going to Mathurā; Bhava-sanmilana or union in spirit, and so forth.

**Kriṣṇa and Rādhā.**

Kriṣṇa is the Divine Incarnation worshipped by the Vaiṣṇavas. He is represented as having a dark blue complexion. Dark blue suggests the predominating colour of the universe. We find it in the azure, in sky and ocean, in distant landscapes and in the immense verdure of pastoral meadows. On the head of Kriṣṇa is a crown of flowers and a plume of peacock's feathers reminding us of the rainbow. This symbolizes the various colours which adorn the main dark-blue pervading the earth and the sky. He has a flute in his hand, and when he plays on it, the very Jumna bends out of her course signifying that with a person who has heard the call of his God, the result is irrestible, the course of his life is sure to change. The human soul is symbolized in Rādhā, the soul that, with its five finer senses, becomes instinct with new life, the moment God appears to it in all His glory.

**A further analysis of the subject.**

This is how the enlightened Vaiṣṇavas interpret the love of Rādhā and Kriṣṇa. Let us explain this idea a little more elaborately. The devout Vaiṣṇava believes that there is no paradise higher

than the home, with all the social relationships which centre there. To take the motherly instinct first; when the child was helpless and entirely dependent on mercy, who gave it food? Who watched over it and protected it with the utmost care? It was the mother. Now a Vaiṣṇava, would say that it was not in the power of a frail woman to undergo such sacrifices; it was God's mercy needed for the protection of the helpless child that manifested itself in her motherly love. So the Vaiṣṇavas see Him in the mother. This is বাৎসল্য-ভাব.' But this has also another aspect; when a man is made a father, he,—rough, rude-tempered, cruel man, becomes tenderness itself at the sight of the baby. Now such kindness was not inherent in his nature: and the Vaiṣṇava sees in the child, who can evoke these feelings, the love of God Himself. So in friendship also, which is called 'সখ্য'; in the devotion of a servant, which is called 'দাস্য' or in শান্ত that quietness of soul which is attained by the elders of the family, living the life of the religious recluse, we have only other forms of the realization of divinity. Thus, the Vaiṣṇava's environment throbs with a new life as he becomes conscious of divine love, and realizes the presence of God everywhere. His social and domestic ties only bind him with his god and in the voices of affection all around, he discovers the loving call of Him who wants all souls to come near Him, but whose voice is not heard by ears deafened with the tumult of the world.

'Vatsalya Bhāba.'

'Sakhya' 'Dāsya' and 'Çānta.'

But higher than any where else is the manifestation of God known to us in the love of man and woman. This embodies in itself the quintessence of

Madhur Bhāba

all lofty emotions. This is the মধুরভাব which Chandi Dās has expressed so beautifully in his songs. In all this, a clue will be found to the point of view which accepts the love songs of the Vaiṣṇavas—displaying, as these do, every form of intrigue and passionate idealism, between man and woman—as hymns of religious adoration.

**The dark-blue complexion of Kriṣṇa.**

In Chandī Dās's 'dawn of love,' Kriṣṇa appears before the mind of Rādhā as a spritual vision. She has caught a glimpse of his dark-blue complexion. It has acted on her almost like some infatuation. She sits alone—lost in thought. The poet says* :—

"O what pain has overtaken Rādhā! She likes solitude. She sits alone, and will listen to none. Pensive, she looks up to the sky and watches the clouds, her eyes do not move. She wants no food. She wears the yellow garb of a nun and looks like one. She unlooses the garlands from her hair, and pores over the beauty of her own dis-hevelled locks. With longing eyes, she beholds the clouds and stretching out her hands, what

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* রাধার কি হৈল অন্তর ব্যাথা।
সে যে বসিয়া একলে, থাকয়ে বিরলে
না শুনে কাহার কথা।
সদাই ধেয়ানে, চাহে মেঘ পানে
না চলে নয়নের তারা।
বিরতি আহারে, রাঙ্গা বাস পরে
যেমন যোগীনী-পারা।
এলাইয়া বেণী, ফুলের গাথনি
দেখয়ে খসায়ে চুলি।

does she say to them? Her glance becomes fixed on the neck of the peacock. Love for Kriṣṇa, says Chandī Dās, has dawned on her heart."

Love for Kriṣṇa—the shepherd god, who wears the crown of peacock's feathers,—Kriṣṇa, whose beautiful dark-blue colour so soothes the eyes! It is this which accounts for her reveries about the clouds, her own hair, and the neck of the peacock, referred to in the poem. All alike remind her of Kriṣṇa. She drinks deep of their beauty. She is indifferent to her physical comfort. She fasts and lives like a holy maiden—a Yoginī, we find in the lines! It is a strange abstract love, and symbolises also the spiritual love of the Vaiṣṇavas! For this dark-blue complexion, as I have said, is taken to mirror the pervading colour of the Infinite, and, as an emblem of the divine presence, is sacred to all Vaiṣṇavas. Many a time and oft it is told of Chaitanya Deva, the God-man of Nadia that he saw the dark-blue clouds, reminding him of God and swooned away in an ecstasy of love. To him the very contact with matter conveyed a spiritual idea. The objects of the senses were mere signs of the presence of One who was above the senses; form indicated in his eyes the formless, colour, the colourless, and all knowledge of the outword world,—the great Unknowable. This is the

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আকুল নয়নে, চাহে মেঘ পানে
কি কহে দুহাত তুলি ॥
এক দিঠি করি, ময়ূর ময়ূরী
কণ্ঠ করে নিরক্ষণে।
চণ্ডীদাস কয়, নব পরিচয়
কালিয়া বধুর সনে ॥

distinctive characteristic of Indian thought. It has a constant tendency towards idealization. The river Jumnā and the village Vrindāvana will be found on any Indian map. They are sanctified in the eyes of ordinary Vaiṣṇavas. To them Kriṣṇa lived in the flesh and sported with the milk-maids in the groves of Vrindāvana, ever hallowed by the love-making of the Divine shepherd. But the gross aspect changes, the whole matter becomes abstract, in the eyes of an enlightened devotee. To him the human mind is Vrindāvana, and there the enternal play of the Divine love—the 'নিত্যলীলা'—is ever going on. Rādhā was married to Āyan Ghosh but she belonged to Kriṣṇa, as our souls, though bound to this world, repudiate these bonds on their spriritual awakening, and cling to God alone.

**A tendency towards idealization**

I may give an instance of this spiritualization of ideas even by rural and illiterate people in Bengal. In 1894, I was residing in Tippera. It was early in June ; the clouds had gathered on the horizon, and round the Çataratan Maṭha of Comilla they had made the darkness of night a shade more black. An illiterate Vaiṣṇava devotee, an old man of seventy, was singing the following song of Chandī Dās, playing on a lute made of a long gourd.*

**An example. The story of an old man.**

"Dark is the night and thick are the clouds,

"How could you, my beloved, come by the path in such a night ?

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* এ ঘোর রজনী, মেঘের ঘটা,
কেমনে আইলা বাটে।
আঙ্গিনার মাঝে, বঁধুয়া ভিজিছে,
দেখে যে পরাণ ফাটে॥

"There in the garden, I see him standing in the rain;

"My heart breaks at the sight thereof.

"I say to you, O maidens, for many virtues of mine, my love has graciously come here to meet me.

"Within the house there are the elders and my sister-in-law is very cruel; I could not immediately run out to meet him.

"Alas what anguish and pain have I not caused him by beckoning him to come!

"When I see how earnestly he loves me, fain would I bear the load of infamy on my head and set fire to my house!

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সই কি আর বলিব তোরে,
বহু পুণ্যফলে, সে হেন বঁধুয়া,
আসিয়া মিলল মোরে।
ঘরে গুরুজন, ননদী দারুণ,
বিলম্বে বাহির হৈনু।
আহা মরি মরি, সঙ্কেত করিয়া,
কত না যাতনা দিনু।
বঁধুর পীরিতি, আরতি দেখিয়া,
মোর মনে হেন করে।
কলঙ্কের ডালি, মাথায় করিয়া,
অনল ভেজাই ঘরে।
আপনার দুঃখ, সুখ করি মানে
আমার দুঃখের দুঃখী॥
চণ্ডীদাস কয়, বঁধুর পীরিতি,
শুনিয়া জগৎ সুখি॥

"All the troubles suffered for my sake he takes as happiness and he is only sorry if he sees me sad.

"The story of this love, says Chandīdās, will gladden the world."

While the old man was singing, I suddenly heard his voice become choked with tears, and he could not proceed any more. On his coming to himself after this display of feeling, I asked him the cause of his tears. He said, it was the song. The song, I said, described a secret love-affair, and where could be the pathos in it that gave occasion for such an out-burst of feeling in an old man?

He explained to me that he did not consider the song as an ordinary love-song. Here is his interpretation,—"I am full of sins. My soul is covered with darkness. In deep distress I beckoned Him to come to me. The merciful God came. I found Him waiting for me at the gate of my house. It cannot be any pleasure to Him to come to a great sinner like me,—the path is so foul, but by my supreme good fortune the merciful God took it. The world I live in, has left no door open for Him. Relations and friends laugh, or even are hostile, but remembering His great mercy what can a sinner do, except desert his house and all, court any abuse of the world, and turn a sannyāsin!" The thought of His mercy choked my voice—"Oh dark is the night and thick are the clouds, how could you, my beloved, come by the path." But He exposes Himself to the rain, because in order to help the sinner He is ready to suffer."

Tears were still dropping from the eyes of the old man and as with his right hand he was still playing on the lute, he hummed again and again "Dark is the night and thick are the clouds."

**Chandīdās omits no detail of human love.**

Chandīdās's songs omit no particulars of human sentiments. The longing regret at parting; the pleasure, even ecstasy, of stealthy meetings at odd moments and the devices used for such meetings are described by him in simple and unadorned style, without many classical figures. Indeed the scantiness of these is what strikes the reader. But the descriptions are vividly realistic, at once presenting a picture to the mind. Kriṣṇa comes to Rādhā in the guise of a woman-physician and touches her hand to feel the pulse. He comes as a magician and the women of the village assemble behind the screens to witness his feats. His labours are rewarded by one stolen glance at Rādhās face. He comes to her as the barber-wife and obtains a minute's interview; as a nun, and on the pretext of giving a blessing, whispers a word of love to her. Rādhā also goes to meet him in the disguise of a shepherd-boy, and the pastoral scenes are enlivened by a poetic touch describing their talk. In all this, as I have said, Chandīdās repudiates classical similes and the language of convention. We quote some extracts from his writings.

**Nothing to compare with this love.**

1. *"Of such love no one ever heard. Their hearts are bound to each other by their very nature. Thay are in each other's presence, yet they weep fearing a parting. If one is hidden

* 1. এমন পীরিতি কভু দেখি নাই শুনি।
পরাণে পরাণ বাঁধা আপনা আপনি॥

from the other for half-a-second, they feel the pangs of death. Just as a fish dies, when dragged from the water, so do they, if parted from one an other. Among men such love was never heard of. You say that the sun loves the lily, but the lily dies in the frost, and the sun lives on happily. You say the bird Chātaka and the clouds are lovers, but the clouds do not give a drop of water to the bird before their time. The flower and the bee, it is said, adore each other; but if the bee does not come to the flower, the flower does not go to the bee. It is foolish to describe the bird Chakora as a lover of the moon—their status is so different. There is nothing, says Chandīdās, to compare with this love."

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দুঁহু কোরে দুঁহু কাঁদে বিচ্ছেদ ভাবিয়া।
আধ তিল না দেখিলে যায় যে মরিয়া॥
জল বিনু মীন জনু কবহুঁ না জীয়ে।
মানুষে এমন প্রেম কভু না দেখিয়ে॥
ভানু কমলে বলি সেহ হেন নহে।
হিমে কমল মরে ভানু সুখে রহে॥
চাতক জলদে কহি সে নহে তুলনা।
সময় না হইলে না দেয় এক কণা॥
কুসুম মধুপে কহি সেহ নহে তুল।
না আসিলে ভ্রমর আপনি না যায় ফুল॥
কি ছার চকোর চাঁদ দুঁহু সম নহে।
ত্রিভুবনে হেন নাহি চণ্ডীদাস কহে॥

**Parting.**

2. *Such love was never seen or heard of. Moments to them are years. In each others' arms, they yet feel the pangs of the apparaching separation. With the edge of his cloth he fans her, and if she turns her head a little, he trembles with fear apprehending a parting. When the meeting comes to an end, my soul, as it were, leaves my body. My heart breaks to relate to you, O maidens, the pangs of parting. I quite believe you, says Chandidās."

3. †'May I go, now,' he speaks this thrice. O how many kisses and embraces with these words! He proceeds half a step and looks back to gaze at me. He looks at my face in such anguish as I cannot describe. He places his hands in mine and asks me to swear by himself. O how he flatters me to get the promise of another meeting! His love is so deep and his prayers are so earnest, says Chandidās, let him remain in the heart for ever."

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* 2. এমন পীরিতি কভু দেখি নাই শুনি।
নিমিখে মানয়ে যুগ কোরে দুর মানি॥
সমুখে রাখিয়া করে বসনের বা।
মুখ ফিরাইলে তার ভয়ে কাঁপে গা॥
রজনী প্রভাত হৈলে কাতর হিয়ায়।
দেহ ছাড়ি যেন মোর প্রাণ চলি যায়॥
সে কথা কহিতে সই বিদরে পরাণ।
চণ্ডীদাস কহে ধনি সব পরমাণ॥

† 3. আমি যাই আমি যাই বলে তিন বোল।
কত না চুম্বন দেই কত দেই কোল॥
পদ আধ যায় পিয়া চায় পালটিয়া।
বয়ান নিরখে কত কাতর হইয়া॥

We are only too conscious of the fact that the beauty of the original is lost in the translation. It is always difficult to translate deep sayings into another language. Underlying the modes, experiences and make-shifts of human love with which these songs apparently deal, there is a mighty current of love divine, which originates here, and streams out along its heavenward course. Some of Chandidās's songs sound like hymns to God, Here is one.

**The spiritual side.**

*"Thou art, O Beloved, my very life.

"My body and mind I have offered unto thy service,

"My family prestige, my good name, my caste my honour and all.

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করে কয় ধরি পিয়া শপথি দেয় মোরে।
পুন দরশন লাগি কত চাটু বোলে॥
নিগূঢ় পীরিতি পিয়ার আরতি বহু।
চণ্ডীদাস কহে হিয়ার মাঝারে রহু॥

* বধু তুমি সে আমার প্রাণ
দেহ মন আদি, তোঁহারে সঁপেছি,
কুল শীল জাতি মান।
অখিলের নাথ, তুমি হে কালিয়া
যোগীর আরাধ্য ধন।
গোপ গোয়ালিনী, হাম অতি দীনা,
না জানি ভজন পূজন।
পীরিতি সাগরে, ঢালি তনু মন,
দিয়াছি তোমার পায়।
তুমি মোর গতি, তুমি মোর পতি,
মন নাহি আন ভায়।

"Thou art the lord of the universe, O Kriṣṇa, adored by the Yogis.

"I am but a poor milkmaid and know not how to worship thee!

"Yet do I offer myself, my soul and body, unto thee as the sacrifice of love.

"Thou art my lord, thou art my path,—My mind seeks not for any other object.

"The world scorns me because of this love, yet do I not regret it.

"Abuse is like a garland of flower about my neck for thy dear sake.

"Thou alone knowest whether I am pure or impure.

"I know not even what is good or bad for me.

"Virtue and vice, says Chandīdās, are alike to me. I know them not, but know thy feet alone."

Some of Chandīdās's songs of Bhāvasanmilana (Union in spirit) have been adopted with slight changes by the Brāhmo Sāmāj of Bengal and are sung in their churches during divine service.

**God as lover.**

The paradox that has to be understood is that Kriṣṇa througout such passages means God. Yet he is represented as a youth, standing at a gate,

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কলঙ্কী বলিয়া, ডাকে সব লোকে,
তাহাতে নাহিক দুঃখ।
তোমার লাগিয়া, কলঙ্কের হার,
গলায় পরিতে সুখ।
সতী বা অসতী, তোমাতে বিদিত,
ভাল মন্দ নাহি জানি।
কহে চণ্ডীদাস, পাপ পুণ্য মম,
তোমার চরণ খানি।

trying to waylay the beloved maiden, attempting to entrap the soul, as it were, into a clandestine meeting. This, which is so inconceivable to a purely modern mind, presents no difficulty at all to the Vaiṣṇava devotee. To him God is the lover himself ; the sweet flowers, the fresh grass, the gay sound heard in the woods, are direct messages and tokens of love to his soul, bringing to his mind at every instant that loving God, whom he pictures as ever anxious to win the human heart.

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### 2. Vidyāpati.

**Vidyāpati not a Bengali poet.**

Vidiyāpati is not, strictly speaking, a Bengali poet. He belonged to Mithilā (Dwārbhāṇgā) and composed his songs in the Vernacular of those districts. Yet we include his name in a history of Bengali literature. This will appear anomalous, but our people have established their claims upon this Maithil poet in a manner that leaves no room for disputing our action. Vidyāpati's songs have found a prominent place in all the compilations of the Vaiṣṇavas current in Bengal, and they are sung here by the Vaisnub singers on all occasions. In fact a quarter of a century ago, it was believed by Bengali readers that Vidiyāpati was a Bengali poet. Recently, however, when a true account of his life was unearthed by the researches of scholars like Bābu Rāj Kriṣṇa Mukherjee and Dr. Grierson, we began to question the propriety of our claim. Vidyāpati's songs, as known to Bengalis, are in many respects different from the versions found in the Maithil

language. The days of Vidyāpati were the days of the glory of the Mithila university and at that time there was a great interchange of thought between Mithila and Bengal. Hence Bengali poems dealing with the love of Rādhā and Krishṇa found entrance into Mithila and the versions of those poems current there are full of Maithil idioms and expressions. The poems of Govinda Dās, the great Bengali poet, are still known in Behār, although the people there have changed their language by introducing many Maithil words and idioms which sound strange to the Bengali ear. In the same manner, Vidyāpati's poems have passed through changes in the hands of the Bengali poets who recast them. The reader may compare the recensions current in the two countries from a collection of Vidyāpati's poems made by Dr. Grierson. One looks very much like a translation of the other, yet the Bengali recension is sometimes marked by as much genius as the original itself. It not only retains the sweetness but occasionally improves upon it by introducing new sparkling thoughts. Some of the best songs attributed to Vidyāpati—as "জনম অবধি হাম রূপ নেহারিনু" are found only in the Bengali recension and the people of Mithilā have not preserved them in their collection, nor even heard of them. It is the popular belief that Vasanta Rāi, uncle of Rājā Pratāpāditya of Jessore prepared the Bengali recension of Vidyāpati in the 16th century. Vidyāpati's songs in Bengali glow with poetry, colour, and wealth of expression, and, as we have said, are quite equal to their Maithil originals. Under these circumstances Vidyāpati must be counted as

**Vidyāpati's poems recast by Bengali poets.**

Bengali poet, at least in this version, and it would be impossible now to expunge his poems from the compilations current in Bengal, where they have for the last three centuries found a prominent place.

**And are now inseparable from Bengali songs.**

Vidyāpati was a resident of Visfi—a village in the Sub-division of Sitamari, near Jarail, in the district of Durbhanga. This village he obtained as a grant from Rājā Çiva Siṁha. Vidyāpati enjoyed the patronage of Çiva Siṁha, Lacchimā Devī, Viçwās Devī, Narasiṁha Deva and other sovereigns of Mithilā. The copper-plate grant by which Rājā Çiva Siṁha is said to have conferred on the poet the title of Nava Jay Deva together with the ownership of the village Visfi is dated 1400 A.D.* Some scholars consider this copper-plate to be forged. The date in the inscription is given in Hijrā era along with other eras, but the Hijrā era was, by the unanimous opinion of historians, introduced at a much later period by the Emperor Ākbar. The characters of the inscription, besides, do not bear the stamp of that early period when the grant is said to have been made. The copper-plate, has been, on these grounds, declared to be unreliable. There is, however, no doubt that the village Visfi was granted by Çiva Siṁha to Vidyāpati. The poet himself speaks of this grant in one of his poems ;† and the descendants of Vidyāpati have for

**The date of the copper-plate grant.**

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* "অব্দে লক্ষ্মণসেন ভূপতিমিতি বহ্নিগ্রহদ্বাঙ্কিতে,"

**In 293 of Lakṣmaṅ Sen's era.**

† "জনম দাতা মোর, গণপতি ঠাকুর, মৈথিলী দেশে করুবাস।
পঞ্চ গৌড়াধিপ শিবসিংহ ভূপ কৃপাকরি লেউ নিজ পাশ॥

long years held possession of the village. The tradition prevalent in the country also supports the grant. The probable causes of the anomalies found in the copper-plate inscription may be thus explained. The copper-plate would be naturally in the custody of the eldest member of the family, and the other descendants interested in the endowment would, according to custom, be permitted to retain copies of it. Supposing that the original copper-plate was lost, the descendants were no doubt reduced to the necessity of preparing another from the copies they had with them, in order to satisfy Rājāh Todar Mall who surveyed the lands during Akbar's time. If this supposition is correct, it accounts for the introduction of the Hijrā era into it, and also for the comparatively modern style of the characters used in the inscription.

**The dates of Raj-Pañji not reliable.**

The court-register, or Rāj Pañji of Mithilā, records the year of Rājāh Çiva Siṁha's ascent to the throne as 1446 A.D. This, however, is also open to objection, as in a poem of Vidyāpati we have a mention of the date of Rājāh Çiva Siṁha's coronation as 1400 A.D. There are also other reasons which make the dates given by the court-register of Mithilā of doubtful authenticity. There

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বিসফি গ্রাম, দান করল মঝে, রহতহি রাজ-সন্নিধান।
লছিমা চরণ ধ্যানে, কবিতা নিকসয়ে বিদ্যাপতি ইহভাণ॥"

**My father's name is Gaṅapati Ṭhākur, and we are natives of Mithilā. Çiva Siṁha, the Lord of 'five Indies' took me to his court through kindness. He made a gift of the village Visfi to me, and my poetry flows at the contemplation of the feet of Lacchimā Devī (the Queen).**

are conflicting opinions about these dates. But recently there has come to light another document which refers to a date in regard to Vidyāpati and which we believe to be of unquestionable authenticity. The MS. of an annotated copy of Kāvya Prakāça in Sanskrit lately recovered, shows that it was copied by one Deva Çarmā by the orders of the poet Vidyāpati in November 1398 A.D. The MS. of Bhāgavata in Vidyāpati's own handwriting is also preserved : but the date of the copy given on the last page, has not yet been deciphered. The two pundits, deputed by the Asiatic Society of Bengal for the purpose, disagree in their readings.

**1398 A.D.**

From the various evidences which we have come across, we can declare with certainty that Vidyāpati was born towards the end of the 14th century and lived to a good old age, probably covering the whole of the 15th century. He was a contemporary of Chandīdās and was attracted by his great rival's fame to undertake a journey to meet him. Many of the later Vaiṣṇava poets have described the interview between these two eminent men, which is said to have taken place on the banks of the Ganges in the spring season. The talk in which the poets are said to have indulged was appertaining to love and its higher flights. It is said that Chandīdās made an impression on the Maithil poet which is distinctly traceable in his later poems, chiefly about Bhāba Sammilāna. In the biography of Adwaitāchāryya of Çāntipur—the vetern saint of the Vaiṣṇava community, written by Içān Nāgara in 1560 A.D., it is related that the saint, while touring in Mithilā, saw Vidyāpati there.

**Lived probably a whole century.**

**Interview between Chandīdās and Vidyāpati.**

**Adwait met Vidyāpati in 1458 A.D.**

The poet is described as a person of handsome appearance, and an excellent singer. This meeting between Adwaitā and Vidyāpati took place about the year 1458 or 27 years before Chaitanya Deva was born. Vidyāpati refers to Giāsuddin Toglak in one of of his songs and in another to Nasir Sāha. But with very few exceptions his songs as a whole are dedicated to Rājāh Çiva Sinṁha —his great patron and friend.

**His patron.**

**Vidyāpati's ancestors.**

Vidyāpati was a scion of a distinguished family of scholars. His father, Gaṅapati Thākur dedicated his celebrated Sanskrit work 'Gaṇgā Bhakti Taraṇginī' to the memory of his deceased illustrious patron Mahārāj Gaṅeçwara of Mithilā. Gaṅapati's father, Jaya Datta was not only a great Sanskrit scholar, but was distinguished also for his piety and saintliness of character. He obtained the title of 'Yogeçwara' for these qualities. The father of Jaya Datta and the great grandfather of Vidyāpati was the illustrious Vīreçwara who compiled a code of rules for the guidance of every day-life of the Maithil Brāhmins. The Vīreçwara Paddhati, as his great work is called, is almost as much revered in Mithilā as the Aṣṭāviṁçati Ṭattva of Raghunandan in Bengal. Another point showing the social rank of our poet is that for several generations, his ancestors had discharged ministerial functions in the court of the Maithil sovereigns.

**His Sanskrit works.**

Vidyāpati was a voluminous writer. Besides his ballads in the Vernacular, of which nearly 800 are now recovered, he wrote the following Sanskrit works :—

1. Puruṣa Parīkṣā. 2. Çaiva Sarvaswasāra. 3. Dāna Vakyāvali. 4. Vivādasāra. 5. Gaya-Pattan. 6. Gaṇgā Vikṣyāvalī. 7. Durgā Bhakti Taraṇgini. 8. Kīrtilatā.

My own criticism deals however with his Vernacular poems alone.

**His songs about Radha and Krishna.**

Vidyāpati sang much in the strain of Chandi dās; as a Sanskrit poet of eminence, he was held in great admiration in the court of Rājāh Çiva Siṁha. His own heart, however, was in the songs which he composed in the Vernacular. In the brilliance of his metaphors and similes, in the choice of his expressions, and in the higher flights of his poetic fancy, he over-shadows all Vernacular poets; and Chandīdās, the child of nature, is no match for him. When one reads the songs of both the poets, the ordinary ear is charmed with the elegant expressions of the Maithil bard; but to those who dive deeper into the inner yearnings of the human soul, Chandīdās will seem a far greater apostle of love; his simple words will leave a more lasting impression, than all the literary embellishments and poetic flights of Vidyāpati. Yet Vidyāpati also sometimes scales the heights attained by Chandī dās. In the 'Pūrvarāga,' 'Sambhoga Milana,' 'Abhisāra' and 'Māna'* Vidyāpati is more of a poet than a prophet. There is not much of spirituality, but a good deal of sensuality, in his earlier love songs. He ransacks the whole classical store to find an apt simile and is never weary of applying as much of these as is within his knowledge, like the sound scholar of rhetoric that he is. To give an example;

**His metaphors and similes.**

* Lover's quarrels.

**Radha's eyes compared to lotus and to bee.**

the eyes of Rādhā are compared to a lotus,—to a bee. These are commonplace and stereotyped similes; but the poet observes for himself in what aspect the comparison holds good and makes his descriptions greatly interesting.

"The pupil of her eye is like a bee resting on the lotus, the breeze driving it into a corner,"†—this refers to the sidelong glances of Rādhās playful eyes.

"The pupil of her eye is like a bee, so intoxicated with the honey of the lotus that it can not fly away,"‡—this refers to the absorbed looks of Rādhā while brooding over her love.

"Her eyes beautified with Kajjala, have assumed a purple hue, they look like the petals of lotus coloured with vermilion,"§—this is a picture of Rādhā just after bathing when the eyes grow reddish. The Indian poets are lavish in using metaphors to indicate the beauty of the eyes,—of those glances which bear messages to lovers, for their subjects can hardly find an opportunity to speak or write to each other. The stolen glances are the only means of intercourse of soul, they are the speech of love, and are minutely watched by the poets—চঞ্চল নয়নে বঙ্ক নেহারণী is a significant point in all such stories.

**Vayas Sandhi or Dawn of youth.**

The poet begins with Rādhā's বয়ঃসন্ধি or dawn of youth. This is the time when she is to fall in

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† জনু ইন্দীবর পবনে ঠেলল, অলি-ভরে উলটায়।

‡ লোচন জনু থির ভৃঙ্গ আকার। মধুমাতল কিয়ে উড়ই না পার॥

§ নীরে নিরঞ্জন লোচন রাতা। সিন্দূরে মণ্ডিত জনু পঙ্কজ পাতা॥

love with Kriṣṇa. She has reached an age when one would not mistake her for a child, yet would hesitate to call her a women. If at times she moves with the blithe steps of a child, she immediately mends her motion and walks slowly, with the grace of a maiden. The merry ring of her laughter may remind one of a child's voice, but she controls herself quickly, and a sweet smile such as befits a modest damsel is displayed in the soft curve of her coral lips. The beauty that has come so newly to her person is a surprise to herself. The freedom of childhood is gone; and her eyes become downcast if a whisper is heard. While busy with her toilet, in the company of her maidens, she silently listens to their talk of love; and if any of them notices this, she rebukes her, with mingled smiles and tears.

**Radha a creation of beauty.**

Vidyāpati's Rādhā is a special creation of beauty. She is a dream seen in the flesh. Where her gentle steps may tread, water-lilies spring up at the touch of her feet. The charms of her person are a revelation; she can hardly hide the joy, that a consciousness of it brings to her mind. Her smile is like the nectar which gives life and immortality. Her glances are Cupid's own arrows, not five, but a hundred thousand—shot forth on all sides!

When she goes on Abhisāra to meet her lover, the poet creates a wilderness of lavish metaphors. The idea is here overloaded with classical and conventional figures. Yet through this cloud of imagery, appears a vision of beauty. She is, says the poet, like a luminous wand, created by the lightning; like a golden tendril; the rich clusters

of her hair fall loose behind, black as the clouds or as the bees, but soft and curling like the tender Çaibala (moss.) Her eye-brows are bent, in the graceful curves of a bow, and her forehead beams with the lustre of the moon. The playfulness of her eyes reminds one of the bird Khañjana; her beautiful nose is like the Tila flower; her lips have the hue of coral, and so on. Rādhā's lovely form glows with shy happiness at the thought of this first meeting. She goes out in the dark night to meet her lover, covering herself with a Sāḍī of dark silk. She trusts to her guides, but when brought to the bower made by the maidens for the interview, she hesitates; she fears to enter; her heart is full of tenderness and love, but a feeling of shyness and delicacy holds her back. The maidens lead her in, inspite of her gentle protests, and she finds herself face to face with Kriṣṅa. Her eyes droop; she dares not lift them even to see that beautiful face at which she could never be weary of gazing. The tenderness of the meeting is indescribable. The delicate maiden cannot say one word in response to the many, with which she is greeted; and when she comes back she is overwhelmed with remorse at the recollection of her own failure. By degrees, however, all this is changed. In a subsequent canto she is found relating to her maidens the manœuvres adopted by Kriṣṅa in order to meet her, such as at the moment when her sister-in-law was asleep, resting her head on her lap, and he came gently from behind her, to steal a kiss. In these descriptions, as I have said, there is an exuberance of sensuousness, and songs of Vidyāpati would never have passed for religious writings.

**The first meeting.**

**Kriṣṅa's stealthy visits.**

if in the last canto he had not suddenly risen high above such sentiments and repeatedly given to the whole story a spiritual interpretation. Of this, I may give a few specimens. Rādhā describes Kriṣṇa. He is, she says, a flower to be placed upon her head; he is the collyrium (অঞ্জন) that makes her eyes beautiful; he is a precious necklace clinging about the neck; she cannot, she says, conceive of life without him,—he is to her what water is to the fish, or wings to a bird—the very breath of her being and the only object of her life. By a torrent of such similes which arise spontaneously, but are bound to lose their beauty in translation, she describes herself as altogether merged and lost in the consciousness of her love. Alas, she has told all, but, though loving with all her might, she has failed to grasp him; giving all that her soul is capable of offering, she feels that Kriṣṇa remains unrevealed to her, as ever. In the last line she turns suddenly, with the cry, 'Tell me, O Kriṣṇa, what art thou?' This touching cry "তুহুঁ কৈছে মাধব কহবি মোয়" is wholly spiritual and mystic, it is the agonised expression of the infinitely little in presence of the infinitely Great.

**The spiritual aspect.**

In the songs called Māthurā, Vidyāpati creates tender pathos by describing Kriṣṇa's desertion of Gokula. The shepherd has left the groves of his childhood.

**Kriṣṇa's desertion of Gokula.**

*"Kriṣṇa has gone to Mathurā. Alas, Gokula is deserted.

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* "হরি কি মথুরাপুর গেল। অব গোকুল শূন্য ভেল।
রোদিতি পিঞ্জরে শুকে, ধেনু ধায়ব মাথুর মুখে।

"The bird Çuka weeps in its cage.

"The cows look up wistfully, and all their gestures point to Mathurā.

"No longer do shepherds and milkmaids meet on the banks of the Jumnā.

"O maids, how can I go to those banks again and bear to see the pleasant bowers without him!

"The beloved groves where he and the maidens played amongst the flowers, how do they rise before me and yet I bear to live!"

The maidens speak of Kriṣṇa's return, but Rādhā feels that she is about to die, and says:—

"If the lily has been withered by the cold rays of the winter-moon, what joy can it have in the coming of the spring!

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অব সহি যমুনারি কুলে, গোপ গোপী নাহি বুলে।"
"কৈছন যাওব যমুনা তীর, কৈছে নেহারব কুঞ্জকুটীর।
সহচরী সঞে যাঁহা কয়ল ফুল খেরি।
কৈছনে জীয়ব তাহি নেহারি।"

"হিমকরকিরণে নলিনী যদি জারব, কি করব মাধবী মাসে।
অঙ্কুর তপনতাপে যদি জারব, কি করব বারিদ মেহে।
সিন্ধু নিকটে যদি কণ্ঠ শুখায়ব, কো দূর করব পিয়াসা।
চন্দনতরু যদি সৌরভ ছোড়ব, শশধর বরখিব আগি।
*  *  *  কি মোর করম অভাগী।
শ্রাবণ মাহ ঘন, বিন্দু না বরখব, সুরতরু বাঁঝ কি ছান্দে।
গিরিধর সেবি, ঠাম নাহি পাওব, বিদ্যাপতি রহু ধন্দে।"

"If the seeds have been destroyed by the summer sun, what will it avail that there be showers afterwards!

"Dying of thirst I came to the ocean. Alas! not a drop had I to quench my thirst!

"Weary, I came to the sandal tree, but the sweet scent ceased.

"I came for soothing to the light of the moon, and it began to scorch me with fire.

"The month of Çrāvaṅa with its raining floods had not a drop for me.

"The Kalpataru* is barren for me.

"O Kriṣṅa, O Lord of my soul! I sought refuge in thee, but found it not.

"The poet Vidyāpati is silent from wonder."

Though Rādhā speaks in the language of despair, she is nevertheless conscious of the all-pervading mercy of God. The images here are all similes for Kriṣṅa himself. He is the ocean, the sandal-tree, the moon-light &c.

**The touching appeal, when death seems near**

The mourner is about to die of her longing for the return of Kriṣṅa. Here are a few beautiful familiar lines :—

†"I shall surely die, says Rādhā, but to whom can I trust my Kriṣṅa?

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* The Tree of Plenty in Indra's Heaven.

† "মরিব মরিব সখি, নিচয় মরিব,
কানু হেন গুণনিধি কারে দিয়ে যাব।
তোমরা যতেক সখী আছ মঝু সঙ্গে।
মরণ-কালে কৃষ্ণ নাম লিখ আমার অঙ্গে॥

"O ye maidens, my companions, cover me, in my last hour, with the name of Kriṣṇa (lit., write on me the name of Kriṣṇa.)

"O Lalitā, friend of my heart, let the last sound, I hear, be the name of Kriṣṇa.

"Burn not my body, O maidens, nor float it on the stream; but bind it on the boughs of a Tamāla-tree; and let me rest for ever in its dark blue colour.

"If it should sometime chance that Kriṣṇa come to these groves again, I shall be called back to life at the sight of him.

"Sing in my ears, O maidens, the name of Kriṣṇa, that hearing it, I may expire."

**The spiritual significance**

The writing of the name of Kriṣṇa on the body may be a strange idea to my foreign readers, but those who have visited India will perhaps have seen the name of Kriṣṇa inscribed on the forehead, breast and arms of many Vaiṣṇavas. At the

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ললিতা প্রাণের সখি মন্ত্র দিহ কাণে।
মরা দেহ পড়ি যেন কৃষ্ণ নাম শুনে॥
না পুড়িও রাধা অঙ্গ না ভাসাইও জলে।
মরিলে বান্ধিয়া রেখ তমালেরি ডালে॥
সেই ত তমাল তরু কৃষ্ণ বর্ণ হয়।
অবিরত তনু মোর তাহে যেন রয়॥
কবহু সো পিয়া যদি আসে বৃন্দাবনে।
পরাণ পায়ব হাম পিয়া দরশনে॥
শ্রবনহু শ্যাম-নাম করুণান।
শুনয়িতে নিকসউ কঠিন পরাণ॥"

moment of death, it is a duty always observed by the relatives to recite the name of Kriṣṇa in the ears of the dying. These love songs, therefore, as I have said, cannot be dissociated from their pervading religious idea.

**Chandīdās and Vidyāpati compared.**

Of Chandi Dās and Vidyāpati, it may be said that the one sings as impelled by nature,—his is a cry from the depths of the soul ; literary embellishments are lost sight of ; poetry wells up like a natural fountain, whose pure flow contains no coarse grain of earth. The other is a conscious poet, and a finished scholar, whose similes and metaphors are brilliant poetical feats ; they at once captivate the ear, and the boldness of colour in the pictures, presented to the mind, dazzles the eyes. The scenes of sensuality, and lust are redeemed by others which are platonic and spiritual, —a strange combination of holy and unholy, of earthly and heavenly. His earlier poems are full of sensualism,—his later, of mystic ideas. Chandī Dās is a bird from the higher regions, where earthly beauties may be scant, but which is nearer heaven, for all that. Vidyāpati moves all day in the sunny groves and floral meadows of the earth, but in the evening rises high and overtakes his fellow poet.*

* Complete editions of the love-songs of **Vidyāpatī** and **Chandīdās** are expected shortly to be published with copious annotations by two Bengali scholars. **Vidyāpatī** is being edited by Babu Nagendra Nath Gupta under the patronage and directions of Babu Sarada Charan Mitter, late Judge of the Calcutta High Court and the credit of collecting a large number of hitherto unknown poems of **Chandīdās** belongs to Babu Nilratan Mukherjee, Head Master, **Kirnahār** School in the district of **Bīrbhum.** Each of the two compilations will contain about a thousand poems or *padas.* This is far ahead of the number of *padas* hitherto extant in the country.

# CHAPTER IV.

## THE POURĀNIK RENAISSANCE.

1. The Leading characteristics of the Renaissance. Faith in God and in the Brāhmin.
2. Vernacular recensions of Sanskrit works. General remarks.
   - (a) The Rāmāyaṅa.
   - (b) The Mahābhārata.
   - (c) The Bhāgabata.
   - (d) The Chandi of Mārkandeya.
3. The conception of Çiva in the Renaissance and songs in honour of him.
4. The Çakti-cult and its development in Bengal. Poems in honour of
   - (a) Manasā Devi.
   - (b) Çhandi Devi.
   - (c) Gangā Devi.
   - (d) Çitalā Devi.
   - (e) Laksmi Devi, Saraswati Devi and Ṣasthi Devi.
5. Dharma Mangal poems recast by the Brāhmins.
6. Poems in honour of Dakṣina Rāi (God of tigers). Some remarks about the poems.

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### 1. The leading characteristics of the Renaissance. Faith in God and in the Brāhmin.

**The reactionary movement**

I have tried to shew that the revival of Hinduism, which had reached full development amongst the vernacular-reading classes in Bengal by the 15th century, was effective in bringing society back into discipline and order, thus counteracting those vices of free-thinking and gross Tāntrikism to which it

had succumbed during the last days of Buddhism. In written language, metrical forms, aiming at rythmical perfection gradually found favour, and Sanskritic expressions were preferred to the loose Prākrita which in the Buddhistic age had been the current dialect of this country. Everywhere a reactionary movement—a tendency to correct and embellish the current forms—was observed. Both social and literary movements were imbued with this spirit.

**Creed of devotion.**

But the chief point in the revival of Hinduism was the promulgation of the creed of devotion and trust in God, which tended to balance the scepticism of the later forms of Buddhism. Buddhism had, in its flourishing days, observed a strict moral code. The metaphysical side of religion was rejected by Buddha as vain speculation. In the Ambatta Sutta, he declares theological discussion to be utterly fruitless, and advises his followers to stick to the practical matters of high moral principles and works of philanthropy and charity.

When, however, Buddhism with its noble laws of character declined, the masses felt that the moral code was unavailing without faith. From one extreme, the human mind always runs to the other. In the natural evolution of spiritual thought, the negative aspect changes till it takes a positive character. The Hindu reaction put faith in place of laws. Thus moral principles, self-dicipline, and introspection, the watch-words of Buddhism, were thrown into the back-ground, and faith in God became the motto and the catch-word of the Pouraṅik Ranaissance. The Hindu revivalists, in running to such an extreme, perhaps overdid their

part. They preached that man, being essentially a creature of circumstances, could not at all depend on self-help. He needs divine grace at every step. Faith, they said, was the only thing to be sought for,—not only in order to attain salvation, but for the purpose of building up character. They went so far as to declare that it was not in the power of a human being to commit so many crimes in life as could not be expiated by utterring the name of God once in sincere faith!

**The growth of the Brahmanic power.**

The dissemination of such ideas was necessarily accompanied by the growth of the Brāhmanic power. As a set-off against the lawlessness of the Buddhistic free-thinkers, absolute obedience to the leaders of society was enforced. The Mahammodans, as the new ruling race, did not enterfere with the social and spiritual movements of the Hindus. Full powers, thus, came to be vested in the leaders of society. Without a reverence for the promulgators, truth loses much of its force. Hence in the Pouraṅik Renaissance the Brāhmin came to the front, and stood next to God in popular estimation. Hinduism thus became in a far greater sense than ever before, Brāhmanism, or a Brāhmanic cult

A creed of faith has, often, much in it that is peculiar; it has its weak points which every rational man can laugh at. Yet a man of faith, blindly devoted to his faith, is often a better man than the rationalistic sceptic. There were many absurdities in the propaganda of the Hindu reaction. The following lines in Kaçıram Das's Mahābhārata shew the nature of the romances invented and

the modifications introduced into older stories, at this time, in order to raise the Brāhmins above the level even of the Gods.

**Fables about the Brāhmins.**

*"It is a Brāhmin's anger which, like fire, burnt down the great dynasty of the Yādavas and of Sāgara—the distinguished king of the Lunar race. It is a Brāhmin's anger, again, which has placed a blot on the Moon's surface. Even the god of fire, Agni Deva, and the god of the sky, Indra Deva, have been subject in their turn to a Brāhmanical curse. A Brāhmin's anger has made the waters of the great sea saline. Even the greatest of the gods, Viṣṇu, bears the mark of a Brāhmin's kick on his bosom."

Kāçirām Dās describes the incident of the curse of a Brāhmin, under which Rājā Parīkṣit was to die of snake-bite within a week. The snake had not yet appeared at the fixed hour. The Rājā grew restless, and when a worm was found in a fruit presented to him, he cried out, "Let this worm become a snake and bite me, rather than that a Brāhmin's word should prove untrue."† There is

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* যাঁর ক্রোধে যদুকুল হইল নির্ব্বংশ।
যাঁর ক্রোধে নষ্ট হৈল সগরের বংশ॥
যাঁর ক্রোধে কলঙ্কী হইল কলানিধি।
যাঁর ক্রোধে লবণ হইল সলিলধি॥
যাঁর ক্রোধে অনল হইল সর্ব্বভক্ষ।
যাঁর পদচিহ্ন ধরে নারায়ণবক্ষ॥"
Kāçidās's Mahābhārata.

† "এই পোকা তক্ষক হউক এইক্ষণ।
দংশুক আমারে রহুক ব্রাহ্মণবচন॥"
Kāçidās's Mahābhārata.

nothing corresponding to this line in the orginal epic, which makes it only the more significant in Bengali, as shewing to what an extent Brāhmin-worship was developed in this country in a subsequent age.

A Brāhmin was called Bhūdeva or god on earth. In the period of the Upaniṣadas, the glory of a Brāhmin lay in his knowledge of the Supreme Being. In the Paurāṅik age he claimed reverence equal to that offered to the gods, by virtue of his birth alone.

**The reason of Brāhmin-worship.**

But how are we to account for the meek submission of the people to the Brāhmanical yoke? Why did they allow a class of their own community to usurp the reverence due to their gods, on the claim of birth alone, and how could such wild stories about their powers obtain credence with the laity?

**The Yogis.**

In explanation of these startling facts, we have to remember that the highest type of Brāhmin was that of the Yogī, who had renounced the world, and developed the mystic powers of the soul by communion with God. These were unapproached and unapproachable. The people of Hindustan believed in the miraculous power of the Yogīs and offered a reverence to them which was not less than that they gave to the gods. The next class amongst the Brāhmins was that of pious saints, who were great scholars, caring only for a pure and stainless life and totally indifferent to worldly considerations. Such men took no thought for the morrow, even as Jesus taught. One of these was tempted by Mahārājā Kriṣṇa Chandra of Nava-

**The Saints.**

dwipa to accept a grant from him, but the Rājā received only a rebuke in return though the Brāhmin was in an utterly destitute condition.

**The lay Brāhmins.**

Besides these, there were lay Brāhmins, who could not boast of any particular merit beyond that of birth. But the whole Brāhmin community was imbued with the spirit of the Brāhmanical ideal on which the reverence of the people for the Brāhmins was mainly based. It is absurd to suppose that men who had no political power could enforce obedience, without first inspiring regard through their character and high attainments. The stories invented to glorify the Brāhmins beyond all measure, were due to a vague and exaggerated idea of the powers of the great Riṣis of old—the ancestors of the modern Brāhmins. In the backwoods of Bengal one meets even now with wonderful instances of belief in the Brāhmin. There are people there who will not touch food before tasting water mixed with the dust of a Brāhmin's feet. Before a Brāhmin, they will tell no lie nor commit any other sinful act. Blind faith sometimes raises the character of illiterate people, in a way which it is easy to undo, but difficult to replace by the spread of education.

**The Brāhminical ideal pervaded the society.**

Yet it is the Brāhmanical ideal and not the Brāhmin of flesh and blood that is really worshipped by Hindu society. It is love of truth, absolute trust in God, utter indifference to worldly concerns, wonderful devotion and universal charity which are still the governing principles in the ideal Brāhmin's life. The indifference of a Brāhmin to worldly concerns is shown in the following story

related in the Chaṅdi Kāvya by Madhavāchāryya of Bengal.

**An example from Chaṅdi Kāvya.**

**The sage Lomaça.**

Lomaça the great Brāhmin, was passing through the austere duties of the religious life on the sea-coast. There, immaculate and pure, he was firm as a rock in his high pursuit and exposed like the rock to the inclemencies of the weather. He cared not though the burning rays of the tropical sun beat on his bare head and was indifferent alike to the violent rain and the howling wind that came roaring in from the surging sea. Nīlāmvara, a son of the God Indra, one day approached him and said, "Great sage, I want to build a hut here in order to give you a little shelter." Lomaça replied, "No need of a hut since life is transitory." Nīlāmvara asked the sage, "How long then will you live in this world?" Lomaça said "My body is covered with hair as you see; the fall of each hair will take the whole cycle of an Indra's reign; when all the hair thus falls off, my death will surely come." That is to say, the sage would live for ages and ages, and yet he would not allow others to build a hut for him. 'For', said he, 'when death was certain, sooner or later, what good could there be in coveting the small comforts of life'.

Though couched in the form of an exaggerated Paurāṅik story, this supreme indifference to the world and devotion to the cause of the highest good which is everlasting, is the true Brāhminic ideal which has been the cherished dream of the whole Indian community through ages.

**Gifts to a Brāhmin.**

According to the Çastras, it is a great act of virtue to make gifts to the Brāhmins. They were prohibited from pursuing any avocation for money,

Their lives were to be devoted to religious work, to study and to other disinterested pursuits, calculated to contribute to the happiness of mankind. And as the State would not take charge of them, it was enjoined as a part of the duty of every man in society to provide for their maintenance.

**The Chief characteristics of the Paurāṅic Literature.**

I have tried to indicate the lines on which the Paurāṅik Renaissance attempted to build up Hindu society. The literature that grew up in this attempt at a proper exposition of the spirit of Hinduism, promulgates the creed of faith in God and in the Brāhmin which constitutes its essential features. We shall next deal in detail with those Bengali translations of Sanskrit works which first gave an impetus towards popularising the doctrines of the Paurāṅik religion.

**Translations.**

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**2. Vernacular recensions of Sanskrit works. General remarks.**

**(a) The Rāmāyana.**
**(b) The Mahābhārata.**
**(c) The Bhāgabata.**
**(d) The Chaṅdi of Mārkendeya.**

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### General remarks.

**Translations were not literal.**

Bengali translations of Sanskrit works at this period did not, as a rule, follow the text too closely. They were meant for the masses. Learned people read the originals, and did not at all care to see them again in Bengali. In order more effectually to work on the impressionable mind of the common people, as also to suit their intellectual capa-

city, the original texts required modification in Bengali. The Kathakaṭās or recitatives with songs, which became very popular during these times, introduced stories and descriptions not contained in the original Sanskrit writings, but much appreciated by the people, since the narrators invented them for the very purpose of making a greater impression on their audience. The translations of the period, though mainly agreeing with, not seldom deviated from, the spirit of their originals. These literary sins again were not always of commission merely, but sometimes of omission also. The higher truths and more advanced literary compositions of the Sanskrit originals, were not always translated because they were not likely to be understood by those accustomed only to the Bengali recensions. So, inspite of fresh accretions, the translations were generally less in length than the Sanskrit texts.

**Dissemination of Classical ideas.**

In the declining days of Buddhism, the masses had lost all touch with Sanskrit learning. We have seen that the teeth of Queen Aduṇā were compared by the rustic bard to the bark of the cork plant (solā) in order to signify their whiteness. The metaphors of that period appear to the Bengal people of this age as neither refined nor edifying, in spite of thier apt and homely character. With the revival of a taste for Sanskrit, the metaphorical expressions with which that language abounds, were freely borrowed for the embellishment of the vernacular, and they became familiar even to the rustic people of the villages. These metaphors were often translated without any idea of appropriateness. A woman's gait would be compared, for instance, to

the movements of an elephant. The beauty of the nose was indicated by the beak of an eagle. Arms that reached down to the knee-joints were held as signs of manly beauty. The graceful steps of a girl were compared to the movements of a swan, and these and numerous similes like them became quite a craze with Bengali poets. Whenever a woman's beauty was to be described, the reader was certain to meet with such stereotyped figures of speech, which in more modern times became extremely hackneyed and tiresome. We must remember that this country was once covered with forests, and in such ages when men lived closer to nature than they now are, the march of the elephant, slow and majestic, would attract the eyes. In a sight so familiar, they might well discover points which would remind them of the stateliness of a graceful woman. On the Jungly banks of the beautiful Indian *Jhils*, the grace of a swan's movement was a frequent sight that attracted the eyes. But ages passed and the forests were cut down; the wild elephants passed out of sight, and the swan ceased to be a common object, hence those similes were no longer thought applicable to the idea of beautiful maidenhood. But where they thus naturally failed, convention came to the rescue. Conventional phrases from the classics had great attractions for our poets, and with those who did not themselves possess keen eyes for the observation of nature, they commanded an overwhelming influence. I quote below a stereotyped description of beauty. However ludicrous it may appear in translation, the cadence of the rhythmical lines, added to the sweetness and sonorousness

**Not always appropriate.**

**Convention keeps up the fashion.**

of the words, makes the description attractive in Bengali. What may strike a foreigner as somewhat grotesque, is to us excusable, or even elegant, because the similes are classical and conventionally correct, in accordance with the highest taste of a former period.

**A Stereotyped description of beauty.**

*"Her eyes reprove the bird Khañjana in their playfulness. Her eye-brows are like the bow of the God of Love, bent to aim the arrows of her side-long glances. The beak of an eagle would be no match for her beautiful nose. The crimson hue of her lips reminds one of the Vānduli flower. Her teeth are like pearls, and her smile like a flash of lightning, which dispels the darkness. By it she sheds ambrosia all around. Her waist is slender like the lion's, and her motion slow and graceful as a swan's."

**The translators enrich our language from Sanskrit.**

If classical figures occasionally overloaded vernacular poetry, the efforts of the translators, however, did immense service towards the development of our language, by gradually enriching it with a supply of choice expressions from Sanskrit. Our

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* সুন্দর কামিনী কাম বিমোহে।
খঞ্জন গঞ্জন নয়ন চাহে॥
মদন ধনুক ভুরু বিভঙ্গে।
অপাঙ্গ ইঙ্গিতে বাণ তরঙ্গে॥
নাসা খগপতি নহে সমতুল।
সুরঙ্গ অধর বাঁধুলি ফুল॥
দশন মুকুতা বিজলী হাসি।
অমিয় বরিষে আঁধার নাশি॥
হরি * * কটি নিতম্ব।
রাজ হংস জিনি গতি বিলম্ব॥ Algol.

poor despicable *patois* rose to the dignity of a finished and mellifluous tongue, and a vast literature was brought into existence, comprising numerous translations and expositions of Sanskrit works. The influence thus exerted upon the masses produced results of inestimable value. There is now not a rustic in a Bengal village who does not know how Rām nobly courted all misfortune and gave up the throne which by right belonged to him, because his father Daçaraṭha in a moment of weakness had given a pledge to Kaikayī, his queen; how the great Bhiṣma took the vow of celibacy because his father King Çāntanu could not win Satyabatī for his bride unless he promised the throne to her sons; how the King Çivi offered his own flesh in fulfilment of a promise; how Prahlāda, son of Hiraṅyakaçipu, was true to his faith, in the midst of the cruel persecutions by his father; how the sage Dadhichi, for the good of the world died by fire, to create the Thunderbolt; how the young prince Dhruva attained final beatitude in the heart of the forest, and dwells for ever in the Polar star; how Alarka the king of spotless fame put out his own eyes for the sake of a vow; how Ekalavya, the great archer cut off the thumb of his right hand at the desire of his teacher, Drona; how Janaka the princely saint ruled his kingdom as a true servant of God, unmoved through weal and woe; how Yudhisthira would even choose hell for the sake of others; and how Nala, King of Niṣada, suffered for the sake of truth all that a human being could suffer, and yet did not swerve from the righteous course. The devotion and sacrifices of woman as related in the Purāṅas are even greater. Half a century ago no

**The Paurāṅik stories grow familiar.**

**Rām.**

**Bhiṣma.**

**Çivi.**

**Prahlāda.**

**Dadhichi.**

**Dhruva.**

**Alarka.**

**Ekalavya.**

**Janaka.**

**Yudhisthira.**

**Nala.**

**Sitā.**

**Sāvitrī.**

**Damayantī.**

**Chintā.**

**Kauçalyā.**

woman in Bengal, however illiterate, was ignorant of the sufferings of the faultless Sītā, her trial and her exile; of the wonderful devotion of Sāvitrī, who followed her husband Satyavāna even in death; of Damayantī and her wonderful resourcefulness in the recovery of her husband, Nala; of Chintā, the devoted wife of King Çrivatsa; of the calm courage of Queen Kauçalyā who could say to her son Rām on the eve of his exile, "Go thou to the forest for the cause of virtue; and may the virtue and truth, which thou hast so faithfully followed, preserve thee!" Such were the stories and traditions by which the minds and characters of the masses were formed. When we read in the Chaṅdī Kavya by Mukundarāma, of Kālketu, the illiterate huntsman, referring to texts from the Bhāgvata, in his soliloquy on the banks of the Ajoy; of his wife Phullarā explaining to the Goddess Chaṅdī the imprudence of visiting at strange houses, and illustrating her argument by chapter and verse from the Rāmāyana; or of Khullanā, the beautiful wife of Dhanapati, freely quoting from the Purāṅas, as she talks with her co-wife Lahanā, one need not be surprised at this display of learning even by people who sprang from the lower classes of Hindu society. The translations of the Purāṅas had by this time reached the humblest cottage in Bengal. The way in which they were made familiar to illiterate men and women is interesting. The translated works were recited to them by those amongst themselves who were able to read, but a far greater popularising of Paurāṅik stories was carried out by the performances of the professional singers. These people, Mangal Gāyaks, as they are called, give their

**Translations reached the humblest Bengali cottage.**

**Professional singers. The Mangal Gāyāks.**

renderings of the ancient stories to this day during winter evenings by the roadsides and in the villages of Bengal. The performers may be as many as eleven or twelve in number, of whom one, the Gāyen is the leader or soloist, while the rest act as a kind of subdued, humming chorus. The Mangal or recitation is held in some large court or in the open air. The Gāyen stands in a prominent position, often wearing a crown on his head and *Nupura* or cymbals on his feet, while his chorus sits crouching in a semi-circle behind him. He begins to narrate a Paurāṅik story, singing the metrical verses of a vernacular translation from some Sanskrit poem. He acts as he sings, and the *Nupuras* make a jingling accompaniment to his measured and rythmical movements; even now and then his recitation is interrupted by some moral or theological digression of his own, which is often of extraordinary depth and beauty. This will end with a song, in which, at a given signal, the chorus joins, dwelling on a low droning note, and giving to the main narrative a major or minor character according to the musical interval they maintain between themselves and the solo.

**The Mangal Gāns give a glimpse of the ancient world.**

In this quaint spectacle—which will draw hundreds or even thousands of men and women to see it, night after night, for months at a stretch,—we catch a glimpse of a world so old that even the Paurāṅik Renaissance itself, beside it, seems to be a thing of yesterday. The intellectual history of India ever since Çankarāchāryya in the end of the Seventh century has been one long story of the progressive democratising of the Vedānta philosophy; and the theological and devotional profundity

of these Indian Mangal Gāyaks is a result of this fact, a characteristic peculiar to themselves and to their age. But in the Mangal Gān itself, we cannot doubt that we have preserved to us the mode by which, in a remotely ancient past, the ballads of Homer were handed down amidst the villagers of Greece; the mode adopted by Damayanti in one of the oldest portions of the Mahābhārata, when she sent out the Gāyaks to search for the lost Nala; nay, a mode not unprecedented in medieval Europe itself, when the parties of strolling minne-singers performed simple dramas like 'Ancassin and Nicolette' in the manor hall.

There are many classes of Indian rhapsodists, but these ballad singers are undoubtedly the oldest and most primitive. Even before the period of which we are now speaking, in the time of the Pāl Kings, as we have already mentioned, Bengal was rich in such ballad-chronicles. It is perhaps from the great patronage which the Gāyaks received from this particular dynasty, that a single performance of any narrative is called a Pālā to this day. The one-stringed lyre which was used by a ballad-singer while singing the glories of Gopi Pāl, is still known as the Gopi-yantra, after the name of that monarch. The poets who composed the songs of the Pāl Kings were, in this respect, different from the court-bards of Delhi of a later period. The Renunciation of Gopi Chānd, for instance, was obviously not a subject that a man was hired and paid to sing. Its popularity and persistence were directly due to the way in which it struck the imagination of the people and was taken up by the village Mangal Gāyaks. The ballads of Behulā,

"Pālā"

Gopi-yantra

or Manasā Mangal, have a similar source. Old systems of worship seem to fly before us, as we begin to thread the mazes of the history of the Mangal Gāns. For instance, we have the worship of the Planets, probably introduced by the Sythic Brahmins in a very remote age. It is my own belief that the story of Çrivatsa and Chintā, which occurs in most of the Bengali versions of the Mahābhārata, and cannot be traced to any known Sanskrit original, represents an attempt, fashionable at a certain period, to popularise the worship of Saturn or Çani, through these Mangal Gāns.

**A story in honour of Çani.**

When we consider how much of the recitation, at any given performance, may be the rhapsodist's own composition and what portion is derivative or traditional, we are able to realise the way in which this particular form must have contributed to the growth of the great Epics. The Mangal Gāyak is accountable to none, for the source from which he draws his narrative. He may take one part of his recitative from one version of the story, and another from another, at his own sweet will. His only responsibility is to please his audience. The songs with which his religious and descriptive passages are interspersed may be his own, or traditional, or lyrics of unusual beauty that he has picked from other poets of the countryside. The chorus is in such *rapport* with him, that they will often begin the accompaniment, in hushed fashion, on the last words of his recitation, bursting into fuller music as he enters on the song. Sometimes, again, they will be silent until the song gives the signal.

**The Gāyak and his Chorus.**

All this, which may seem to thoughtless observers crude and unliterary, in actual fact consti-

**The Mangal Gāns create Epic poets.**

tutes the great value of the Mangal-gān. The fullest room is left to individual genius, and that fame and appreciation which are the main stimulus to poets, are given in their utmost measure by the rapt audience vastly experienced in this form of composition and ready to listen, spell-bound, for hours, if necessary to a Gāyak of unusual powers. It is thus easy to see how every performance of a Mangal represents the net result of the whole past experience of the Chief Gāyen and his chorus, in appealing to their audiences. Each has acted and reacted on the other for many years, and a very successful form of Mangal will become more or less stereotyped, though not beyond the possibility of added refinement, and will be handed down from father to son, from teacher to disciple, from master-singer to student or apprentice, generation after generation. Supposing now some great poet to arise,—some Homer or Vālmiki—these floating tales and songs and ballads will be woven by him, with his unique combination of critical and creative genius, into a strong coherent shape. Definition and form are given to this. At such a moment it may be written down, weeded of its vernacular impurities, its popular grossness or chance vulgarities, but throbbing with the strong sympathies and dramatic instinct of the common people who gave birth to it. At this point, it appears as if the impossible had taken place. The world receives a new epic and it bears on its front a single poet's name.

It is owing to this popularization of old stories by the professional rhapsodists that there is still a possibility of epic poems being written in this

country. Not only the subject, but the poetical features of a connected narrative become quite familiar to all classes of people, and when the great poet comes, he has the double advantage of finding a vast body of raw poetical material at hand, and a willing audience educated to appreciate his subtlest acts of creative fancy. The poems of Chaṅdī Mangal, Manaṣā Mangal, and the like, though they certainly do not bear comparison with the great Indian Epics, have thus a truly epic quality about them. They are expressions of all the poetry of the race and hence we find them read and admired by millions—the illiterate masses forming by far, the most devoted of their admirers.

**New features introduced.**

At every stage of our past history, these ballad-singers have risen up from amongst the masses. New features have been introduced, in accordance with the taste and fashion of the period, the nature of the changing environment. As the Gopiyantra or one-stringed lyre of the old rhapsodists was supplanted in a later age by the behālā or violin and *khanjan* or cymbals, of our present Mangal Gāyaks, so also the crown of the Chief Gāyen is perhaps a new departure.

**The Hindu Renaissance adopt the Mangal Gāns for popularising Paurāṅik stories.**

It is but natural that the Hindu Renaissance should have adopted this most convenient and powerful method for popularising Paurāṅik stories, and we have seen that it did so, with the utmost vigour, improving the old ways, which had been natural only to rustic singers, and adding such touches of heightened poetry as were inevitably demanded by the deeper culture of the present audience. Under this head, of additions in accord-

ance with new tastes, will fall those passages of description and devotion, which are now expected.

I have already referred to the subject-matter of these songs. The vast literature of the Paurāṅik stories furnished the Gāyaks with inexhaustible stores of inspiration. Most of these stories are wrought by the Mangal Gāyaks in high strung pathos. The story of the Great Hariç Chandra, for instance, is one of their favourite subjects.

**The Story of Hariç Chandra.**

This mighty king, after having performed the Açwamedha and other sacrifices, felt that there was no monarch in the world who was as righteous as he. He was indeed one of the most truthful of men, but the vanity that he secretly indulged in the recesses of his heart was to be rooted out in order to make him a perfect man. A severe trial follows :—Viçwāmitra, the sage, seeks to complete and manifest Hariç Chandra's passion for truth. He appears before the king and seeks gifts. Hariç Chandra whose bounty is unlimited promises to give him whatever he would seek. The sage asks for his whole kingdom. The king has already pledged his word and there is no escape. He leaves the kingdom and with his Queen Çaibyā and the prince Rohitāçwa goes a-begging. But the sage will not let him alone even in this plight. He comes to the king and asks for dakṣhinā, the religious fee which must be added to all kinds of gifts to a Brāhmin. He could not, he said, accept the kingdom if a fixed sum was not paid on this head. The King finding no remedy sells his wife and son to a Brāhmin ; and he himself becomes the slave of a Dom, one of those low-born men, who serve in the

**The King gives his kingdom.**

**Sells himself, his wife and son,**

funeral ground, and thus meets the demand of Viçwāmitra.

**Serves in the funeral ground.**

He is bidden by his master to watch and serve in the funeral ground during the night. It is a cloudy night and the rays of stars shine feebly over the grounds from which appears here and there the lurid light of funeral pyres that only increases the gloom of the place. A mourner comes, carrying a young lad in her arms, and implores, in a petious tone, help for cremating the dead child. Hariç Chandra at once recognises in her his beloved Queen, the dead body being of his own son, the prince Rohitāçwa who died of snake-bite on that very day. The interview between the royal couple in that plight becomes heart-rending; the King of the world in the guise of a Dom in rags, and the Queen Çaibyā whose beauty and character were the themes of the songs of the Maghada bards, lowly at his feet in the agonies of insupportable grief.

**The pathetic meeting.**

The whole story is trāgic and full of tender pathos. Rājā Hariç Chandra suffers for the sake of truth. There is no other compulsion throughout all these trials than that which springs from within, —from a sense of duty, which with men of high character, always carries the strongest force. The Gāyen sings in a melodious strain and his voice trembles with tender emotion, as he describes the sufferings of the King. The pathos created by the woes of the Queen and of the Prince melt the audience to tears, and the silence that prevails over that vast congregation is only interrupted by occasional sobs—the Chief Singer's tone ringing in

**The great effect on the audience.**

strains of tender wail which is heard in that assembly like the plaintive sound of a single lyre and the story becomes more real than any history.

In all this, I have tried to show how great an influence was exercised on the minds of the people, by the Bengali versions of the Purāṅas. I shall now proceed to deal with some of the popular translations themselves which have helped to educate the masses of Bengal, and also to form their character, for the last five centuries.

### (*a*) Translations of the Rāmāyaṅa.

**Krittivāsa and his great popularity.**

The translation of the Rāmāyaṅa by Krittivāsa is by far the most popular book in Bengal. Five hundred years have gone by, since the date of its composition, and still nearly a hundred thousand of copies are annually sold in Bengal. I found the hill people of Tippera, who speak the Tippera dialect, purchasing copies of this work when they came down to the plains. It is in fact the Bible of the people of the Gangetic Valley, and it is for the most part the peasants who read it.

**His autobiography**

Krittivāsa has left a graphic account of his own ancestry, and of the earlier portion of his life. Owing to the omission of certain names, however, from this autobiographical notice, an important problem touching his career remains unsolved. It has not been definitely ascertained who the Emperor of Gour was, referred to by him as his patron, by whose order he translated the Rāmāyaṅa.

**Born 1346 A. D.**

We know for certain that he was born in February, 1346 A.D., on the 30th of the Bengali month Magh—the Çri Panchamī day, when Saraswati, the

goddess of learning, is worshipped in Bengal. The goddess no doubt looked with a benign smile upon the new comer, who heard at his birth the hymns recited by the Brahmins, and the sound of the conch-shells blown by the women. We may presume further that the goddess granted the baby the boon of immortal fame. Krittivāsa gives an interesting history of his ancestors. They were Kulīna Brāhmins descended from Çriharṣa who came to Bengal from Kanouje at the call of King Adiçur in 732 A.D.* Nara Siṁha Ojhā, 17th in descent from Çriharṣa, was the prime minister of King Vedānuja, whom we identify with King Danuja Mādhava of Swarnagrāma. Nara Siṁha Ojhā left Eastern Bengal and settled in the village Fuliā in 24 Paraganas probably in 1248 A. D., owing to the disturbance which followed an invasion of Suvarṅagrāma by Emperor Fakiruddin. Nara Siṁha's son Garveswara was known for his large-heartedness and his son Murāri Ojhā was by far the most distinguished scion of his illustrious family, if we are to believe the accounts given by Krittivāsa. He thus says of Murāri Ojhā.

**Ancestors of Krittivāsa.**

† "Murāri was a great man, and was always engaged in religious pursuits. He was known for his extreme piety and was esteemed by all. No one

**Murari Ojhā, his grandfather.**

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* "বেদবাণাঙ্গশকে"—654 Çaka or 732 A.D.

† মহাপুরুষ মুরারি জগতে বাখানি,
ধর্ম্মচর্চ্চায় রত মহান্ত যে মানী।
মদরহিত ওঝা সুন্দর মুরতি,
মার্কণ্ড ব্যাস সম শাস্ত্রে অবগতি।—Krittivāsa.

ever saw him moved by the vicissitudes of life or by passion. He was handsome in appearance. His scholarship in religious literature was as great as that of Mārkandeya or of Vyas."

**Other particulars.**

Murāri Ojhā's son Vanamāli was the father of our poet. In his autobiographical sketch Krittivāsa gives details about the position held by his uncles and cousins, together with a description of their personal qualifications which we omit. When Krittivāsa entered his eleventh year he went to read in a Tôla on the banks of the Bara Gangā.* There he read Sanskrit, Grammar and poetry, for many years. When he completed his education, he waited on the King of Gauḍa with a view to obtain some recognition of his scholarship.† He had composed five elegant verses in Sanskrit, praying for an interview with the king and had sent this through one of the officers of the royal guards. At about 7 o'clock in the morning, the guard came back carrying with him a golden staff. He approached Krittivāsa and informed him that his prayer was granted and that he was ordered to lead him to the Emperor. Krittivāsa followed the officer through nine successive gates, and came to the presence of the king, who sat on a throne, lion-like in his majesty. On his right sat the minister

**He completes education and visits the Emperor of Gauḍa.**

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* The river Padmā.

† রাজপণ্ডিত হব মনে আশা করে।
পঞ্চ শ্লোক ভেটিলাম রাজা গৌড়েশ্বরে॥
দ্বারী হস্তে শ্লোক দিয়া রাজাকে জানালাম।
রাজাজ্ঞা অপেক্ষা করি দ্বারেতে রহিলাম॥

Jagadānanda and behind him was Sunanda, a Brāhmin. On his left was Kedār Khān. The sovereign was talking gaily with his ministers and courtiers. Amongst these was Gandharva Raya, handsome as a Gandharva, who was held in great esteem by the whole court. Three of the ministers were standing by the king who was in a humorous mood. There were also Sundar, Çrivatsa and other Justices of the peace; Mukunda, the Court-Pandit, with attractive looks, and Jagadānanda Rāy, son of the prime minister. The Durbar of the king shone like the presence of the gods, and I was charmed with the sight. The King was in a jovial mood, many distinguished people were standing beside him. In several parts of the palace songs and dances were going on, and all the people were moving to and fro in a great hurry. A red mat was spread in the courtyard and over it there was a striped cotton sheet; a beautiful silk canopy

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সপ্ত ঘটি বেলা যখন দেয়ালে পড়ে কাটি।
শীঘ্র ধাই আইল দ্বারী হাতে সুবর্ণ লাঠি॥
করে নাম ফুলিয়ার মুখটি কৃত্তিবাস।
রাজার আদেশ হৈল করহ সম্ভাষ॥
নয় দেউড়ী পার হয়ে গেলাম দরবারে।
সিংহ সম দেখি রাজা সিংহাসন পরে॥
রাজার ডাহিনে আছে পাত্র জগদানন্দ।
তাহার পাশে বসিয়াছে ব্রাহ্মণ সুনন্দ॥
বামেতে কেদার খাঁ ডাহিনে নারায়ণ।
পাত্র মিত্র সহ রাজা পরিহাসে মন॥
গন্ধর্ব্ব রাজা ব'সে আছে গন্ধর্ব্ব অবতার।
রাজসভা পূজিত তিঁহ গৌরব অপার॥

haug overhead, and the monarch was there enjoying the sunshine of the month of Māgha. I took my stand at some distance from his majesty, but he beckoned me with his hand to come nearer. A minister loudly pronounced the royal order, requiring me to approach the King, which I did in all haste. I stood at a distance of four cubits from him. I recited seven verses in Sanskrit, to which he listened attentively. Five gods inspired me, and by the grace of Saraswatī, the rhyme and metre came spontaneously. Sweet were the verses and varied were their metres. The king was pleased and ordered me to be garlanded. Kedār Khān sprinkled drops of sweet-scented sandal on my head. The King presented me with a silk-robe. He asked his courtiers what gift would best be-

**The Emperor receives him kindly and asks him to translate the Rāmāyaṇa.**

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তিন পাত্র দাঁড়াইয়া আছে রাজার পাশে।
পাত্র মিত্র লৈয়া রাজা করে পরিহাসে॥
ডাহিনে কেদার রায় বামেতে তরণী।
সুন্দর শ্রীবৎস আদি ধর্ম্মাধিকারিণী॥
মুকুন্দ রাজার পণ্ডিত প্রধান সুন্দর।
জগদানন্দ রায় মহাপাত্রের কোঙর॥
রাজার সভাখান যেন দেব-অবতার।
দেখিয়া আমার চিত্তে লাগে চমৎকার॥
পাত্রেতে বেষ্টিত রাজা আছে বড় সুখে।
অনেক লোক দাণ্ডাইয়া রাজার সম্মুখে॥
চারিদিগে নাট্ট গীত সর্ব্বলোকে হাসে।
চারিদিকে ধাওয়া ধাই রাজার আওয়াসে॥
আঙ্গিনায় পড়িয়াছে রাঙ্গা মাজুরী।
তার উপরে পড়িয়াছে নেতের পাছুড়ি॥

come the occasion. They replied, "Whatever your majesty may deem fit. The recognition of your majesty is the only true reward of merit." Then they advised me to ask of the king whatever I might want. I replied, "Nothing do I accept from any one. Gifts I avoid. Whatever I do, I care for glory alone. No scholar, however great, can blame my verses."

The King was pleased with my answer and requested me to compose the Rāmāyaṅa. With this token of recognition from him I left the court. People from all parts of the capital thronged to

**"Blessed are you O, Scholar of Fulia."**

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পাটের চাঁদোয়া শোভে মাথার উপর।
মাঘ মাসে খরা পোহায় রাজা গৌড়েশ্বর॥
দাণ্ডাইনু গিয়া আমি রাজ বিদ্যমানে।
নিকটে যাইতে রাজা দিল হাত সানে॥
রাজ আদেশ হৈল পাত্র ডাকে উচ্চৈঃস্বরে।
রাজার সম্মুখে আমি গেলাম সত্বরে।
রাজার ঠাঁই দাঁড়াইলাম হাত চারি অন্তরে॥
সাত শ্লোক পড়িলাম শুনে গৌড়েশ্বরে॥
সরস্বতী প্রসাদে শ্লোক মুখ হতে স্ফুরে॥
নানা মতে নানা শ্লোক পড়িলাম রসাল।
খুসি হয়ে মহারাজ দিলা পুষ্পমাল॥
কেদার খাঁ শিরে ঢালে চন্দনের ছড়া।
রাজা গৌড়েশ্বর দিল পাটের পাছড়া।
রাজা গৌড়েশ্বর বলে কিবা দিব দান।
পাত্র মিত্র বলে রাজা যা হয় বিধান॥

have a sight of me, deeming me a wonderful man. They said, "Blessed are you, O scholar of Fuliā, you are amongst the scholars what Vālmīki was amongst the sages." By the blessings of my parents and with the authority of my master, I completed seven cantos of the Rāmāyaṅa."

In the genealogical work Mahāvaṁçāvalī, by Dhruvānanda Miçra, written in the year 1495, we find this mention of Krittivāsa. "Krittivāsa the wise poet, who is of a quiet nature, and peace-

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পঞ্চ গৌড় চাপিয়া গৌড়েশ্বর রাজা।
গৌড়েশ্বর পূজা কৈলে গুণের হয় পূজা॥
পাত্র মিত্র সবে বলে শুন দ্বিজরাজে।
যাহা ইচ্ছা হয় তাহা চাহ মহারাজে॥
কারো কিছু নাহি লই করি পরিহার।
যথা যাই তথায় গৌরব মাত্র সার॥
যত যত মহা পণ্ডিত আছয়ে সংসারে।
আমার কবিতা কেহ নিন্দিতে না পারে॥
সন্তুষ্ট হইয়া রাজা দিলেন সন্তোক।
রামায়ণ রচিতে করিলা অনুরোধ॥
প্রসাদ পাইয়া বারি হইলাম সত্বরে।
অপূর্ব্বজ্ঞানে ধরে লোক আমা' দেখিবারে॥
চন্দনে ভূষিত আমি লোক আনন্দিত।
সবে বলে ধন্য ধন্য ফুলিয়া পণ্ডিত॥
মুনি মধ্যে বাখানি বাল্মীকি মহামুনি।
পণ্ডিতের মধ্যে কৃত্তিবাস গুণী॥
বাপ মায়ের আশীর্ব্বাদে গুরু আজ্ঞা দান।
রাজ আজ্ঞায় রচে গীত সপ্ত কাণ্ড গান॥

loving disposition, and very popular." The court, referred to in the autobiographical account, was in all probability that of Kaṁsa Nārāyaṅa of Tāhirpur. Jagadānanda, the minister referred to by the poet, was a nephew of the Rājā. Mukunda, the chief Pandit of the court, was probably Mukunda Bhāduri whose son Çrikriṣṅa was the prime minister, and whose grandson Jagadānanda was a minister of the court. They were all Vārendra Brāhmins. The title Khān affixed to the name of a courtier named Kedār shews the court of this King to have been already subjected to Mahammadan influence. In a manuscript-copy of the Araṅyakānda of the Rāmāyaṅa, we find Krittivāsa lamenting over his failing health and his sufferings.

**An historical review.**

The Rāmāyaṅa by Krittivāsa, as we find it in print, is not at all the book that Krittivāsa wrote. In Bengal, where the vernacular was adopted as a means of popular teaching, all good works used to be recast by those who copied them at subsequent periods. The words which grew obsolete, and forms of expressions that became unfashionable, in course of time, were changed by copyists. There were also interpolations and omissions on a large scale, by reason of which after a few centuries the whole work would present a form in many points different from the original. But the general tone was as a rule preserved, and those who made changes, or otherwise added to the poem, adapted themselves more or less to its style. Krittivāsa and Chaucer were nearly contemporary. But what a difference between them! The Rāmāyaṅa of Krittivāsa, passing through constant changes to suit the tastes of the moderns, is even now

**The interpolations & changes in the poem.**

a fountain of inspiration to millions of people, whereas 'The Canterbury Tales' lies on the shelf amongst the classics, and is approached by the learned only. Historically of course such a state of things does not commend itself. What the original poem of Krittivāsa was like, can now be only dimly guessed under the mass of later interpolations and alterations. By the efforts of the Vangīya Shāhitiya Pariṣada, a number of very old Mss. of the Rāmayaṅa have been secured with a view to the recovery of the genuine poem of Krittivāsa. Their different readings, however, are a puzzle to our scholars. But when we consider the vast influence that this poem in its modernised form is still exerting, after the lapse of 500 years, on the education of the masses in Bengal, we do not really know how far we should regret the loss of the original poem, the quaint and antiquated form of which could afford only a philological interest. It must be stated here that the poetry of the original work has not suffered at all by these changes. The country people, true to their strong poetical instincts, have preserved the really beautiful and interesting passages while they simplified and modernised the style. Interpolations and changes have been made chiefly with the object of introducing into the poem leading thoughts of the succeeding ages. Vaiṣṅava poets, particularly, have enhanced the charm of the book by adding a devotional element, which, in the present shape of the poem, forms one of its chief features.

The changes wrought in the poem have been great. We can now trace in it the interpolating

hands of Vaiṣṇavas as well as Çāktas—followers of those two different cults who shewed such bitter animosity towards each other for so many centuries. The work being, as I have said, the most popular in Bengal, different religious sects missed no opportunity to introduce their own various doctrines, and pass them on in the name of Krittivāsa. These are like the advertisements on the cover of a shilling-novel. There could not be a better method for propagating a religious creed, and Krittivāsa not only helped the circulation, but his name added weight to the doctrines themselves.

Krittivāsa's Rāmāyaṅa at the present day is a curious medley, in which the different elements of Paurāṅic religion have found a place, and it does not follow Vālmīki's original poem very closely. As far as Krittivāsa was concerned, he was probably faithful to Vālmīki, though he abridged him. We come to this conclusion on comparing the earlier manuscripts; the older the Ms., the nearer it is to Valmiki's Epic.

**The Story of Ram's exile.**

The story of Rām's exile which forms the main theme of the Rāmāyaṅa is briefly this:—Rām is to ascend the throne by the wish of his father King Daçaraṭha. He is dressed gorgeously, his person decked with jewels, his rich apparel diffusing the sweet scent of sandal; he is delighted with the prospect of his coronation; the people applaud his virtues and look forward to his being crowned a king. Rām is talking gaily about his good fortune with his beautiful bride Sītā, when he is suddenly called, at dawn of day, to the appartments of his

**The coming Coronation.**

royal father, old Daçaraṭha He passes through the streets, which ring with the joyous shouts of men and women greeting him. The capital is decked with flowers and banners. The air is fragrant. Everywhere, throngs of people wait to catch sight of Rām, whose beauty of person, matchless valour, truthfulness and anxiety to help the poor and needy, have endeared him to all hearts. Rām comes into the presence of the old monarch, but there he meets with a strange spectacle ; the king is shedding tears and dares not look at his dear son. Rām is awe-striken, like a traveller treading on a venomous snake that lies in his path. His

**The banishment.**

step-mother Kaikeyī, the favourite Queen of Daçaraṭha, sits beside her husband in an attitude on which the firmness of a fell purpose is apparent—her features inspired with strange emotions, which do not betray any softness of heart. Rām makes his usual obeisance to both. The king weeps like a child, and hangs his head ; but the queen speaks out. Taking advantage of an old vow which Daçaraṭha made to her, she has extorted a promise to banish Rām for fourteen years, and to place her own son, Bharata, on the throne of Ayodhyā. To this, Daçaraṭha adds in great grief that, promise-bound as he is, he is helpless ; but his son can easily take the throne by force ; and this he ought to do. The people of Uttara Koçala will give him full support in such an attempt. Rām for a moment stands silent as a statue. Only a moment ago he dreamt of an Empire. Now he feels, with the ascetics, that man's true greatness lies in the sacrifice that he makes, and that earthly magnificence cannot really give him glory. At this, he throws away his jewels

and his rich apparel, dismisses the state-carriage that brought him here, waives aside the royal umbrella and with a firmness of purpose which is dignity itself, he puts on the bark of a tree, turns an ascetic, and leaves the palace. His half brother Lakṣmaṅa and the beautiful princess Sītā, of whose fair face even the Sun and Moon were scarcely hitherto allowed to have a peep, follow him. This daughter of the pious and revered Janaka, the King of Mithilā, can by no means be persuaded to live in the palace without her Lord; she throws away her jewels, and her tender feet, coloured with beautiful Āltā, tread the bare earth with its thorny paths, while the people of Ajodhyā lament wildly, as they see the royal couple, and the prince Lakṣmaṅa leave the capital in such a sad plight. The old King Daçaraṭha is crushed to death under the heavy burden of sorrow. Bharata, son of Kaikeyī, comes to Ajodhyā, and hears of the machinations of his mother only to be struck with grief. Followed by the loyal subjects of Ayodhyā, he overtakes Rām in the forest; abandoning his own royal dress, he walks on foot and falls at his brother's feet, begging him, with tears, to take the kingdom. But Rām will not accept this. Bharata, however, cannot be persuaded to return without Rām. Rām prevails upon him at last, giving him his sandals, which he carries on his head and places on the throne, proclaiming himself to be the regent of Rām's shoes, and ruling the kingdom in that capacity. Rām goes to the Dandakāraṅya groves, where the lofty peaks of Chitrakuṭa, the beautiful lake Pampā, the silver streams of the Mandākinī girdling the foot of Chitrakuṭa,—the manifold beauties of the picturesque

**Lakṣmaṅ and Sītā follow him.**

**Bharata rules as the Regent of Rām's shoes.**

scenery of the Dākṣiṅātya and the ever-changing seasons allay their heart's grief, and the royal couple and the prince Lakṣmaṅa pass their days, restored to peace of mind, and even to happiness. In the 14th year of exile, Sītā is carried off by Rāvaṅa, the Rākṣasa King of Lankā; and Rām with the help of Sugrīva, King of Kiskindhyā, wages a dreadful war to recover his wife. In Lankā, Sītā resists all the persuasions, threats and oppressions of Rāvaṅa. She is resigned in her forlorn condition but firm and resolute in her mind. Rām obtains victory over the Rākṣasa King and recovers Sītā, and returns with her to the capital after fourteen years. He ascends the throne of Ayodhyā, but his subjects express their doubt about Sītā's fidelity during her stay at Rāvaṅa's palace; and Rām only to satisfy the people, banishes her, though he knows her to be faultless. For the purpose of the Açvamedha or horse-sacrifice ceremony which he holds after a time, the subjects hope that the king will marry again, as without a queen such ceremonies cannot be performed. But Rām makes a golden image of Sītā, and says that he has but one wife; she has been true to him in all his sufferings and he does not, for one moment, suspect her to be faithless. He knows her to be pure as purity itself; and he has banished her only because he could not prove his own conviction to others. In the capacity of a king whose principal duty is to win the good wishes of his people, he has sacrificed all the happiness of his life and he is more miserable by doing so than the most miserable of his subjects. He performs the horse-sacrifice ceremony, sitting beside the golden image of Sītā. Not

**Sītā carried off by Rāvaṅa.**

**The victory.**

**Sītā's exile**

long after this, she is brought by the sage Vālmīki, in whose hermitage she was, to the court of Rām. There she stands, with down cast eyes like the young moon, the poet says, in its second day. The people are struck dumb at the sight of the lovely queen—that beautiful Sītā who in her youth went to the forest of her own free will, out of devotion to Rām, and triumphed over the unheard-of persecutions of Rāvaṅa, and who now, though subjected to repeated wrongs by her husband, is, as ever, a suppliant of his grace. When the question of her trial is again raised, however, the queen calls upon her mother, the Earth, to open and take her to herself. Verily she has been her true daughter, ever since she was found by Janaka, the King, in the furrow of a field, and she is a patient sufferer of wrongs even as the Earth herself. A cavity opens, at these words, and the Earth in the guise of a stately woman appears from within. Sītā throws herself into her arms, and, with her last looks fixed on Rām, enters in, and disappears.

**Sītā vanishes away in the arms of her mother Earth.**

This is in brief the story of the Rāmāyaṅa. It is full of tender and pathetic interest. Its tales of righteousness, of life-long devotion, of holy adherence to one's vows and consequent sufferings have an ennobling influence on the people at large, and they are never weary of hearing them recited.

**The ennobling influence of this and other Paurāṅic stories.**

One point need be mentioned here. The stories of the Purāṅas never involve their readers in a merely tragic interest. The sufferings that raise a man's character—martyrdoms for the sake of virtue, are the subjects which they take up. The poem attracts the reader by its literary excellence,

by some romantic motive appealing to the ordinary mind; But in addition, there is a great purpose to be traced in this Paurānic literature, underlying and hallowing the realistic scenes. This purpose is not made inartistically prominent, but it works half-revealed as the great Moral Law that runs through the affairs of men in this world. In India religion is not dissociated from any department of thought; in poetry, in philosophy and even in logic, the chief point, the Indian writers have in view, is spirituality, which to their eyes is the finer essence of life and without which life sinks into grossness. Their earthly habitations are meant as temporary residences which always have lattices and apertures open towards heaven.

Details of the changes which have been made by later poets in the original work of Krittivāsa will be dealt with in the chapter on Vaiṣṇavism.

**The great popularity of Krittivasā's Rāmāyaṅa.**

The great popularity of Krittivāsa cannot but strike any one who visits Bengal. Through the cocoanut and mango groves which half conceal the thatched roofs of the villages, let one pass by the narrow muddy road, in the stillness of the night, when nature, as it were, drowses, with the drooping leaves of the trees and the waning light in the cottages, and he will mark here and there some small merchant or craftsman, sitting beside his lamp and poring over the pages of the Rāmāyaṅa, which he chants, as he reads, in a sing-song voice, that chimes in, with the droning of the beetles and the sound of the falling leaves.

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**Other translations of the Rāmāyaṅa.**

Numerous writers after Krittivāsa translated the Rāmāyaṅa into Bengali, but none of them could ever rival his popularity or throw his great work into the shade, though some of the subsequent translations display a highly finished style of composition. The reasons which have determined this preference for Krittivāsa are two-fold. (1) Krittivāsa, of all the translators of the Rāmāyaṅa, has made the nearest approach to reproducing that pathos which is admittedly the strength of Vālmiki's great epic. (2) The unmatched simplicity of Krittivāsa's translation commends it to the masses more than any other literary quality. This simplicity of the Bengali recension is also on the lines of Vālmiki.

**Ṣaṣtivara and Gangādās.**

Of the other translators of the Rāmāyaṅa, we must first name Ṣaṣtivara Sen who was born at Jhinārdwipa, the modern Jhinerdi in Vikrampur in the district of Dāccā. He belonged to the Vaidya or physician caste and lived more than three hundred years ago. Ṣaṣtivara and his son Gangādās were voluminous writers. The son completed what the father had left unfinished. They translated not only the Rāmāyaṅa, but also the Mahābhārata, and wrote poems besides in honour of Manasā Devī. Ṣaṣtivara is precise and short. Gangādās is rather elaborate and more poetic in his descriptions. Here are a few lines from Gangādās. Sītā prays to be taken to the bosom of her mother, Earth, when her sufferings grow unbearable.

**Sītā's last prayer.**

* "Tear-drops finer than pearls fell from her eyes as she addressed Rām, her husband, in a tone that

* মুক্তা জিনি বিন্দু বিন্দু চক্ষে পড়ে পানি।
রামে সম্বোধিয়া বলে গদগদ বাণী॥

trembled with great grief. 'You are the Lord of the world and the help of the helpless, O King! You know best whether I have been true or not. I am the daughter of Earth and I am your wife. God created me for the personification of sorrow. You desire to place me under public trial, as many times as you please, before the people, even as one might do to a harlot. Such an insult as this trial my heart will no longer bear. Sītā bids you a life long farewell, and begs permission at your feet to depart for ever. None in this world could I count upon as my refuge, excepting you. May you, Oh lord, be my husband in all my future births!' Saying this, Sītā in deep distress, began to cry, 'O mother, mother! you can bear, O mother, the burden of all mortal things, but not the sorrow of your own daughter!'"

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সংসারের সার তুমি অগতির গতি।
আপনি জান যে আমি সতী কি অসতী।
পৃথিবী-নন্দিনী আমি তোমার ঘরণী।
বিধাতা সৃজিল মোরে করে অলক্ষিণী।
বারংবার আনি আমা দোষ পুনি পুনি॥
নগরে চত্বরে যেন কুলটা রমণী।
অপমান মহাদুঃখ না সএ পরাণে।
মেলানি মাগিল সীতা তোমার চরণে॥
তবে তুমি পরে আর নাহি মোর গতি।
জন্মে জন্মে স্বামী হউ তুমি রঘুপতি॥
এই বলিয়া সীতা ঘন ঘন ডাকে
সাগর জঙ্গম ভার সহিবারে পার।
আমার ভার মা কেন সহিতে না পার॥

If this had been a translation from the original, I would not have cared to quote it. But all who know the Sanskrit epic will attest the imperious tone of the brief expressions that fell from Sītā in the moment of deserting the world. In the extract quoted above, on the other hand, she speaks like a simple Bengali woman and though we may miss here the lofty reticence and composure of the original, yet one cannot fail to admire the great insight and refinement with which Gangādās has pourtrayed Sītā's mingling of pride and sweetness.

**Dwija Durgārām**

The date of the composition of Dwija Durgārām's translation of the Rāmāyaṅa is unknown; but this author flourished after Krittivāsa of whose poem he speaks with great respect in the preface.

**Jagat Rām, 1655 A.D.**

Jagat Rām, the next great translator of the Rāmāyaṅa, was born in the village Bhului, three miles to the south-west of Rānigañj, a station on the East Indian Railway. Close to this village on the south are the Vehāri Nāth Hills. On the west rise the historic ranges of Paṇchakota. On the north flows the strong, though narrow, current of the Dāmodara like a silver line through sandy banks. The scenery of the village is beautiful and the place is "a meet nurse for the poetic child." Jagat Rām was a gifted poet. He was set to the task of translating the Rāmāyaṅa by Raghunath Sinha Bhup, Rājā of Paṇchakota, and completed the work in 1655 A. D. He also began to write another book called Durgā Paṇcharātri which he did not live to complete. The last cantos of this were written by his son Rām Prasād Rāy in

**Rām Prasād, 1680 A.D.**

1680 A. D. Jagat Rām's Rāmāyaṅa has a racy and sparkling style and was at one time much appreciated.

**Çiva Charaṅ.**

Next comes Sāradā Mangala by Çiva Charaṅ Sen, a Vaidya, born in the village of Kāṭhādiā in Vikrampur in the district of Dāccā. This recension of the Rāmāyaṅa was composed in the latter part of the 18th century.

**Adbhutāchāryya, 1742 A.D.**

This author's real name was Nityānanda and Adbhutāchāryya was his title. He bagan the work of translation when he was yet a boy and brought his work to completion in 1742 A. D.

**Kavichandra's Rāmāyaṅa**

Kavichandra was the title, Çaṅkara being the name of the poet. Many chapters and passages from this Rāmāyaṅa have been added to that of Krittivāsa, and in the shape in which we find the latter poem now, it owes largely to these additions. The well-known humourous canto of Aṅgada Rāybār or Interview between Aṅgada, as ambassador, and Rāvaṅa, which is now inseparable from Krittivāsa's Rāmāyaṅa, was written by Çaṅkara Kavichandra. Besides this translation of the Rāmāyaṅa, he wrote many other poems, all of which are characterised by a lively poetical spirit. Kavichandra was one of the most voluminous of old Bengali writers.*

* I have found 46 poems in all by this author. Kavichandra translated the **Rāmāyaṅa,** the **Mahābhārata,** and the **Bhāgabata** in Bengali. The 46 poems, numerated below, fall under one or the other of these three groups. I mention in the list the dates, where available, on which the MSS. that I found were copied.

(1) **Akruḍa āgamana** 1683 A. D.
(2) Ajāmiler Upākhyān 080 A. D.
(3) **Arjuner Darpa Churṅa** 1847 A. D.
(4) Arjuner Bānd bāndhā Pālā 1691 A. D.
(5) Unchhabritti Pālā 1054 A. D.

He was born in Pānnā, a village near Logo in the district of Bānkurā. Bābu Mākhan Lāl Banerjee, a descendant of Çaṇkara through one of his daughters, has, at great pains, collected a com-

(6) **Uddhaba Saṁbād** 1654.
(7) **Ekādaçibraṭa Pālā** 1680 A. D.
(8) Kangsabadha.
(9) **Kaṅvamunir Pāraṅ** 1813 A. D.
(10) Kapilā Mangal.
(11) **Kuntir Çīva Pujā** 1672 A. D.
(12) **Kriṣner Swargārohaṅa** 1678 A. D.
(13) **Kokilsaṁgbād** 1859 A. D.
(14) **Geḍu Churi** 1873 A. D.
(15) Chitra Ketur Upākhyan.
(16) **Daçam Puraṅa.**
(17) **Dātā Karṅa** 1655 A. D.
(18) Divā Rāsa.
(19) Draupadir Vastra Harana 1702 A. D.
(20) Draupadir Sayambara.
(21) Dhruva Charitra.
(22) Nanda Vidāya 1758 A. D.
(23) **Parikṣiter Bṛamha Çāpa.**
(24) **Pāriyāta Haraṅa.**
(25) Prahlāda Charitra 1664 A. D.
(26) Bharata Upākhyāna 1673 A. D.
(27) **Vāṅa Parva** 1678 A. D.
(28) Udyoga Parva.
(29) **Bhiṣma Parva.**
(30) **Karṅa Parva.**
(31) **Çalya Parva** 1673 A. D.
(32) Gadā Parva.
(33) Rādhikā Mangal 1660 A. D.
(34) Lankā Kānda.
(35) **Rāvaṅbadha** 1839.
(36) **Rukmiṅī Haraṅa.**
(37) **Çivarāmer Yuddha.**
(38) **Çivi Upākhyān.**
(39) **Sītā Haraṅ.**
(40) Hariç Chandrer Pālā 1796 A. D.
(41) **Ādhyātma Rāmāyaṅa** 1743 A. D.

plete manuscript of Çaṇkara's works which, however, he is not able to publish for want of funds. Kavichandra lived about the end of the 16th century.

**Lakṣmaṅ Bandyopādhāya.**

The Rāmāyaṅa by Lakṣmaṅ Bandyopādhāya, was composed in the middle of the 17th century.

**Valarām Bandyopādhāya, 1838 A. D.**

The Rāmāyaṅa, by Valarām Bandyopādhāya, was written in comparatively modern times. It was completed in 1838 A. D. Valarām Bandyopādhāya was born in the village of Meteri in the district of Nadia: he dedicated his works to Mādhava, his household God.

**Rām's character loses human interest.**

In the original poem of Vālmīki, Rām chiefly figures as a great man only. In Ādikānda and Uttarakānda,—the first canto and the last—which, according to scholars, did not form part of the original poem, there are incidents that prove him to be an incarnation of Viṣṅu. In the other five kāndas, or cantos, however, which we believe to be the genuine epic of Vālmīki, he mainly appears to us as a great man guided by the noblest of impulses, and this high character requires no help of a mythological kind to commend him to the reverence of the people. The Hindu mind, however, has undergone a change since the original epic was composed. Rām has now become, in the eyes of the people, an incarnation of Viṣṅu and his name for millions is a synonym for God. To a writer

(42) Angal Rāybār.
(43) **Kumbha Karṅer Rāybār.**
(44) **Draupadir Lajjānivāraṅa.**
(45) **Durvāsār Pāraṅ.**
(46) **Laksmāṅer Çakti Çela.**

Besides these Kavichandra wrote a voluminous work in honour of **Çiva.**

who believes in the divinity of Rām with all his heart, the epic is no longer a mere poem, every word of it is divine. The Bengali rescensions of the Rāmāyaṅa, as also the Hindi Rāmāyaṅa by Tulasī Dās, differ in this point from the original Sanskrit epic. Whenever the vernacular poets attempt to describe any episode of Rām's life, the expressions they use, in the excess of their devotional fervour, verge on the phraseology of sermons and prayers, and we miss in them the vigorous realistic descriptions of the original. Here is an account of the rainy season by Rām Mohan who lived in the last part of the eighteenth century. The poet labours under an overwhelming idea of Rām's divinity, and cannot forget this even while giving an account of natural scenery at a particular season.

**Rām Mohan.**

**A description of the rains.**

* "In the month of Āṣāḍha the newly formed clouds appear in the sky, and I find the beautiful dark blue complexion of Rām, mirrored in them. It thunders continually. The sound falls upon my ear like the twanging of Rām's bow-string. The lightning flashes at intervals. Even so flashes the figure of Rām in the mind of a devotee. At the sight of the newborn clouds, the peacocks dance for joy. So are goodly men overjoyed at the sight of Rām. Rain pours incessantly on the earth. How like the tears that Rām shed, in his grief for

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* আষাঢ়ে নবীন মেঘ দিল দরশন।
যেমত সুন্দর শ্যাম রামের বরণ॥
ঘন ঘন গর্জ্জে ঘন অতি অসম্ভব।
যেমন রামের ধনু টঙ্কারের রব॥

Sita ! The lotus blooms in the lake, as shines the image of Rām in the minds of his devotees. The bees suck honey never leaving the lotus. Even so do the minds of the spiritual cling to the feet of Rām Chandra. The thirst of the bird Chātaka is allayed by the rain as it falls. So are the passions of the flesh soothed by the presence of Rām. The rivers and streams run swiftly to lose themselves in the ocean, as the universe moves onward to lose itself in Rām. The rain-drops soothe the

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র'য়ে র'য়ে সৌদামিনী চমকে গগনে।
যেমন রামের রূপ সাধকের মনে॥
ময়ূর করয়ে নৃত্য নবমেঘ দেখি।
রাম দেখি সজ্জন যেমন হয় সুখী॥
সদা জলধারা পড়ে ধরণীউপরে।
সীতা লাগি রামের যেমন চক্ষু ঝরে॥
সরসিজ শোভাকর হৈল সরোবরে।
যেমত শোভিত রাম সেবকঅন্তরে॥
মধুআশে পদ্মে অলি বাস করে মোহে।
যেমত মুনির মন রাঘবের পদে॥
জলপানে চাতকের তৃষ্ণা দূরে যায়।
রাম পেলে যেমত বাসনা ক্ষয় পায়॥
পুলকিত হয়ে মেঘ ডাকে ঘন ঘন।
যেমত রামেরে ডাকে নামপরায়ণ॥
নদনদী অতি বেগে সমুদ্রে মিশায়।
যেমত রামের অঙ্গে জীব লয় পায়॥
অবিরত বৃষ্টিতে পৃথ্বীর তাপ যায়।
যেমতি তাপিত রামনামেতে জুড়ায়॥

heart of the earth, as the weary and the heavy laden are soothed by Rām's name."

In spite of its ingenuity, which might have made it artificial, this poem is full of simple faith. But, however this be, there is nothing to be found in the original Sanskrit poem of Vālmīki which would give any opportunity to the poet for indulging in such fancies.

**Raghunandan Goswāmī.**

Of all the translations of the Rāmāyaṅa which followed Krittivāsa's work, that by Raghunandan Goswāmī is decidedly the best. This has been published by the Battalā publishing firms in Calcutta. It commands a good sale. The author was a learned man, and his writings display faultless rhyme, and a great command over language. It is a work which attracts more by the richness of its rythmical expression, its finished style of composition, and its variety of metre than by pathos or power of delineating character and feelings. It is based not only on the Rāmāyaṅa of Vālmīki but also on the Hindi recension by Tulasī Dās, and on some of the Purāṅas in which the story of Rām Chandra is re-told.

The author was born in the village, Mār, in the district of Burdwan and completed the Rāmarasāyaṅa, as his poem is called, in the middle of the 18th century. He belonged to the illustrious family of Nityānanda; and his father's name was Kiçorimohan Goswāmī. He dedicated the book to Rādhā Mādhava, the tutelary deity of his family.

It is difficult to shew in translation the rythm and the elegance of metre of a particular language,

and these are the *forte* of Raghunandana's writings. He pleases the ear more often than he touches the heart. I shall make an attempt to translate a short passage, from the Rāma Rasāyaṅa, below.

* "Now Rām made himself ready for the battle with a gladsome heart. With the tender bark of a tree he girded himself tightly. His thick matted hair he circled about his head. Hard armour he wore that fitted him close."

We feel that in this translation, the rich has become poor. When a very ordinary idea is made to sparkle by mere wealth of expression, it loses all its beauty, as soon as it is stripped of that particular garb; and Raghunandan will be a poet only to those who know Sanskrit well, or speak a Sanskritic language.

**Rāmgovinda Dās.**

The Rāmāyaṅa by Rāmgovinda Dās consists of 25,000 çlokas or verses and is therefore voluminous in size. The author's grandfather's name is Kuṅja Vihārī Dās and his father's name, Çivarām Dās. The date of the composition of this poem is not known.

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এথা রঘুবর, করিতে সমর,
সুখেতে মগন হইয়া।
অতি সুকোমল, তরুণ বাকল,
পরিলা কটিতে আঁটিয়া।
শিরে অবিকল, জটার পটল,
বাঁধিলা বেড়িয়া বেড়িয়া।
পরিলা বিকচ কঠিন কবচ,
শরীরে সুদৃঢ় করিয়া॥

In my researches amongst the Bengali villages, and from other sources was derived, in addition, a large number of translations of particular episodes or portions of the Rāmāyaṅa. Again there are many other poems which treat of the story incidentally. Of these we name some below :—

(1) Çrī Dharma Itihāsa by Guṅarāj Khān.

(2) Kauçalyā Chauthiça by Rāmjivan Rudra.

(3) Sītār vanavāsa by one who subscribes himself as a son of Guṅa Chandra.

(4) Lobkuçer Yuddha by Loka Nāth Sen.

(5) Pārijat haraṅa by Bhavānī Nāth.

(6) Rāyvāra by Dwija Tulçi Dās.

(7) Rāmer Svargārohaṅa by Bhavānīchandra.

(8) Lakṣmaṅa Dikvijaya by Bhavānī Dās.

(9) Rāmāyaṅa by Dwija Dayārāma.

(10) A story of the Rāmāyaṅa by Kaçīrām.

(11) Jagat Ballava's Rāmāyaṅa.

(12) Bhuṣanḍī Rāmāyaṅa by Rājā Prithī Chandra of Pākur.

(13) Lankā Kānda by Fakir Rām (Ms. copied in 1602 A.D.).

(14) Araṅya Kāṅda by Vikan Çukla Dās.

(15) Kālnemir Rāyvāra by Kāçī Nāth.

The above works, on the subject of the Rāmāyaṅa, were written between the 14th and the 18th centuries.

### (6) Translations of the Mahābhārata.

**The Mahābhārata, an epitome of Indian thought.**

The story of the Mahābhārata is not so compact as that of the Rāmāyaṅa. It is by no means, however, the less popular of the two. The Māhābhārata is an encyclopedic collection—an epitome of Indian thought and civilisation, the successive stages of which are, as it were, mirrored in it. There is a Bengali adage which says "What is not found in the Bhārata (the Mahābhārata) is not in Bhārata (India)." Round about the main plot—the great war between the Kauravas and the Pāndavas,—there is a wild growth of wonder-tales in which the current literature and traditions of ancient India are undoubtedly entangled. From the din of warfare to the quiet and contemplative philosophy of the Gītā, the reader is carried without an apology; and descriptions of heroic exploits and unmatched chivalry are interspersed with accounts of austerities and penances undergone for the sake of religion and with mythological accounts of gods. To add a chapter to such a work is the easiest thing that one can do. One has simply to put a query in the mouth of Janmejaya and that never-wearied narrator, the sage Vaiçampāyana, is sure to relate whatever may be asked him in earth or heaven. The poem is like the fabled Sāḍi of Draupadi which may be dragged out indefinitely to any length. In the Bengali versions, the poets lost no opportunity to introduce new stories and incidents from comparatively modern life. The pathetic tale of Çrivatsa and Chintā is their addition; and it is not the only one which they have added to the epic in its Bengali garb.

The contents. The main story.

We need not proceed with the tale of the Mahābhārata at any length. The main story is not the whole preoccupation of the poem. The Gitā in the Udyoga Parva, together with the moral and the spiritual discourses of Bhīṣma, in the Çānti Parva, yields to no episode of the main plot, in the interest which they evoke in the mind of the readers. The story of Nala and Damayantī, of Çakuntala, of Çarmiṣta and hundreds of such engrafted pieces, which are now inseparable from the main poem, have little bearing on the incidents of the Great War. An account of the Kauravas and the Pāndavas only would convey a very inadequate idea of the contents of the epic. Briefly speaking, the story is as follows :—The princes of the lines of Kuru and of Pandu were born and brought up under circumstances which led to feelings of animosity on either side, ultimately bursting into the most sanguinary warfare on the fields of Kurukṣetra. The five brothers, Yudhiṣthira, Bhīma, Arjuna, Nakula and Sahadeva, tried by all possible means to avert the war. They were the rightful heirs to half the kingdom; but Duryyodhana and his brothers would not part with this. Yudhiṣthira, the eldest Pāndava, asked of King, Duryyodhana, a grant of five villages only, so that the five brothers might have some refuge in the world. Even this Duryyodhana refused to give, saying "Not half the earth, that may be covered by the point of a needle, will I give without war." Added to this were the great wrongs committed against the Pāndavas by Duryyodhana from boyhood upwards, —the conspiracies to assassinate them, from each of which they had a narrow escape, and the last act,

surpassing all the rest,—the atrocious insult upon Draupadī, the wife of the Pāndavas. A war was inevitable and the Kṣatriya Princes of India rallied on either side when it actually broke out. The Pāndavas with the help of Kriṣṇa gained the victory, though nearly the whole race of Kṣatriyas was extirpated, in a terrible battle that raged for eighteen successive days incessantly on the plains of Kurukṣetra. Yudhiṣthira was afterwards smitten with remorse for having waged a cruel war which had resulted in the death of his relations and friends. This grief was accentuated by the news of the death of Kriṣṇa—the incarnation of Viṣṇu and the great friend of the Pāndavas. Yudhiṣthira, with his brothers and Draupadī, made the great pilgrimage up the snowy ranges of Himālays to Mount Meru. On the way each of the brothers dropped dead; and Yudhiṣthira was alone left for the crowning scene of the Mahābhārata, his ascent into heaven in mortal form.

**Sañjaya's recension.**

The earliest Bengali recension of the Mahābhārata, that we have come accross, is by a Brāhmin poet, named Sañjaya who belonged to the illustrious family of Bharadwāja whom Ādiçūra of Gauḍa had brought to Bengal. The task of translating the eighteen Parvas of Vyasa's Mahābhārata was immense and Sañjaya justly claims the credit due to the pioneer in this field. He frequently refers to his work in the following strain in his Vaṇitā.

* "The Mahābhārata, which was like an ocean of impenetrable darkness, is now unveiled to sight (made accessible to the masses) having been rendered into Bengali verses (Pānchalī) by Sañjaya."

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* অতি অন্ধকার যে মহাভারত সাগর।
পাঁচালী সঞ্জয় তাক করিল উজ্জ্বল॥ Sanjoy.

**The honour due to the pioneer.**

Yet Sañjaya's work is one of the shortest epitomes of the Mahābhārata that we know of; it is characterised by simplicity of style, and does not even possess any uncommon poetic merit. The manuscripts of Sañjaya's Mahābhārata have been recovered from all parts of Eastern Bengal. The great popularity, it once commanded, is explicable only by reason of its being the earliest Bengali recension. Generally speaking, manuscripts of Sañjay's Mahābhārata are very voluminous, as chapters written by subsequent poets have been added to them at different times. The Ādiparva by Rājendra Dās, the Droṅaparva by Gopī Nāth Datta and numerous compositions by other writers are now inseparable factors in many of such manuscripts; and these two poets at least excel Sañjaya in the wealth of their descriptions and in the beauty and elegance of their style. Sañjaya's antiquated forms of expression give him no advantage in contrast with Rājendra Dās's racy and poetic lines; yet the whole manuscript, about two-thirds of which belongs to other writers, is popularly known as the Mahābhārata of Sañjaya. This writer evidently then enjoys precedence because he was the first in point of time. Sañjaya takes care in his Vaṅitā that his name may not be confounded with that of the great Sañjaya, gifted with clairvoyance, who relates the incidents of the war to the blind monarch Dhritarāṣtra in the Mahābhārata itself, and frequently emphasises on the point of his authorship of the work as distinguished from their recitations by Sañjaya. We however know very little of his life,—the autobiographical account

**Sañjay, probably a contemporary of Krittivāsa.**

which was undoubtedly appended to the work as we find in every old Bengali book, has not yet been recovered; and we are in utter darkness about Sañjaya. From the early date of some of the manuscript-copies of his works that we have been able to secure, we are inclined to believe that he lived at about the time of Krittivāsa and was probably his contemporary.

Though some of the later poets excel Sañjoy in the elegance of expression, the earlier poet frequently displays a highly forcible style. Sañjya particularly excels in describring martial feats. Here is a passage shewing his vigorous and animated style:—

* "In order to excite the anger of Karṅa, Çalya says 'If you are once hit by Arjuna's arrow you will cease to boast in such way. There is no friend, O Karṅa, to advise you rightly. When a fly willingly rushes into a flame, none can save it. A child in the arms of its mother stretches his arms out to catch the moon; your aspiration is like that of the child; you want to drag Arjuna down from his chariot. Like a mad man you attempt

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* কোপ বাড়িবার শল্য বলে আরবার।
ফুটিলে অর্জ্জুন বাণ না গর্জ্জিবে আর॥
সুহৃদ নাহিক কর্ণ তোমা কেহ দেখে।
অগ্নিতে পতঙ্গ মরে তারে কেবা রাখে॥
অজ্ঞান মায়ের কোলে আকিতে ছাওয়ালে।
চন্দ্র ধরিবার হাত বাড়াএ কুতুহলে॥
সেই মতে কর্ণ তুমি বোলরে দারুণ।
রথ হৈতে পাড়িবারে চাহসি অর্জ্জুন॥
চোকা ধার বিশূলেতে ঘষ কেন গাও।
হরিণের ছা'য়ে যেন সিংহেরে বোলাও॥

to scratch your own body with a sharp spear. Like a fawn challenging a lion, you call Arjuna to fight with you. You are like a jackal swollen (with pride) by eating a corpse, and challenging the majesty of a lion. Oh son of a charioteer, how foolish it is for you to challenge the son of a king to fight with you. You are like a gnat defying the elephant. The venomous snake whose bite is deadly, while unharmed lies coiled up in a hole, and you are teasing it with a stick. Like a snake going out to fight the bird Garuḍa (which lives upon snakes) you aspire to fight Arjuna. The moon appears on the furthest limits of the sea, you want to cross the sea without a boat and catch the moon. A frog mimics the thunder. I set the same estimate upon all your fretting."

**Māhābhārata translated at Nasarata Shāha's order.**

The next Mahābhārata, to which we have already alluded, was written at the order of Nasarata Sāha. This translation is referred to, in the Mahābhārata of Kavīndra Parameçvara in the following couplet.

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মৃত মাংস খাইয়া শৃগাল বড় স্থূল।
সিংহেরে ডাকএ সেই হইতে নির্ম্মূল॥
সূতপুত্র হৈয়া রাজপুত্রে ডাক কেন।
মশা হৈয়া মত্ত হস্তী ডাক যুদ্ধে যেন॥
গর্ত্তের কাল সাপ ঝোকাও কাটি দিয়া।
সিংহকে ডাকহ তুমি শৃগাল হইয়া॥
সর্প যেন ধাইয়া যায় মারিতে গরুড়ক।
সেই মত চাহ তুমি মারিতে অর্জ্জুনক॥
চন্দ্র উদয় যেন সাগর অন্তর।
বিনি নৌকায় পার হ'তে চাহসি বর্ব্বর।
সেই মত কর্ণ তোমার বুঝিল যে মন।
মেঘ মধ্যে শুনি যেন ভেকের গর্জ্জন॥

"Nasarata Sāha blessed with all good qualities had a translation of the Mahābhārata compiled in Bengali verses (Pānchālī).* We have not yet been able to recover this Mahābhārata.

**Kavīndra Parameçvara & Çrīkaraṅa.**

Reference has also been made in the first chapter to the next two Mahābhāratas, one of which was written by Kavīndra Parameçvara and the other by Çrīkarṅa Nandī. Kavindra Parameçvara began his poem with the following preliminary account :—

† "The Emperor Husen Sāha was a high minded monarch, prised by all throughout the Five Gauḍas (Panca Gauḍa). He was expert in the use of arms; and was like a second Kriṣṅa in the Kaliyuga. Laskara Parāgal, a commander of the army of

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* —"নসরত খান।
রচাইল পঞ্চালী যে গুণের নিদান॥"
Kavīndra Parameçvara.

† নৃপতি হুসেন সাহ হয় মহামতি।
পঞ্চম গৌড়েতে যার পরম সুখ্যাতি॥
অস্ত্র শস্ত্রে সুপণ্ডিত মহিমা অপার।
কলিকালে হবু যেন কৃষ্ণ অবতার॥
নৃপতি হুসেন সাহ গৌড়ের ঈশ্বর।
তান হকু সেনাপতি হওন্ত লস্কর॥
লস্কর পরাগল খান মহামতি।
সুবর্ণ বসন পাইল অশ্ব বায়ুগতি॥
লস্করী বিষয় পাই আইবন্ত চলিয়া।
চাটিগ্রামে চলি গেল হরষিত হৈয়া॥
পুত্র পৌত্রে রাজ্য করে খান মহামতি।
পুরাণ শুনন্ত নিতি হরষিত মতি॥ Kavīndra.

Husen Sāha, the Emperor of the Gauḍa, was a generous-minded noble man. He obtained royal presents in the shape of a golden dress, and horses of the speed of the winds; and he was further endowed with a grant of an extensive estate in Chittagong where the high minded Khān settled. He enjoyed his territories with his sons and grandsons."

At the command of Parāgal Khān Kavīndra Parameçvara undertook to translate the Mahābhārata. This Mahābhārata which comes down to the Strī Parva, contains 17,000 Çlokas or verses. It was composed during Husen Sāha's reign (1494-1525 A.D.). Close to the sub-division of Feni in the district of Noakhali lies Parāgalpur, founded by Husen Sāha's great general who had conquered Chittagong and had obtained a grant of the neighbouring provinces as a reward for his valour. There is a tomb in the village, raised in honour of Rāsti Khān (father of Parāgal) whose name we also find mentioned in this Mahābhārata. Parāgal Khān's son was the valourous prince Chhuti Khān. In Parāgalpur, tanks dug by the orders of the illustrious father and the son still exist and are called after them, পরাগল খাঁর দীঘি and ছুটি খাঁর দীঘি respectively. Kavīndra Parameçvara, as I have said, translated the Mahābhārata down to the Strī Parva. Parāgal Khān had in the meantime died and his son Chhuti Khān succeeded him. He followed in the foot-steps of his noble father and appointed a poet named Çrikaraṅa Nandī to translate the Açvamedha Parva. We find the following historical account in the introductory chapter of his book.

**Parāgal Khān.**

**Chhuti Khān appoints Çrikaraṅa Nandī.**

* "The father of Nasarata Sāha (Husen Sāha) was a great king. He ruled the kingdom like a second Rām. Husen Sāha, the great monarch, ruled the earth by Sāma (preserving of peace), Dāna (offering of gifts), Danda (punishment) and by Bheda (bringing about division amongst his enemies). Laskar Chhuti Khān was one of his generals. He settled near Tipperah on the north of Chittagong,—in the valley of the Chandra Çekhara Hills. The abode of his father had been in the Charlol Hills. The town is so beautiful that only a god could have built it. People of four castes and various races live there. The place is almost surrounded on all sides by the River Fani (modern Feni, lit. a snake). On the East are seen vast mountainous ranges without a limit. Chhuti Khān, the son of Parāgal Khān, is dauntless in battle. His manly arms reach to his knee-joints. His

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* নসরতসাহতাত অতি মহারাজা।
রামবৎ নিত্য পালে সব প্রজা॥
নৃপতি হুসেন সাহ হএ ক্ষিতিপতি।
সামদানদণ্ডভেদে পালে বসুমতী॥
তান এক সেনাপতি লস্কর ছুটি খান।
ত্রিপুরার উত্তরে করিল সন্নিধান॥
চাটিগ্রাম নগরের নিকট উত্তরে।
চন্দ্রশেখর পর্ব্বত কন্দরে॥
চার লোল গিরি তার পৈত্রিক বসতি।
বিধিএ নির্ম্মিল তাঁক কি কহিব অতি॥
চারি বর্ণ বসে লোক সেনা সন্নিহিত।
নানা গুণে প্রজা সব বসয়ে তথাত॥

eyes are like full-blown lotuses. He moves majestically like the elephant. Sixty four qualities dwell in him and God has granted him world-wide renown. In magnanimity of soul and in his charity he matches Valī and Karṅa. In his great warlike qualities and in the dignity of his mien, however, there is none with whom he may be compared. On a report of his excellent qualities reaching the Emperor (Husen Sāha) he was called to his court. He received great honour from the Emperor and obtained those rewards to which only the distinguished generals of the court are entitled. Chhuti Khān began to rule his kingdom by Sāma, Dāna, Danda and Bheda. The King of Tipperah left his country being afraid of Chhuti Khān. He took refuge in the mountain (of Udaypur). He

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ফণী নামে নদীএ বেষ্টিত চারিধার।
পূর্ব্ব দিগে মহাগিরি পার নাহি তার।
লস্কর পরাগল খানের তনয়।
সমরে নির্ভয় ছুটি খান মহাশয়॥
আজানুলম্বিত বাহু কমল লোচন।
বিলাসহৃদয়ে মত্তগজেন্দ্রগমন॥
চতুঃষষ্টি কলা বসতি গুণের নিধি।
পৃথিবী বিখ্যাত সে যে নির্ম্মাইল বিধি॥
দাতা বলি কর্ণ সম অপার মহিমা।
শৌর্য্যে বীর্য্যে গাম্ভীর্য্যে নাহিক উপমা॥
তাঁহার যতেক গুণ শুনিয়া নৃপতি।
সম্বাদিয়া আনিলেক কুতুহলমতি॥
নৃপতি অগ্রেত তার বহুলসম্মান।
ঘোটক প্রসাদ পাইল ছুটি খান॥

further sent elephants and horses as tribute to Chhuti Khān and built his palace in the midst of a dense forest. Chhuti Khān has not yet done anything to inspire fear in him. Yet he lives in constant alarm. Chhuti Khān gave friendly assurance to the King of Tipperah and he dwells happily in his own capital. The khān's royal glory is increasing every day and he looks upon the people of the country as his children.

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লস্করী বিষয় পাইয়া মহামতি।
সামদানদণ্ডভেদে পালে বসুমতী॥
ত্রিপুর নৃপতি যার ডরে এড়ে দেশ।
পর্ব্বত গহ্বরে গিয়া করিল প্রবেশ॥
গজবাজিকর দিয়া করিল সম্মান।
মহাবন মধ্যে তাঁর পুরীর নির্ম্মাণ॥
অদ্যাপি ভয় না দিল মহামতি॥
তথাপি আতঙ্কে বৈসে ত্রিপুর নৃপতি॥
আপনে নৃপতি সম্ভাষিয়া বিশেষে।
সুখে বসে লস্কর আপনার দেশে॥
দিনে দিনে বাড়ে তার রাজ সম্মান।
যাবৎ পৃথিবী থাকে সন্ততি তাহান॥
পণ্ডিতে পণ্ডিতে সভাখণ্ড মহামতি।
একদিন বসিলেক বান্ধব সংহতি॥
শুনন্ত ভারত তবে অতি পুণ্যকথা।
মহামুনি জৈমুনি কহিল সংহিতা॥
অশ্বমেধ কথা শুনি প্রসন্নহৃদয়।
সভাখণ্ডে আদেশিল খান মহাশয়॥
দেশী ভাষায় এই কথা রচিল পয়ার।
সঞ্চোরৌক কীর্ত্তি মোর জগৎ সংসার॥

"One day while Chhuti Khān was seated in his court in the company of scholars and friends, he seemed to be much delighted on hearing the story of the sacred Mahābhārata. He heard the Açvamedha Parva, written by the great sage Jaimuni, and expressed a wish to his courtiers that the book might be translated into the vernacular dialect. If any courtier of his would undertake and complete the task, it would add lustre to his glory throughout the country. Placing the garland of royal order upon the head, Çrīkaraṅa Nandī composed the poem in Payāra."

**The poet's flattery.**

The reference to the king of Tipperah in the above extracts is a distortion of historical facts made by the poet to please his master. Early in the 16th century Dhānya Mānikya was the king of Tippera. He was a powerful monarch who, with the help of his celebrated general Chaichāg, had successfully checked the advance of the invading Muhammadan armies into his territories by adopting prompt and vigorous measures; and Chhuti Khān had to remain contented with his possessions in the Chittagong hills.

**A list of thirty-one writers.**

We have come across thirtyone old writers in all, who compiled translations of the whole or portions of the Mahābhārata. We give a list of them below :—

(1) Mahābhārata by Sañjaya.

(2) Bhārata Pānchālī written by the orders of Nasarata Sāha (not yet recovered).

(3) Mahābhārata by Kavīndra Parameçvara.

(4) Açvamedha Parva by Çrīkaraṅa Nandī.

(5) Do do by Dwija Abhirāma.

(6) Çānti Parva by Kriṣṅānanda Vasu (Mss. found dated 1694 A.D.)

(7) Açvamedha Parva by Ānanda Miçra.

(8) Mahābhārata by Nityānanda Ghoṣa.

(9) Açvamedha Parva by Dwija Rām Chandra Khān.

(10) Mahābhārata by Dwija Kavi Chandra.

(11) Ādiparva to Bhārata Parva by Çaraṅa.

(12) Bhārata by Ṣaṣthībara.

(13) Ādiparva and Açvamedha Parva by Gangā Dās Sen.

(14) Ādiparva by Rājendra Dās.

(15) Droṅa Parva by Gupi Nath Datta.

(16) Mahābhārata by Rāmeçvar Nandī.

(17) Do by Kāçī Rām Dās.

(18) Bhīṣma Parva, Droṅa Parva and Karṅa Parva by Nandarām Dās (adopted son of Kāçīrām Dās).

(19) Mahābhārata by Trilochana Chakravartī.

(20) Do by Nemāi Dās.

(21) Droṅa Parva by Dvaipāyaṅa Dās.

(22) Bhārata by Ballava Dās.

(23) Açvamedha Parva by Dwija Kriṣṅarām.

(24) Do by Dwija Raghunāth.

(25) The Nala Upakhyan by Loknāth Datta.

(26) Do by Madhusudan Nāpit.

(27) The story of Sāvitrī by Çiva Chandra Sen.

(28) Bhārata by Bhrigurām Dās.

(29) Açvamedha Parva by Dwija Rāmakriṣṇa.

(30) Do by Bhārat Pandit.

(31) Mahābhārata compiled by the order of Dharma Māṅikya, king of Tippera.

**The original & its translations.**

Of these writers Kavindra Parmeçvara, as we have said, translated nearly the whole of the Mahābhārata, and amongst others,—Saṣthivara, Rāmeçvar Nandi, Trilochan Chakravarty, Nityānanda Ghoṣa, Nimāi Dās, Ballabha Dev, and Bhrigurām Dās also attempted to translate the whole of the epic. Translations, in those days, as I have said, were not closely restricted to the texts. Besides omissions and changes, stories and incidents were freely added to the poems by the writers. The Bengali recensions, as compared with the original of Vyāsa, appear to be, in many respects, quite different poems. One would hardly find in many of these works a score of lines together which would conform to the Sanskrit text. The Ramāyaṅa and Mahābhārata were, so to speak, reborn in these Bengali recensions, which resembled the Sanskrit epic only as the child does its father. They offer many striking points of difference which cannot be ignored. In the history of these differences is to be found the peculiar bent of the Bengali genius which, moulding the great epics in its own way, gave the Bengali recensions an air of originality of which we shall have to speak hereafter.

**Çakuntalā by Rājendra Dās.**

Of the episodes translated from the Mahābhārata, the story of Çakuntalā by Rājendra Dās, who flourished in the middle of the 17th century, is one of the best that we have found in the whole

book. Though mainly following the Sanskrit text of Vyāsa, the poet is indebted to Kāli Dās's Çakuntalā and to Bhatti Kāvya, from which he culls many beautiful blossoms to adorn his tale. The fine poetical touch in—"There was no tank without its wealth of lilies, no lilies without bees, and no bees that did not hum under the enchantment of the honey,"—is evidently borrowed from a well-known passage in Bhatti Kāvya.

**Draupadī fights.**

In the Droṅa Parva by Gapīnāth Datta, Draupadī, the wife of the Pāndavas, comes to the battle-field and fights. We do not find anything of this nature in the Sanskrit Epic. The author probably wrote from his imagination.

**Gaurī Mangal.**

In 1806 A.D. Rājāh Prithvī Chandra of Pākur wrote a poem in Bengali named Gaurī Mangal. The work is interesting to us for its preface, in which he takes a bird's eye view of old Bengali literature, and gives us a list of some of the noteworthy Bengali writers, who had preceded him. He refers thus to the translations of the Mahābhārata :—

"Eighteen Parvas of the Mahābhārata were rendered into Bengali verses by Kaçirām Dās and before him by Nityānanda."

**Nityānanda Ghos's Mahābhārata.**

In Eastern Bengal, the Mahābhārata by Sañjaya and by Kavīndra Parmeçvara once enjoyed great popularity, but in Western Bengal Nityānanda Ghoṣ's Mahābhārata was in high favour with the people until the advent of Kaçirām Dās. We know very little of Nityānanda Ghoṣ; but that Kaçirām Dās, whose Mahābhārata yields to no Bengali book in its popularity amongst the masses excepting perhaps the Rāmāyaṅa by Krittivāsa,

drew largely from Nityānanda Ghoṣ's work, which was earlier in the field, admits of no doubt. The Kathakas and the professional singers of the Purāṅas had already popularised the story of the Mahābhārata in the country. Those amongst them who attained celebrity, by their proficiency in the art of recitation and singing, found numerous engagements all over the province. In their professional tours they visited all the important villages of the country, and thus the very language they used became familiar to the people. It is probably owing to this reason, that in all the Bengali recensions of the Mahābhārata, from Sañjaya and Kavīndra to Kaçī Dās and even to more modern writers, we frequently come across the same lines almost word for word, as if the authors whose fields of activity lay at different places and who lived at remote distances of time from one another, had copied from the same source. If this is, generally speaking, true of the different Bengali recensions of Sanskrit works in our old literature, it is most of all so in the case of Kaçīrām Dās's work and that of Nityānanda which preceded it. We often find page upon page of the two works to be almost identical, the slight difference, observable in the two works, is no more than what we may find in two different manuscripts of the same book. We have evidence to prove that Kaçīrām Dās did not himself write the whole of the Mahābhārata, the authorship of which is attributed to him; and in many portions he simply revised Nityānanda's compositions and incorporated them in his work. Kaçīrām Dās was, however, an expert recensionist and showed much originality in his work. This

**Why do the various recensions so closely agree.**

**Kaçirām & Nityānanda.**

point will be dealt with hereafter. In the meantime let us refer our readers to two stray passages of the two recensions (*viz.* one by Nityānanda and the other by Kāçīrām Dās) to shew how closely the two texts agree with each other. One extract will be sufficient for both, the slight difference being indicated in the footnote:—

**The Lamentation of Gāndhārī.**

* "When Kriṣṇa's consoling words she heard, she was restored to consciousness. The chaste Gāndhārī, daughter of Vichitravīryya and Queen of Dhritarāṣtra, said again to Kriṣṇa, "Behold Kriṣṇa—my hundred powerful sons lie dead on the field, struck by the iron mace of Bhīma. O, look, my daughters-in-law, all princesses, are crying most bitterly—those whom the sun or the moon could not see,—whose body is tender as Çirīṣa flower, and whose beauty is a wonder, which the sun stops his chariot in the sky to observe—these ladies have come to the field of

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গান্ধারী বিলাপ।

* কৃষ্ণের প্রবোধ বাক্য মনেতে বুঝিয়া।
উঠিয়া বসিলা দেবী চেতন পাইয়া॥
পুনঃ বলে কৃষ্ণকে গান্ধারী পতিব্রতা।
বিচিত্রবীর্য্যের বধূ রাজার বণিতা॥
দেখ কৃষ্ণ একশত পুত্র মহাবল।
ভীমের গদার ঘাতে মরিল সকল॥
দেখ কৃষ্ণ বধূ সব উচ্চৈঃস্বরে কাঁদে।
দেখিতে না পারে যারে সূর্য্য আর চাঁদে॥

Kurukṣetra, poorly dressed and with hair dishevelled. Look at them, they are singing wildly—owing to excess of grief—their voice is heard like the sound of the lute of Nārada. There, some widows, maddened by grief, have taken weapons in their hands and hero-like are dancing wildly,—I cannot bear it; I cannot find peace anywhere. O, where is my son Duryyodhana! Where has he gone leaving his mother! Look at his condition now, O Kriṣṇa. Over his head the regal umbrella of gold used to be spread. His body which was bedecked with pearls lies low in the dust!"

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শিরীষ কুসুম জিনি সুকোমল তনু।
দেখিয়া যাহার রূপ রথ রাখে ভানু।
হেন সব বধূগণ আইল কুরুক্ষেত্রে।
মুক্তকেশ হীনবেশ দেখহ সাক্ষাতে॥
ঐ দেখ নৃত্য করে নারী পতিহীনা।
শ্রুতিশব্দ শুনি যেন নারদের বীণা॥
পতিহীনা কত নারী বীরবেশ ধরি।
ঐ দেখ নৃত্য করে হাতে অস্ত্র করি॥
সহিতে না পারি শোক শান্ত নহে মন।
মাএ এড়ি কোথা গেল পুত্র দুর্য্যোধন॥
ওহে কৃষ্ণ হের দেখ পুত্রের অবস্থা।
যাহার মস্তকে ছিল সুবর্ণের ছাতা॥
নানা আভরণে যার তনু সুশোভন।
সে তনু ধূলায় ঐ দেখ নারায়ণ॥

**From Nityānanda Ghoṣ's Mahābhārata.**

Kāçī Dās gives exactly the same poem with the following alterations. In the 3rd line, in the place of

This almost *verbatim* agreement cannot be explained by the fact of the two works' being equally translations from a common Sanskrit original. As I have said, Bengali recensions scarcely ever follow their texts closely; and in this instance the difference between the original and what is belived to be its translation, is really similar to that between the deep and measured tone of a European organ and the soft and melodious lay of an Indian lute.

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**Kaçīrām Dās, a poet of the people.**

We now come to Kaçīrām Dās, admittedly the best of all recensionists of the Mahābhārata. He draws largely from the preceding writers. Indeed his purpose is to revise their works and incorporate them in his own. But in spite of this, his poetic individuality is deeply impresed on many of those lines with which he illumines their compositions. But this is not all. He introduces episodes not to be found in the original Mahābharata, nor in any extant translation earlier than his own: and it is mainly in these additions that he displays the peculiar traits of his poetry. Kāçīrām Dās was a poet of the people. Indeed his education, scope of intelligence and mode of treatment of his subjects were all such as to meet the requirements of the masses. Those deep problems of the soul, which are worked out in so many chapters of the original Mahābhārata, he scarcely

পুনঃ বলে, we find কহে কিছু; the 12th line reads ছিন্ন-কেশ মত্তবেশ দেখ তুমি নেত্রে; in the 16th line, we read কণ্ঠশব্দ for শ্রুতিশব্দ: in the 20th line, there is তাজি for এড়ি: in the 21st, দুর্গতি for অবস্থা: and in the 22nd ছাতি for ছাতা।

notices, or if he touches them at all, he dismisses very briefly. He narrates a story in an intensely popular fashion. His dogmatic pronouncements on religious matters and great reverence for the Brāhmins are all characterestic of the views and beliefs of the crowd, and he scarcely ever rises above their level in the narration of the story of the great epic. He often worries the readers by repetition of common places ; his exaggerations, besides, are such as sometimes to verge on the grotesque. But throughout his writings one feels a constant current of devotion, which flows like a noble stream purging and refining all grossness, and beautifying what is awkward and inelegant. The strength of popular Indian Literature lies in the vehemance of faith which underlies its somewhat vulgar humour.

**The devotional element.**

There are many passages in Kāçīrām Dās's Mahābhārata which bear testimony to his ardour of belief, and in such passages, the Bengali recensionist wonderfully develops the materials at his command. The episode of the insult to Bibhīṣaṅ, which does not occur at all in the original of Vyāsa, is introduced by Kāçīrām with singularly happy effect. The piece shews the grandeour of Judhiṣthir's Rājsuya sacrifice which was, it is said, attended by all the princes living in the vast continent, bounded on the North by the North Kurus, on the West by the dominions of the Jādavas, on the East by the Sea and on the South by Ceylon. Here had come King Joy Sen of Giribraja (Bhāgalpur) with his gigantic array of boats that "covered sixty miles of the Ganges." Here was the Lord of

**Insult to Bibhisaṅ.**

Chedi with numerous feudatory chiefs who waited at the gate for days till he could obtain entrance into the Great Hall. Here the King Dirghajanghā of Ayodhyā (Oudh), with a picturesque array of noble steeds, elephants, and camels, patiently awaited the command of the Great Emperor; and other mighty princes, too many in number to be mentioned, approached Yudhiṣthir with presents of immense gold, silver, pearls, diamonds, corals, invaluable stuff made of silk, fur and cotton,—big tuskers, musk-bearing deer and curious animals as horses with horns,—nay the very gods of Heaven were present here to do honour to Yudhiṣthira. In this grand assembly Bibhiṣaṅ, the King of Laṅkā, declined to bow down before Yudhiṣthira, saying that he never bowed to any body on the earth except to Kriṣṅa —the divine Incarnation. Insulted at every gate, in which the king of Rakṣhasas witnessed the grandeour of the Rājsuya Sacrifice, he still persisted in his determination not to do homage to the paramount Emperor. Kriṣṅa vainly tried to convince him of the greatness of Yudhiṣthira and when Bibhiṣaṅ was still inexorable in his attitude of pride, the Lord took to a device to humiliate him.

Entering the great Hall, Kriṣṅa found Yudhiṣthira seated on his throne situated on a flight of 100 steps, and himself taking his stand above fifty steps manifested himself in his Viçwa-Rupa. Yudhiṣthira seated behind him could not see this manifestation of his divinity, but all others present saw it. Suddenly tiaras of gold crowns—a thousand of them—shone forth from the Divine Head. The astonished multitude saw thousands of arms holding resplendent weapons, thousands of eyes, that looked like solar orbs—

the diamond Kaustava—the great bow Sāranga—the conch Pāñchajanya, the mace and the lotus—the sacred enblems of Divinity. This appeared as a vision too glorious, not only for human sight, but even for that of the gods. The great god Çiva had come to see the Rajsuya Sacrifice under the guise of a Yogi, but the sight made him unconscious, and he revealed himself to all by falling at the feet of Kriṣṇa. Brāhma also fainted there and his rosary and *kamandalu* dropped from his hands as he fell prostrate. Indra, the holder of the thunderbolt, with his host of gods, fell stunned by the sight, at the feet of Kriṣṇa, and all the princes, Bibhīṣan not being excepted, that had assembled there, fell prostrate at this glorious vision which even the gods could not bear to look upon. Thus Kriṣṇa made the vast assembly of gods and men bowed down in reverence apparently before the royal throne on which sat Judhiṣthira in full glory. Pointing to this phenomenal sight of the bowing down of all, Kriṣṇa addressed Judhiṣthira calling him the mightiest of all monarchs, to whom even the great gods had made their obeisance. The humble reply of Judhiṣthira shewed his devotion to the Lord, his great meekness and piety. The story thought crude in many respects, is a masterpiece of tender faith and it is in this point that Kāçi Dās always excels.

**A brief account of the poet.**

Kāçirām Dās was born in the village of Singi in Perg. Indrāni in the district of Burdwan. This village is situated on the river Brāhmanī, and it was formerly known as Siddha or Siddhi. The poet belonged to the Kāyastha caste, and his brothers and son were all gifted with poetic talent.

His elder brother Kriṣṇa Dās wrote a poem describing the events of Kriṣṇa's life. The third brother, Gadādhara, wrote a very elegant book in honour of Jagannāth of Puri in 1645 A. D. and named it "Jagat Mangala." From a reference to the Mahābhārata by Kāçirām Dās in the above poem, we conclude that the former work was written before 1645 A. D.; and in fact we have further evidences of this, which will be dealt with hereafter. Kāçirām Dās's adopted son Nandarām Dās (a son of the poets' brother Gadādhar) wrote the Drona Parva, which we find incorporated with Kāçirām's Mahābhārata, though the authorship of that Parva is popularly ascribed to Kāçirām. There is a saying current in the country to the effect that Kāçirām Dās died after having finished the Ādi, Sabhā, Bana and portions of the Virāta Parvas. The easy flow of verses characterised by its Sanskritic expressions, which indicate the poetic individuality of Kāçirām Dās is traceable in those cantos which are ascribed to him in the saying; and we believe that the latter part of the Mahābhārata consists mostly of Nityānanda Ghoṣ's writings revised and incorporated into the work, a few more chapters having been added by Nanda Rām, the son of Kāçirām Dās. In these we miss the genial flow of Kāçi Dās's style and that sprinkling of choice Sanskritic expressions which abound in his compositions.*

**The latter portion of the Mahābhārata written by others.**

* Evidences have quite recently been found to substantiate this point. In an old M.S. of this Mahābhārata, Nandarām says that his uncle and father Kāci Dās at the hour of his death regretted the circumstance of not being permitted to live to complete the great work he had undertaken, and piteously asked Nandarām to do the task left unfinished by him.

**Date and other particulars.**

We know very little of the life of Kāçirām Dās. It is said that he was a school-master in the village of Āwāshgarah in the district of Midnapore; and that the above village having been an important resort of the Pandits and Kathakas, who recited the Purāṅas in the house of the local Rājā, Kāçi Dās first conceived the desire to undertake a translation of the Mahābhārata in their learned company. In Singi, the native village of the poet, there is a tank, which is called কাশী পুকুর after him. We are in possession of several dates which have a bearing on his time. The year in which "Jagat Mangal" was written by his brother Gadādhar has already been referred to. We know of a manuscript of Kāçirām Dās's Mahābhārata in the handwriting of Gadādhar; it was written in the year 1632 A. D. Nanda Rām Dās, made a deed of gift to his family priest in 1678 A. D. This must have been drawn up after Kāçi Dās's death, as during the lifetime of his father, Nanda Rām could not possibly have made a gift to the priest—a duty generally devolving upon the head of the family. From these dates we may safely conclude that Kāçirām Dās was born towards the latter part of the 16th century and lived till the middle of the seventeenth. At the instance of some young men of the village Singi, the Vangiya Sahitya Parishat of Calcutta is shewing great activities in raising subscriptions for erecting a suitable memorial in honour of the poet in his native village.

**A memorial in honour of the poet.**

Kāçirām Dās's Mahābhārata and Krittibāsa's Rāmāyana are the two books which have been, for some centuries, *par excellence*, the great educative agencies of Bengal. What may appear as incon-

gruous, crude and unpolished in them is, as I have said, due to the poets having adapted their works to the humble intellectual capacity of our uncultured peasantry, whom it was their aim to elevate. These poets have been, for ages, the fountain-heads from which have flowed wisdom and spirituality, striking the finer chords in the hearts of multitudes of Bengal, and their works are up to the present, a living source of inspiration throughout the country.

**The two great epics have raised the character of the Bengali nation.**

### (*c*) Translations of the Bhāgavata.

**Bhāgavata has a pastoral interest; its contents.**

Next to the Rāmāyaṅa and the Mahābhārata comes the Bhāgavata in order of popularity throughout Bengal. The two epics have a universal interest for all the Hindus, but the Bhāgavata is mainly restricted to the Vaiṣṅavas. Though its circulation is thus narrower, yet its votaries admire it the more highly, in fact it is looked upon by them as the only sacred book and is revered with the Vedās. The Bhāgavata has passages of high poetic merit: its descriptions of the pastoral scenes and rural sports of Kriṣṅa particularly are greatly admired; they have found peculiar favour in Bengal. The scene is laid on the banks of the Jumnā. Kriṣṅa, here, is not only the god of love, but retains his omnipotent character, even as a shepherd boy. King Kaṁsa of Mathura, bent on killing him, sends the demon-nurse Putanā, who with poison in her nipples tried to kill the child, but Kriṣṅa while sucking her breasts draws out her life-blood and kills her. The great demon Triṅāvarta comes riding on a whirl-wind, and the shepherds, who were grazing their cows on the banks of the Jumnā, are awe-struck, when Kriṣṅa, who is with them, pulls the demon down by his hair, and

**Kriṣṅa encounters Putanā, Triṅāvarta, Vaka, Krimira and other demons.**



Four Panels from Book-Covers, taken from the district of Birbhum. These pictures were painted in lacquer on wooden boards. They date from the 16th to early 17th centuries. Produced for the decoration of Bhagabata Literature.

destroys him in the severe fight which ensues. The demons Vaka, Krimira and a host of others, sent by Kaṁsa, are killed in succession by Kriṣṇa. The God Indra, whose worship was forbidden by him, dooms Vrindāvana to destruction, by sending heavy showers of rain for seven consecutive days and nights and exposing it to thunder-storms. But Kriṣṇa holds up the mount Govardhana with the tip of his finger and so makes it a shelter for the village. The thunderer is weary; the stormy winds crash against the rock; the lightning makes deep cavities in it; hail-stones destroy the trees; but beneath lies Vrindāvana snug and cozy,—not one of its herbs is touched, nor a leaf nor a petal of its sweet Kadamva flowers is broken under the surging floods which pass over the rock Govardhana. The accounts of these exploits and victories, however, are but of minor interest in the poem; its main attraction being the pastoral occupation,—the sports and the domestic scenes, descriptions of which are interspersed amongst those of the valourous exploits of Kriṣṇa undertaken to protect his friends who resigned themselves to his care. The tender love of his mother Jaçodā, unwilling to part with him in the mornings, (when his comrades and fellow-shepherd boys call him to join their games and his elder brother Valarāma invites him to the groves by sounding his horn) lest he fall into the snares of Kaṁsa, ever plotting against his life; the beautiful pastimes indulged in by the shepherds, in which Kriṣṇa takes a prominent part;—his love-making with the milk-maids; and above all the deep religious meaning given to each passage by the enlightened Vaiṣṇava interpreters who invest the poem with high devotional

**He holds up the mount Govardhana.**

**The domestic and pastoral scenes.**

**The deep religious meaning.**

significance even in apparently realistic descriptions,—all these combine to make the Bhāgavata one of the most remarkable poems of the world. But as it is written in very academic Sanskrit, it is likely to lose its main charm by translation into non-Sanskritic languages.

**Mālādhar Vasu, the first translator, 1473 A.D.**

Mālādhar Vasu, the first translator of the Bhāgavata in Bengali and a Kāyastha by caste, was a courtier of the Emperor Husen Sāhā at whose orders he commenced translating the tenth and the eleventh cantos of the Bhāgavata in 1473 A. D. and completed the work in 1480 A. D. The work is named Çrikriṣṇa Vijayā. Husen Sāhā conferred on the poet the title of Gunarāja Khan as a reward for his literary services. Mālādhar Vasu was a native of Kulingrāma and belonged to the Vasu family of that place, who at the time wielded great influence and power. The village was fortified and the pilgrims to Puri were required to take a Duri or a kind of passport from the Vasus of Kulinagrāma, without which no one was allowed to visit the shrine. Mālādhar Vasu wrote his work with a facile pen. The easy and graceful flow of his style is very marked throughout the book. I quote here a passage* :—

* প্রভাতে ভোজন করি শিঙ্গা বাজাইয়া।
পিছে পিছে চলে যত বাছুর চালাইয়া ॥
একত্র হইল সবে যমনার তীরে।
নানা মত ক্রীড়া করে দেব দামোদরে ॥
কথাতে কোকিল পক্ষীগণে নাদ করে।
তার সঙ্গে নাদ করে দেব গদাধরে ॥
কথাতে মর্কট শিশু লাফ দেহি রঙ্গে।
সেই মতে যায় কৃষ্ণ বালকের সঙ্গে ॥

"When they had finished eating, the shepherds sounded the horn and marched. The cows followed them, and all assembled on the banks of the Jumnā. On the way, the spirit of fun found many kinds of expression. Here the cuckoos were bilthely singing and Kriṣṇa imitated their notes. There the monkeys were leaping from bough to bough and he and his comrades went climbing and leaping with them. Again, the peacocks were dancing and the lads copied the dance. The birds were flying in the sky, and their shadows on the earth were pursued by Valarāma and Kriṣṇa who danced as they did so. The trees abounded with flowers which they gathered as they went; some Kriṣṇa wore on his head and some he placed on his heart."

**The merry sports of the shepherds.**

The Bengali translation of Mālādhar Vasu, it should be said, is not literal, and Rādhā, whom we do not find mentioned in the Bhāgavata, is introduced in this Bengali recension where the poetic passages describing her deep spiritual love awake the loveliest interest. By this innovation, Mālādhar Vasu strikes the key-note of those love-poems on Kriṣṇa and Rādhā, with which the Vaiṣṇava works of later times abound.

**Rādhā introduced in the poem.**

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কথাতে ময়ুর পক্ষী মধু নাদ করে।
সেই মত নৃত্যকরে দেব দামোদরে॥
কথা কথা পক্ষীএ আকাশে উড়ি যাই।
তার ছায়া সঙ্গে নাচে রাম কাহ্নাই॥
কথা বা সুগন্ধি পুষ্প তুলিয়া মুরারি।
কত হৃদে মস্তকে শ্রবণে কেশে পরি॥

Bhāgavata by Mālādhar Vasu.

**Other translators of the Bhāgavata.**

After Mālādhar Vasu came a host of Bengali recensionists of the Bhāgavata. They generally restricted themselves to the tenth canto of the work. I give a brief notice of these authors and their works below :—

2. Çrikriṣṅa Mangala by Mādhavāchāryya. This work was dedicated to Chaitanya Deva. The author was a pupil of the Tola founded by Chaitanya and was related to him. This work was written early in the 16th century.

3. Çrikriṣṅa Mangala by Nandarām Dās.

4. Çrikriṣṅa Vijaya by Kriṣṅa Dās, a brother of Kāçirām Dās. Kriṣṅa Dās was decorated with the title of Kriṣṅa Kiṅkar, on his writing this work.

5. Gopāl Vijaya by Kavivallabha.

6. Govinda Mangal by Çaṅkara Kavichandra.

7. Gokul Mangal by Bhaktarāma.

8. Kriṣṅa Mangal by Dwija Laksmināth.

All the above-named works are voluminous in size, and were written more than three hundred years ago. Govinda Mangala by Çaṅkara Kavichandra was the most popular of all of these. We have already referred to the other works of Çaṅkara Kavichandra. Of other writers who translated portions, I name some below.

9. Bhāgavata by Nandarām Ghoṣe.

10. Do. by Āditya Rāma.

11. Do. by Abhirāma Dās.

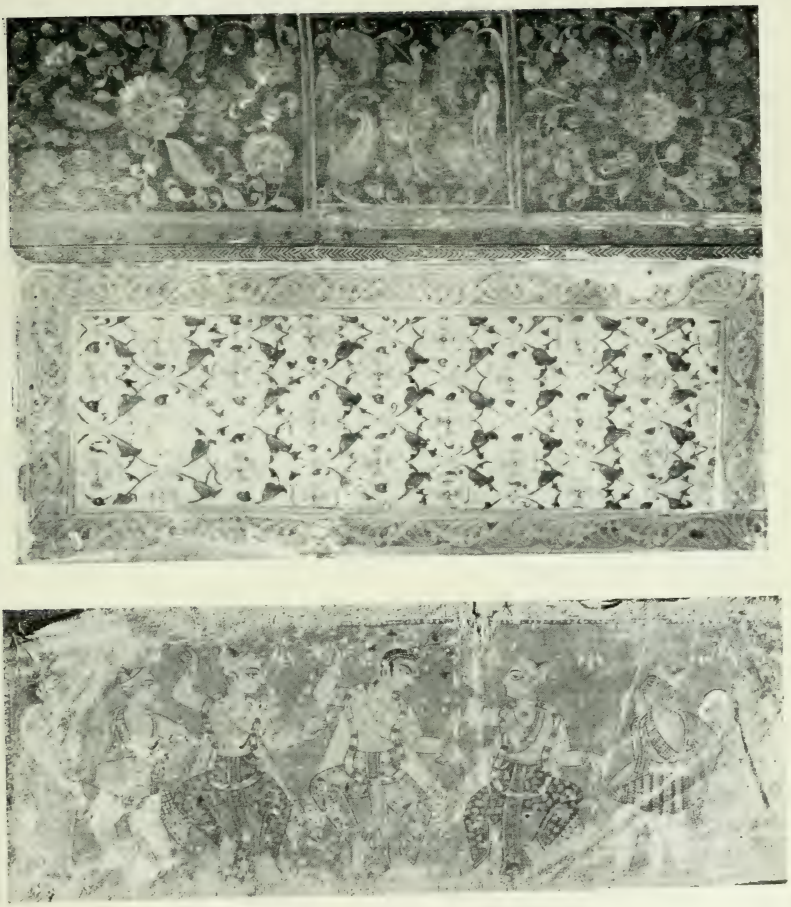
12. Do. by Dwija Bānikantha.

13. Do. by Dāmodar Dās.

14. Do. by Kavi Çekhara.

15. Do. by Yadunandana.

16. Do. by Jaççachandra.



Book-covers from the neighbourhood of Birbhum, 16th and early 17th centuries. The picture proper is generally contained on the inner face of the cover. The floral designs are from the outside (originally) in coloured lacquer on wood.

Here is a list of translators of episodes from the Bhāgavata.

17. Hansadūta by Narasiṁha Dās.
18. Do. by Mādhava Guṅākara.
19. Do. by Kriṣṅa Chandra.
20. Prahlād Charitra by Dwija Kaṁsāri.
21. Do. by Sitārām Dās.
22. Uddhava Saṁvāda by Mādhava.
23. Do. by Rām Sarkār.
24. Do. by Rāmtanu.
25. Dhruva Charitra by Paraçurāma.
26. Do. by Dwija Jayānanda.
27. Sudāma Charitra by Jivana Chakravarti.
28. Do. by Govinda Dās.
29. Do. by Paraçurāma.
30. Uṣāharaṅa by Pitāmbar Sen.
31. Do. by Çrikanṭha Deva.
32. Gajendra Mokṣana by Dwija Durgā Prasād.
33. Do. by Vāmana Bhikṣu.
34. Do. by Bhabānī Dās.
35. Maṅiharaṅa by Kamalā Kanṭha.
36. Vastraharaṅa by Rāmtanu Kaviratna.
37. Gurudakṣiṅā by Vipra Rūparām.
38. Do. by Çyāma Lāl Datta.
39. Do. by Ayodhyārām.
40. Do by Çaṅkarāchāryya.

Of the manuscripts of the above works, none was copied later than the eighteenth century; and the composition of most them is no doubt to be referred to a much earlier period.

**(*d*) Translations of Chandī of Mārkaṇḍeya.**

**Mārkaṇḍeya-Chandī and its contents.**

We now come to another Sanskrit work held in high esteem as a sacred book. Numerous transla-

tions of this work are also to be found in old Bengali literature. This is the Chandī by Mārkaṇḍeya. It describes how the goddess Chandī first manifested herself in heaven. Rājā Suratha was driven from his kingdom by his enemies, who had already subdued the Kols. The Rājā rode a horse and wandered near the hermitage of Mārkaṇḍeya where he met a Vaiçya named Samādhi. This man had immense wealth but his wife and children had taken possession of it and driven him away. In the hermitage the King and the Vaiçya with hearts heavy-laden with grief met and related to each other, the sad story of their misfortunes. They both brooded over their conditions, the king upon his lost kingdom, and the Vaiçya on his wife and children who had so cruelly treated him. The king asked Mārkaṇḍeya, the sage, as to why he could not find peace of mind. What was it that caused him so much pain! He knew that it was unavailing now to grieve over what could not be recovered. He referred also to the condition of his friend the Vaiçya,—his mind still yearning for the sight of his wife and children, though they had ill-treated him. Mārkaṇḍeya said that it was that power of God, which producing phenomena that bear a semblance of truth without being true, blindfolded all living beings. By this power which produces illusion, men are confounded and become unable to distinguish what is true from what is not true. The phenomenal and unreal world seems as real to them; and they ignore God, the only Great Reality. This, the sage said, is the cause of all human woes. This Power of the Supreme Deity is Mahāmāyā (lit. Great illusion) or Chandī—personated as a goddess whose mercy alone, it was

**Rājā Suratha and the Vaiçya.**

**Theory of illusion.**

urged, could assuage the pain of troubled hearts. We need not enter into the philosophy of this faith. It is a solution of the problem of evils, arrived at, from a point of view, other than that in which a god of evil matches his power against a god of good. Being asked how this goddess came into existence, Mārkaṇḍeya said that she who appears as the phenomena of the Universe is eternal, but people trace her origin from that time when she first became manifest to the gods. Here the sage gives a mythological story. At one time the demon Mahiṣāsura became so powerful that he took possession by force of the kingdom of heaven, driving away Indra its king, and the god of death, of wealth, and of ocean who were his associates and officers. Crestfallen and humiliated they wandered for a time on earth, bemoaning their lot, and then went to Vaikuṇṭha, with Brahmā at their head, and applied to Viṣṇu—the greatest god of the Hindu Trinity, for help. Viṣṇu heard the story of the misfortunes that had befallen them and anger flashed from his brow. Simultaneously on the angry faces of Çiva and Brahmā, appeared the same terrible light. The other gods were also moved by sudden anger and from that vast assembly sparks of fire arose like a terrible conflagration and extended to the farthest limits of the firmament. This fire, which appeared as a destructive force, gradually gathered itself together and took the shape of a goddess resplendent in glory, who stood majestically before the mighty host of gods. The sparks of godly power from Çiva created the queen-like majesty of the face of the goddess,

**The mythological story.**

those from Yama created her mass of black hair which fell behind her like the clouds. Her arms were made by the sparks that immanated from Viṣṅu. The Sun god saturated every pore of her body with his rays; her eye-brows were created by the power of Sandhyā —the goddess of evening, and her third eye on the forehead which shone fiercely was born of the power of Agni—god of fire. Earth trembled under the feet of this majestic goddess and her crown touched the skies. The gods in concert chanted her glory. Kriṣṅa gave her his divine discus, Çiva his great trident, Varuṅa his conches, Indra his thunder-bolt and Brahmā his rosary. Viçvakarma gave her his axe, a necklace and a pair of Nupura. The god of ocean gave her a garland of lotuses which never fade. The goddess who was thus an outcome of the united power and glory of all the gods, challenged Mahiṣāsura to a fight, and killed him in the severe contest which ensued. In subsequent times when the gods were pressed by the demons Çambhu and Niçambhu, she again came to their rescue and killing the demonic brothers, restored Indra to his throne. Suratha, the king and Samādhi the Vaiçya, afterwards obtained their lost possessions by the grace of this goddess. This is briefly the tale, as related in the Chandī by Mārkandeya. Though it gives a mythological account, it contains high metaphysical truths embodying in them the essence of the Vedāntic philosophy. The Durgāpujā festival, which is held with great *eclat* in Bengal, commemorates the victory of Chandī or Durgā over Mahiṣāsura.

**Vedantic philosophy in Chandī.**

**The Durga Pujā.**

Of those who translated 'Chandī' into Bengali we shall here mention a few. The first of

**The translators of Chandī. Bhavāni Prasād-the blind poet.**

them was Bhavāṇi Prasād Kar, a Vaidya by caste who lived in the earlier part of the 16th Century. Here are a few lines from the long autobiographical account that he gives of himself.

"I was born in a Vaidya family of Kāhthāliā (in the district of Mymensing). I have attempted to compose this poem in honour of Durgā (Chandī). She has made me miserable from my birth. Providence did not grant me eyes. I have taken refuge at the feet of Durgā, having no place to stand on in this world."*

After having described his domestic troubles chiefly brought about by the wickedness of his nephew, he says,—"I was born in the Kar family of Kāhthāliā. My father's name is Nayan Kriṣṇa Kar. God created me without eyes. So I do not know the alphabet and cannot write."†

His translation of Chandī is very close to the text,—a novel feature in a work of this class, for which we ought to be thankful to the blind poet, but as he did not know how to read or write, and

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* নিবাস কাটালিয়া গ্রাম বৈদ্য কুলজাত।
দুর্গার মঙ্গল বোলে ভবানীপ্রসাদ॥
জন্মকাল হৈতে কালী করিলা দুঃখিত।
চক্ষুহীন করি বিধি করিলা লিখিত॥
মনে দঢ়াইয়াছি আমি কালীর চরণ।
দাঁড়াইতে আমার নাহিক কোন স্থান॥

† কাটালিয়া গ্রামে করবংশেতে উৎপত্তি।
নয়নকৃষ্ণ নামে রায় তাঁহার সন্ততি॥
জন্ম অন্ধ বিধাতা যে করিলা আমারে।
অক্ষরপরিচয় নাহি লিখিবার তরে॥

had to depend upon his ear, to acquire the art of poetical composition, his rhyming is not faultless. There is a nice distinction between mā and nā, tā and thā, and tā and dā in Bengali which at once strikes the eye when looking over a written page but which we often miss in the spoken form of the language. Thus poor Bhavāni Prasād's poem displays faults which in his case were almost unavoidable; yet his work is creditable notwithstanding these drawbacks, and though he is not a blind Homer or a blind Milton of Bengal, yet he is our blind Bhavāni Prasād for aught he is worth, and deserves our praise. We quote below a passage from his translation to shew how the blind poet often retained the sublimity of the classical poem by the very unassuming simplicity of his style which closly immitated the original.

**Defect in rhyming.**

**The sublimity of the classical poem retained.**

"Thou, O Goddess, that dwellest in all, manifesting thyself in the intelligence of the created beings, a hundred times do I salute Thee.

"Thou that dwellest in the hearts of all manifesting Thyself in human kindness, a hundred times do I salute Thee.

"Thou that revealest Thyself in all pervading motherly love, a hundred times do I salute Thee.*

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* যেহি দেবী বুদ্ধিরূপে সর্ব্বভূতে থাকে।
নমস্কার নমস্কার নমস্কার তাকে॥
যেহি দেবী দয়ারূপে সর্ব্বভূতে থাকে।
নমস্কার নমস্কার নমস্কার তাকে॥
যেহি দেবি মাতৃরূপে সর্ব্বভূতে থাকে।
নমস্কার নমস্কার নমস্কার তাকে॥

The next writer who translated 'Chandi' was Rūpanārāyaṅ Ghoṣa—a Kāyastha. Rūpanārāyaṅ was born about the year 1597 A. D. He was a native of Āmdālā in the sub-division of Mānikganj in the district of Dacca. He was well-versed in the Sanskrit classics but did not closely follow the text. He showed his erudition and poetical powers by importing poetical ideas from various Sanskrit poems into his translation to which he also added passages from his own fancy.

**Rupanārāyan Ghosa Born 1597 A.D.**

We next came across Chandī by Vrajalāl. Judging by the language, it appears that this poem was written about the same time as Rūpnārāyan's. But the next work on Chandī by Yadu Nāth displays a far greater power than most of the preceding works of this class. Yadu Nāth was born in Çarkhābārī on the river Ghāgat in Perg. Andhu (Police Station, Mithāpur) in the district of Rangpur. His work was written in the latter part of the 17th century. We quote a passage from the poem in which he describes the union of Çiva and Umā who are so blended as to form one figure. This figure is known in Hindu mythology as Ardhanāriçvara. Bengali poets and painters alike have applied their talent to the representation of this figure which seems to have a peculiar charm for them. There are three figures in our pantheon which illustrate such a blending: (1) Çiva and Umā, (2) Çiva and Viṣṅu, (3) Kriṣṅa and Rādhā. We quote from Yadunāth to illustrate the first, and from Kaçidās to shew the second.

**Vrajalāl.**

**Jadunāth.**

**Ardhanariçwar.**

"My life has to-day been made blessed by seeing Çiva and Umā united in a single form. On one side are beautiful black locks and on the other a thick array

of loosely hanging matted hair. On half the breast hangs a garland of heavenly Pārijat flowers, on the other half, beads of Rudrākṣa strung together to from a rosary. The left half of the figure is scented with rich sandal perfumes, and the right half is covered with the dust of the funeral ground. On the left half the finest apparel appears whose colour shines like the sun and on the other a tiger's skin brought from the forests!—Umā and Çiva blended in one. To the feet of both Yadunāth offers his humble worship in the cadence of Goura Sārang."* This image carries a mystic significance amongst enlightened Çaivas. The form of Umā represents the fineness and delicacy of earthly life and that of Çiva, the grimness of death. Here, as in the actual world, life and death are united ;—from the smiles of youth the wrinkles of age are inseparable,—the flower that blooms and the flower that fades

**Life and Death united.**

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* আজি কি পেখনু সম্মিলিত হরগৌরী।
সফল ভজরে নয়নযুগল মেরি॥
চাঁচর বেণী বিরাজিত কাঁহ
কাঁহ পরলম্বিত বিনোদ জরাউ॥
পারিজাতমালা গলে গিরিবালা।
গিরিগণ্ডে দোলে লোহিতাক্ষমালা॥
মলয়জপঙ্কপ্রলেপ অঙ্গ চারু।
চিতাধূলিভূষণ ত্রিজগতগুরু॥
লোহি লোহিতাম্বরঅরুণ জিনি সোহা।
বাঘাম্বর কাঁহ দলজদল মোঁহা॥
হরগৌরী নিরখে গৌরীসারং লোকাই।
যদুনাথ উভয়চরণে বলি জাই॥
Jadunāth.

appear on the same bough. This embrace of life by death is a common phenomenon, and the Hindu devotee does not see in it anything to strike terror to his heart or make him sad. He takes it as a fact of the immutable law of nature and views it with a feeling of reverence which inspires his songs with poetry.

**Çiva and Viṣṇu.**

The next figure of this sort is that of Çiva and Viṣṇu. Viṣṇu here is the God of glory—of power and of life, and Çiva that of death. They are united in one image.*

" They merged one in the other and became united in one form. Half the body was covered with ashes and the other half with sweet scented Kasturi. From one half the head hung matted locks, and from the other flowing curls of finest hair. Over one half the head, the serpent hissed, the other was illumined by a glorious crown. On half the brow

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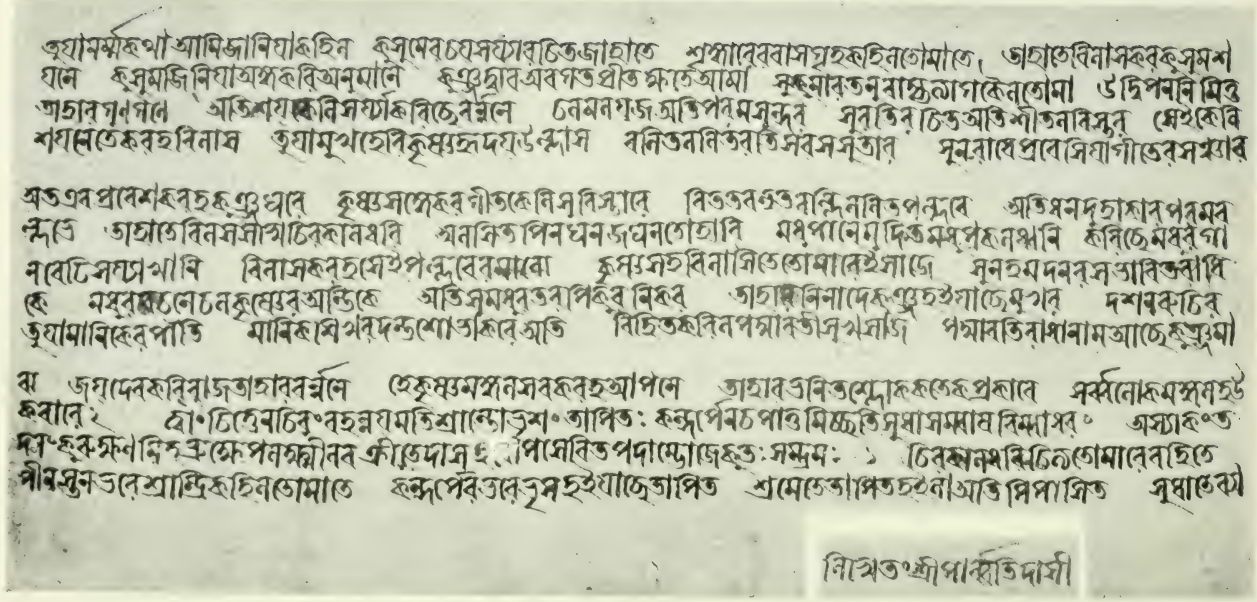
* " আলিঙ্গনে যুগল শরীর হৈল এক।
অর্দ্ধ ভস্মভূষা হৈল কস্তুরী অর্দ্ধেক ॥
অর্দ্ধ জটাজুট অর্দ্ধ চিকুর চাঁচর।
অর্দ্ধেক কিরীট অর্দ্ধ ফণি ফণাধর ॥
কস্তুরী তিলক অর্দ্ধ অর্দ্ধ বহ্নিজ্বালা।
অর্দ্ধ গলে হাড়মাল অর্দ্ধ বনমালা ॥
মকরকুণ্ডল কর্ণে কুণ্ডলীকুণ্ডল।
শ্রীবৎসলাঞ্ছন অর্দ্ধ শোভিত গরল ॥
অর্দ্ধ মলয়জ অর্দ্ধ ভস্মকলেবর।
অর্দ্ধ বাঘাম্বর কটি অর্দ্ধ পীতাম্বর ॥
এক পদে ফণী একে কনক নূপুর।
শঙ্খচক্র করে শোভে ত্রিশূলডম্বুর ॥" Kaçi Dās.

appeared the sweet-scented print of the Kasturi and on the other blazed flames of fire. Half the neck was wreathed with flowers, about the other half, hung bones. From one ear hung the pendants and the glorious earing bearing the emblem of Makara, and from the other small serpents, coiling into the form of a ring. On half the neck there was the brilliant diamond Kaustuva and on the other the blue mark of poison. Half the figure scented with sandal perfumes and the other half covered with the dust of the funeral ground. From half the body hung a loose tiger's skin and the other half was apparelled in rich purple. On one of the feet was the sweet sounding Nupura and on the other a ring of serpents. Two hands held conch and discus and the other two the trident and the Ḍumbura."

Here also the world is emblemed in a highly poetic language and in a manner which appeals seriously to the Hindu mind. The sublime and the beautiful in nature, the elegance and glory of life, pass into the desolation of the cremation-ground. This figure is sacred amongst Hindus as embodying the facts of life without ignoring those of death, and both are placed side by side in their natural harmony, instead of that grim contrast in which they are generally regarded elsewhere.

**The union of various cults.**

Another significant point in the conception of this blending of the deities is that it could only be possible when the various sects of the Hindus—the Çaivas, the Çāktas and the Vaiṣṇavas were so far reconciled as to accept one another's ideal in religion.



Page of old Bengali M.S. of Gita Govinda, from Birbhum District. Date about 1650 A.D. written by a woman Parvati Dasi.

It should be said that the description of Ardhanariçwar given from the peom of Yadunāth does not occur in the original Chandī by the sage Mārkandeya.

**Chandī by Kamalanārāyana 1717 A.D.**

The next translation of Chandī was from the pen of Kamalanārāyana, a son of Yadunāth. This poem contains many passages which are truly poetic. It was written about the year 1717. The Mahammadan Governor of Bengal to whom he refers in his book was probably Sāha Sujā, son of the Mogal Emperor Sāha Jāhān.

**Other translations.**

The translations of other works such as Padmāvata by Alāol and Gitagovinda by Rasamaya and Giridhar, do not fall within the scope of the Paurāṇic Renaissance, so we shall refer to them in a future chapter.

**Translations stamped with originality.**

The writers of the works, dealt with in this chapter, did not, as I have already said, proceed on the plan of literal translation ; that would have given them only a literary interest. The translations were reproductions of ancient ideas with modern accretion of thought, meant to act as a living force for the education and ennoblement of the people,—the element of philosophical interpretation was an innovation which gave them a stamp of originality peculiar to the Bengali genius.

### 3. The conception of Çiva in the Renaissance and Songs in honour of him.

**The later Çaiva-literature.**

The later form of Çaiva-literature contains the leading characteristics of the Renaissance period, though it lost a good deal of its importance as the songs of Çiva no longer formed the main theme of

Bengali songs. We require to write in some detail how Çaivism was gradually pushed into a corner by the advancing Sākta cult.

**Other deities lavish favours upon their worshippers.**

The inertness of Çiva in old Bengali poems is very well-marked. Chandi in that literature is an extremely active deity; so is Manasā Devi, and all those other divinities in whose honour poems were composed in old Bengali. These Gods and Goddesses would not have borne to see a tear in the eyes of their worshippers; whenever they fall into danger they are sure to obtain succour. A Chandi, a Manasā Devi, even a Çitalā or a Satyanārāyāṅa is always devising plans as to how a devotee may be rescued from danger, how scoffers may be put down or how the earthly prosperity of believers may be increased. But Çiva the Great God is inert and immovable. In the poem of Chandi, Dhanapati Sadāgara is exposed to all imaginable dangers: he is thrown into a gloomy dungeon, where a stone, heavy enough to crush the strongest man is placed on his person. At the moment when his sufferings are the greatest, Chandi appears to him and calls upon him to have faith in her, promising him great rewards. Dhanapati replies—"Even though in this dungeon my life goes out, I will not worship any other deity than Çiva."* In Manasār Bhāsāna we find Chānd Sadāgara put through the most harrowing trials because he will not worship Manasā Devi. Yet he remains firm in his devotion to Çiva. "I will not defile the hand with which I worship Çiva by offering worship to Manasā Devi, that goddess who is blind

* "যদি বন্দীশালে মোর বাহিরায় প্রাণী।
মহেশ ঠাকুর বিনে অন্য নাহি জানি॥" Kavi Kankan

of one eye."*—he said in great contempt when he was offered prosperity and happiness provided he agreed to worship Manasā Devī. King Chandra-Ketu in Çītalāmangal, inspite of his great troubles would not worship Çītalā Devī and remained true to Çiva. But what do the followers of Çiva gain as the reward for their heroic devotion to his cause! The great Çiva passive and inert, cares not for the sufferings of his followers. So it is no wonder that the followers of other deities who lavished favour upon the believers and undertook to destroy their enemies and confer wealth and prosperity without being asked, increased daily in number, till the poems in honour of Çiva, though forming a part of the earliest literature of Bengal, were gradually overshadowed by larger and more poetic compositions in honour of Manasā Devī, Chandī and Satyanārāyaṅa.

**While Çiva is indifferent to his worshippers.**

**Çaiva-literature goes to the background.**

The Muhammadans with their vigorous living faith, had by this time come to Bengal. Their Koraṅ which they believed to be inspired, lays it down that the God of Islām helps believers and destroys unbelievers. The strong belief of Islām in a personal God had to be counteracted in this country by forms of religion in which the personal element of divinity predominated. So the Çākta and the Vaiṣṅava religions flourished and the Çaiva religion with its impersonal ideal and mysticism in which man rose to the level of his God in the Advaitabāda, was gradually thrown into the back-

**The Struggle to counter act Islamite influence and the development of the Çākta and Vaiṣṅava cults.**

* "যে হস্তেতে পূজি আমি দেব শূলপাণি.
সে হস্তে না পূজিব চেঙ্গ মুড়ি কাণি।"
Ketakā Dās.

ground, as the masses did not comprehend its speculative features.

**Çaivaism.**

The enlightened Çaivas attempted to reach a stage where the human soul is said to become so elevated as to be identical with the divine spirit. শিবোঽহং শিবোঽহং, I am Çiva, I am Çiva, was uttered by the great propounder of the Çaiva cult Çri Çaṅkarācharyya in the 7th century, and his followers tried to imitate him.

**Çiva and Çakti.**

Çiva represents, in the eyes of the enlightened, a spiritual principle, which to use a philosophical expression, may be called the noumenon. The phenomenal world is attributed to Çakti—the goddess Chandi, of whom I have already spoken. Çakti is ever-active, creating the never-ceasing illusions of the visible universe. All that we see around, is produced by Çakti, who acts upon our senses and causes our sorrows and pleasures. But Çiva is inactive—passionless, feelingless, unknown and unknowable, *nirguna* or without qualities. Yet Çakti could not produce the visible, ever-changing forms of this universe without coming in touch with Çiva, the noumenon or the permanent principle. To the shifting phenomena of the world—to our everchanging visible environment, Çiva gives a permanence;—so that when one spring is over, its permanent principle, worked by Çakti, brings on a new spring in the place of the old,—the blooming flower in the place of the faded one. Çiva, then, is the great bridge that connects the lost with the found,—the universe that changes with the universe that is unchanging. The Purāṅas represent the figure of Çiva as lying like a corpse on which dances Çakti or Kāli in destructive ecstacy. One of her